

AVERNUS
BOOK 15 of 15

DEVIL
IN THE WATERS

KT MORRISON

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Avernus

The Devil in the Waters

Book 15

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

Avernus

A Devil in the Waters novel.

61,000 words

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Chapter 1

Lessons from Kerouac and Caesar

Dorchester played their encore, a rousing rendition of *Holding Your Heart*, around eleven o'clock. Josh and Meyer were out of the Scotiabank Arena, downtown Toronto, and ordering drinks at a pub called the Irish Embassy by eleven-twenty. The waitress escorted them to a booth for four looking out onto Yonge Street, Josh telling her they were expecting two more. Meyer ordered them Guinnesses and the waitress asked Meyer what happened to his arm. Meyer lifted his arm, bound in a cast up to his elbow, the curled tips of his puffy fingers sticking out of the end. "You wouldn't believe it—bear attack. Up north, in the bush—thing came out of nowhere." He shook his head and his gaze went faraway, expression grave. The waitress was attractive and Meyer tried some charm.

The waitress said, "You're right—I don't believe you." Meyer had got her smiling.

Josh slid into the far side of the booth across from Meyer, leaving room for the other two who were meeting them here.

Meyer looked offended. "You don't believe me?"

"No, offense," she said. "You don't strike me as the bear-fighting type."

Meyer cocked an eyebrow. "Who said we were fighting?"

That got a laugh out of her, and Meyer relaxed into the bench, smug-smiling.

Josh said, “Does he look like a man who could fight off a bear or does he look like a man who’d go over the handlebars of a motorcycle?”

The waitress clicked her tongue in her cheek, winking at Josh and shooting a finger pistol. “Got it.” Then to Meyer: “Hope you were wearing a helmet.”

“What’s the point?” Josh said. “There’s no brains to protect.”

Meyer showed him a comical look of scrutiny, and the server laughed again. Now she turned her eye on Josh, flirting with him. Then saw his wedding ring.

“I’ll get you guys some drinks,” the woman said and trotted off, weaving through the packed pub. Josh and Meyer regarded each other then laughed, Josh leaning back on the seat-back and looking up at the pub’s high cathedral ceiling. While it was a pub now, it had long ago been one of the burgeoning city’s very first bank buildings. He fell forward again, putting his elbows on the table and shaking his head.

Meyer reached over the table and punched Josh’s shoulder, flopping back and asking him, “You still feel icky?”

“About what?”

“Taking me out—”

“On a date?”

Meyer’s joy turned to scrutiny once again. “You’re such an idiot.”

“I just took you to see your favorite band for your birthday. Two *dudes* out watching a band like *Dorchester*.”

“You *like* Dorchester.”

“Two dudes *together* seeing Dorchester...? It’s suspect.”

“Come on, we’re cousins.” Then he added with theatrical indecency, “*Kissing* cousins,” bouncing eyebrows and blowing Josh a kiss.

Josh reacted with improvised glee, receiving the air kiss, swooning with a hand held over his heart. He admitted, “Ok, it was a pretty great show.”

“Damn right it was. Dorchester’s the best, buddy.”

Josh eyed over Meyer's shoulders, looking out the windows to the nighttime street, checking the passing pedestrians for their guests arriving. Dread seized his viscera again and his mind raced for the nearest location of his Lorazepam stashes. He put his hand over his heart, patting the leather and feeling the hard shape of his prescription bottle poke his chest. Then the fun server was back again, two big Guinnesses on a tray, stooping and offloading them onto their table. She asked them if their company would be here soon, holding the empty tray over her bosom.

"Yeah, any minute," Meyer told her. "They were at the same show tonight." He thumbed over his shoulder in the vague direction of the Scotiabank Arena.

"Aw, you guys saw Dorchester?"

Josh sipped his drink, nodding, wiping the stout's cream from his mustache. "We did." He pointed at Meyer. "I took this guy for his birthday."

Meyer waved to him with his broken arm. "Thanks, cuz."

The server said, "I wish I could have got tickets. I wanted to go so bad."

"You didn't miss anything," Josh said. "They were off tonight."

Meyer eased the server's obvious disappointment, telling her the truth. "He's being nice. They were"—Meyer looked up to the high ceiling, searching for the right word—"*Incredible*. I mean, absolutely amazing. Best show I've seen from *any* band in a few years."

Meyer and the server talked back and forth about Dorchester and Josh watched the sidewalk, waiting to recognize one of the faces bobbing by. When the server left to attend to another table, Meyer sipped his stout, then wiped the foam from his smile. He said, "So what's happening next weekend?"

Josh closed his eyes. Meyer prompted him again. "Are you going to go or not?"

Josh grumbled and rubbed his forehead. "You're going to start asking me this *now*? They'll be here any minute."

“Are you going to go or not?” Meyer acting like it was an easy decision.

“*No*. I mean, yes,” Josh said, irritation overflowing. “Yes, I *am* going to go. Not during the day, not when anyone else is there. At night. For dinner.”

Meyer was satisfied, yet bothered. “Why didn’t you tell me already? I mean, like, was that so hard?”

Josh wagged his hands, surrendering, not wanting to talk about it, retreating from the table. *Yeah, it was pretty fucking hard, Meyer.*

Meyer drank, then sighed. He lowered his gaze and muttered, “Colleen’s like almost a year old.”

“Ah, Jesus,” Josh said, really getting riled, patting his prescription bottle for reassurance. “I fucking *know*, okay?”

Meyer smiled warmly, sympathetically. This wasn’t the first time they’d been heated over this; it was one of the supporting reasons they went away on the motorcycles.

“What about you? Are you going to go?”

“You know I’m going,” Meyer said. “I’m going for Sophie’s sake. During the day. You can come with me if you want. It might be easier that way.”

Josh shook his head no, then caught a familiar face walking right to left behind Meyer, out on the midnight sidewalk. “They’re here,” he told Meyer, a sign for them to drop the personal talk and get into character.

Meyer’s last words were, “Don’t be an asshole,” and it could apply to the situation next weekend, or the one right now.

Steve and his new girlfriend came into the busy pub through the double doors and looked around. Meyer raised a hand and waved until he had their attention. Steve nodded his chin their way, grinning and putting a hand on his girlfriend’s back, walking her through the throng toward the booth. His girlfriend was a black woman, a Nigerian, which he knew through Steve, back when he wasn’t pissed at him.

Meyer whispered, “Shit, what’s her name again?”

Josh covered his mouth and hissed aside, “Mariam,” then Steve and Mariam were at the table. Meyer patted the seat next to him for Mariam to come sit at his side, standing then shaking Steve’s hand. Josh rose languidly.

Steve said to his girlfriend, “This is Josh. He used to work at Swanson with me.”

Josh half-smiled and shook Mariam’s hand. Mariam had a killer smile; long braids, dazzling eyes, and big thighs.

“Pleased to meet you, Josh,” she said, in an English accent. “Steven talks about you well.”

Steve introduced Meyer as a friend and Josh’s cousin, and they all sat down, Steve beside Josh, Mariam across the table next to Meyer.

First topic of order was the Dorchester show; Steve and Mariam had floor seats, while Josh got him and Meyer lower bowl seats, in the 120s; he was still recovering financially from the road trip while unemployed. Soon the waitress was there, taking their order—four more Guinnesses—and she was back fast, the former flirting now a thing of the past. Something he was sure she did with every table.

When Mariam and Meyer broke off into their own discussion, Josh shrank from the table. Steve listened in to Meyer and Mariam for awhile but soon retreated and offloaded his attention to Josh. Josh and the divide between them. Steve grew sullen for a moment. Took a few sips of his beer.

Then he brightened and said to Josh, “Hey, man, we really miss you around the shop.”

“That’s good, I guess,” Josh said.

“Sure it is. Harjeet talks about you. When you know what’s what, I think a lot of us would want to see you come back. Big time.”

“I don’t know about that. I don’t know about anything anymore.”

“You been looking?”

“For work? No, not yet. . . . I don’t know what I’m doing.”

There was a long, awkward silence on one side of the table. Meyer and Mariam were yucking it up on the other side, laughing about something. Mariam looked like a real hoot. But she'd renamed Steve "Steven" and that was probably a bad sign. That's how it started.

Steve blubbered his lips, looking around, and Josh knew it was coming. He'd already forgiven Steve via text. And the whole thing seemed petty in retrospect.

Steve leaned closer, not looking at Josh, saying aside, "I really am sorry, eh?"

"I know. I told you it's okay."

"I know. I know you told me. I appreciate that. I mean, *listen* . . . I'd done it before I even thought about it. You know? As soon as I sent it, I sat back and was, like, oh, maybe that wasn't a good idea."

"I get it," Josh said and sipped his Guinness.

Steve waited for Josh to look over, then said, "I was an idiot. I shouldn't have done that. I'm sorry. I mean it."

"I know," Josh said, slimming his lips and nodding like a madman, not wanting to talk about it, not wanting it in his mind anymore.

Mariam had their attention now, saying, "That must have been an amazing trip," Meyer nodding alongside her, enjoying her company. Meyer agreed it was.

Josh said yeah, it was a great trip, then in the silence after, felt awkward enough to elaborate. "It was good for both of us," looking to Meyer.

Steve said to Mariam, "They have an apartment together." Her eyes flicked to Josh's wedding ring, and he instinctively put his hand over it.

"Yeah," Meyer said, "but we just cleared our schedules and hit the road on some dirt bikes for two weeks. Trails and the wild, all the way down to South America."

Steve said, "British Columbia to Argentina."

Meyer nodded more and Josh's heart felt like a lead weight in his chest. He touched the prescription bottle like an addict. He muttered, "Yup, two weeks."

Or at least it was supposed to be two weeks.

He wanted to blurt that out. Say to Mariam, well, it was *supposed* to be two weeks but your stupid boyfriend sent me that goddamn picture. The one Meyer now called the \$14,000 photograph.

Bad luck. Bad juju. A transcontinental curse sent via local and international networks; a jinx data packet opened on a phone five-thousand miles from home. It had ruined the trip. Meyer blamed his broken arm on Steve's ill-conceived forwarding of that photo he'd seen in the news. Not the news; the Lifestyle section. *Ooh-la-fucking-la*.

"Hey, you excuse me for a sec?" Josh nudged Steve to let him out of the booth and told everyone he was going to the can. He had a Lorazepam shaken into his palm by the time he shouldered open the men's room door, situating it under his tongue where it would dissolve in about five minutes. Twenty minutes from now he'd feel it kick in. A Lorazepam, two Guinnesses, maybe three, maybe four, plus whiskey shots for the table, and maybe then he could smile for Steve and Mariam. *Mariam*. Mariam from Nigeria. Maybe two years ago in another more peaceable universe, a lawyer he knew had helped Mariam immigrate to Canada.

He emptied his bladder into the urinal, jabbed the old style flusher with his leather elbow and went to the mirror. His fucking reflection was awful. Dark circles under watery eyes, long hair, beard. Gaunt. A Bohemian benzo addict and drunk with a broken heart.

Goddamn that fucking beautiful picture of Kimmy.

Chapter 2

Panic Attacks in Rome

That fucking picture.

The picture that swooped in from out of nowhere. No warning he would receive it, and no warning that the photo's content could even be a possibility.

He could see it in his mind's eye as he stared up at the ceiling in the hotel room he'd booked for Meyer's birthday. He could see it with his eyes closed, too. So he lay sleepless and staring, hands behind his head, gawping at ghosts floating above him on the eggshell white ceiling-cum-movie-screen while Meyer snored hard enough to swallow his own tongue. The way things were. The way they were now. All that could have been. All that could be.

Kimmy Chang. Her name right in the newspaper. Print edition. Saturday special. Not Kimmy Waters. Kimmy *Chang*. Six-foot tall supermodel Kimmy Chang in a blue satin dress, big V cutout on the chest, straps over lean shoulders, her little titties cupped in the shimmering bustier, the photographer's light casting shadows in the cups and edges of her collarbones and long, swanlike neck. Hair pulled back. Her glistening skin. Pampered. She looked pampered.

And that fucking million-dollar smile?

He brought his knees together in a clamp and crunched his stomach against the existential pain coursing through his veins, his heart just a pulsatile pain machine, sending hurt-poison into every part of his being.

Why did it fucking hurt so much?

Because she was yours, dipshit. She was yours and now she's not.

How bad would this night be without the benzo and the beer and the Irish good-stuff? Insufferable. Insupportable.

Five miles outside Cabo, ten o'clock at night, exhausted after an amazing day blatting across the baked landscape and he's getting into his tent, ready for forty winks, but wanted to check his messages. What a mistake. A message from Steve.

The fucking man Kimmy was with in the picture. How? Like really, fucking *how*?

Thank god for Lorazepam. Thank god for tonight's drinks. The hurt and dread were rarer now. And thank god for Meyer. Thank god for the times with Sophie when she'd stay with him and Meyer.

Sophie insinuated there were nights where Aunt Kimmy cried and closed herself in Hyun's bedroom. It was clear Sophie didn't want to spill the beans, that someone, probably Kimmy, had told Sophie not to talk about it. Kimmy was gone from Stone. She hadn't lied about that.

Josh growled from sleepless frustration and whipped down the covers, laying bare-chested in the nighttime city light. His mind raced, but at least the fight or flight only simmered under the wonderful wooly weight of the benzo. His hand searched to the side table, looking for the familiar shape of his phone, Meyer sputtering away in the next bed over. Swiped open, right to screenshots he'd snapped of the texts with Kimmy from back in the day. Wonderful little snippets of things she'd texted him in her departure's aftermath. Statements he'd often ponder.

The time he'd first heard Sophie drop a vague remark about her Aunt Kimmy crying, he'd texted Kimmy, and, not wanting to rat out his adorable

little niece as a tattletale, he'd offered up the blanket reminder that no matter what had happened between them, he would always be there for her. He'd told her that if she ever needed help he would do whatever he could to make things right for her.

She'd texted him back.

Kimmy: Stay away, Josh. I hope it won't be forever. But it should be for a while. I want to earn you back.

Yeah, right. She wanted to earn him back. Uh-huh.

One time she'd texted she was irredeemable. Another time she texted she wanted redemption.

And poor Sophie. Sophie told not to talk about Kimmy's mental state, Kimmy with no job, all alone, then moved in with Hyun—just like he knew she would. Sophie saying cryptic things around her other-week men because she wanted reassurance from her dad and from her Uncle Josh that everything would be okay with her Aunt Kimmy. Then total radio silence from Kimmy. Sophie said Kimmy wasn't living with Hyun anymore, she'd got an apartment downtown. He'd texted her. In those weeks, Kimmy had been a mess. Emotional and sensitive. Their text-based convos were sometimes heated. He could tell she was afraid. He encouraged her to get professional help, but he didn't think she ever went.

Josh: I don't want to find any happiness in your suffering.

Kimmy: I deserve it.

Then more radio silence. Longer. But who gave a fuck? By then he was in Rome and crushing it. At least for a while he was. Then came the times where it was difficult to swallow. He'd passed it off as an infection. Then he was home, and—hell, yeah—he dated.

"Fuck," he sighed, wishing he could just sleep. Instead, he was huddled under the cover to block out the light of his phone so he wouldn't disrupt

Meyer's snoring.

Yeah, that was what set it off. It wasn't an infection, it was his whole body tightening with a fight-or-flight response. Smack dab in the middle of the day he'd have these attacks where his body was convinced fucking Michael Myers was tracking him down with a machete. He'd be at work shitting-his-pants afraid, hands shaking, guts twisting, but with no reason. The reason took some time to figure out. It wasn't an irrational fear of fictional Michael Myers and his machete, it was Devlin Stone with his erect horse-cock.

But that was *still* irrational.

And in time, he also came to understand that it wasn't even Devlin anymore. It was Kimmy. It was lies and it was betrayal.

It was too much.

When Kimmy was giving birth to Colleen at St. Joseph's in the city, he was seven-thousand clicks away curled up on a Rome hotel room floor, heart racing out of control. He was far from home, all alone, scared out of his mind by imaginary threats. He'd even gone mute. Gabrielle knocked on his door in the morning, tried to help him present himself, but he couldn't even talk. She said, "You're a dad, Josh." Gabrielle had sent flowers to Kimmy in his name.

"Turn off your phone, dickhead."

The snoring had stopped and Meyer saw he was *pinning*, as Meyer called it. It wasn't pinning. Who knew what you would call it. For fun one time, he'd plotted revenge. Other times, he swore he would move on, that living a grand life would be the best revenge. But that kind of serenity took months of sifting to find at last. "I was checking the weather," he said, slipping the cover down, turning his phone off and returning it to the side table.

"Stop picking at scabs."

He said, "Stop fucking snoring. How about that?"

"I wasn't snoring." Meyer rolled over to face the wall.

Josh chuckled and tried closing his eyes again, seeking sleep.

Yeah, he would go next week. Hard as it was, he would go. If only just to show Kimmy he didn't care about her anymore. Nothing she could do now would ever hurt him. He would find enormous glory in seeing her rendered powerless over him. The thought of her trying and failing raced his heart and even brought a little smile that tickled his lips with bristly beard hair. He rubbed a hand down his facial pelt. It should go. The beard should be shorn before his visit. Although Kimmy *should* see him as a stranger compared to who she knew, a man who'd moved on—and he was. *Sometimes. Other times, like when you were having a blast in Mexico and some fucking guy you used to work with shoots you a picture of your wife at some gala on another man's arm, maybe not so much.*

And what about the showstopper, Joshy, my boy? What about the one thing in that picture—despite how hot your wife looked in it—that stole all your attention?

He rolled his head on the crisp hotel pillow, some despondency leaking through the Lorazepam's armor. His eyes opened and roamed the room's gray stillness.

Say it.

He mouthed the words: "She wasn't wearing her wedding ring."

* * *

Meyer said, "If I showed up at work with the guys I work with, and I got a hundred dollar haircut...? Jesus fucking Christ, Josh, the nicknames...? The abuse I would receive? I'd rather have a hundred dollars and my dignity. You go ahead, though. You were always the pretty one."

Josh elbowed him surreptitiously, two men almost thirty acting like a couple of teenagers in this upscale city salon with its marble floors and haughty reception and ten-foot ceilings.

“I told you, I just want to get cleaned up.”

“You can get cleaned up at a barber in Ajax. Barber’s like fifteen-twenty bucks.”

“I’m not making you get one.”

“Buy me one. For my birthday.”

“I spent almost a thousand dollars on your birthday already.”

Meyer nodded his chin, “Hey, here’s your guy,” both of them regarding now a tall dude, a stylish Filipino wearing an undershirt and a skirt, combat boots, hoop earrings and an Errol Flynn mustache. The guy said, “Where’s Josh?”

“That’s me.”

Rory was his hairdresser, a funny and charming guy, and real earnest about Josh’s look.

“This jacket is amazing,” Rory said, running fingers on the wicked vintage motocross jacket he’d bought at a flea market in Pickering. Beaten to shit for decades and still dusty from Mexico, he’d hung it up behind his salon chair, not wanting to leave it in the lobby, even with Meyer watching. Then Rory was running fingers through Josh’s hair, checking out the length, wondering what he would do with such a mess.

Josh said, “I want it all gone. I’m going back to work soon.”

“What do you do?”

“Ah, just an executive.”

“You look like a writer. Or an artist, maybe.”

“Nah. Spreadsheets and projections,” he said, then regretted it, preferring to live in Rory’s imagination of who he was. That sounded like a much better Josh. “I want a good presentable haircut for work. Take off the beard, too.”

Rory looked perplexed, running his nails through Josh’s beard, watching in the mirror, then stooping to get eyes on the actual thing. “You have a great suntan.”

“Thanks.”

“Were you on vacation? Where did you go?”

“Kind of a vacation. A guy’s trip. We rode enduro bikes down to Cabo San Lucas.”

Rory had stood up to lift a sprayer but wheeled when he heard about the bikes. “Really? Amazing. How many?”

“Guys?” Josh shrugged. “A dozen of us.”

Rory’s eyebrows kept creeping up, wowed by this tale of transcontinental two-wheel glory. Then he was close again, standing behind him, touching his hair and his beard. “You look good like this. It suits you.”

“It does?”

Hands on beard again. “If I take the beard I’m afraid your cheeks will be white.”

“Ew. That’s not good.”

Rory began spraying Josh’s hair, getting it wet, combing it, studying it.

Josh played with his wedding ring, looking at his reflection, seeing his face again with his hair combed back. The beard looked good. And, frankly, the weight loss looked good, too.

A writer. Or an artist, maybe.

He said, “I want to look good. I’m meeting someone I haven’t seen in a long time.”

Rory loved the story’s presentation. Engaged right away. “Oh, who is it?”

A long beat. “My wife.”

Rory looked puzzled.

“Yeah. Crazy, huh? I haven’t seen her in a year.”

Rory clipped a little, lost in thought, trying to figure the best way to ask a whole series of questions. “Why are you seeing her now?”

“She’s moved on, Rory. Moved on. Bought herself a house.”

Rory stopped clipping and put a hand on his hip. “A house. Bought *herself* a house?”

“I suppose it’s our money, but, yeah, we haven’t really figured that out yet. We have a kid.”

Rory went back to clipping. “This is getting complicated.”

“Tell me about it.”

More clipping, Rory formulating the best approach to get more info from him and maintain the natural charm he had.

“You’re right about that, though,” Josh said, seeing his face emerging, getting tidied but keeping the roguish raconteur with a broken heart who’d rode a motorcycle from Vancouver to Mexico and watched the sun set in Baja drinking a Corona, sun on his brow and cheeks.

“Right about what?”

“I look good like this. It suits me.”

Chapter 3

Chargoggagoggmanchauggagoggchaubun- agungamaugg

The benzo sank in and removed his dread on the Unionville Main Street. The Qashqai's nav screen showed a right turn was imminent.

Fucking *Unionville*. That's where she bought a house. Quaint, historical; ancient trees with huge fluttering canopies. White picket fences, brick Victorian houses, lawns, porches. Like a fuckin' Lifetime movie set. Unreal. He drove north on Main from 7, leaves fluttering, flashing their color on a sunny day. So many times he and Kimmy had come here to eat lunch, back when they were young, happy, and in love. It was their *Gilmore Girls* era, when they binged the show and realized *Stars Hollow* wasn't really in Connecticut, it was a short drive from Ajax to the historic village in Unionville.

He turned right after passing the United Church with its tall gray spire, heading down a side street off Main, a quiet cul-de-sac shy of the village. And then, there it was. Kimmy's house. A farm-style with wraparound porch; a cute Victorian with bay windows and dove-colored siding, cedar shakes up on the gables, the whole plot buffered with maple canopy, gardens, and fat, billowy shrubs.

Two million dollars, easy. *More*. Ten grand a year in property taxes. One of the nicest main streets in all of the Toronto region. Maybe all of Ontario. The best of schools, the best of restaurants and activities and cafes and little

shops. Beautiful. Heart-sinkingly beautiful. *If she hadn't fucked Devlin, if she hadn't bought those ridiculous clothes and the shoes and that suit for him, if, if, if...* This house was better than anything they'd dreamed of.

But then, there was the man in the photo.

A young guy in black pants and white shirt was closing up a Sprinter van in the driveway, the catering company packed up and ready to go. Josh left room for the truck to head out before he drove into the driveway and took the spot. He wondered if Meyer had enjoyed the food. Since he'd set his phone to Airplane, he wouldn't know. He didn't want Meyer in his head before he began the hardest moment of his life. Meyer could say the wrong thing and he might take off out of here so fast he'd leave black streaks on Kimmy's driveway.

It had been too long. Way too long. There was a baby involved and that baby just might be his.

With that, he grabbed the little gift bag from his passenger seat and stretched a leg out of the car. Rose then to stand, but hated the colorful gift bag. He removed the gifts and tucked them inside his motocross jacket instead.

The front door seemed a mile away.

* * *

Thank god it was Sophie who answered the door.

"Hey, kid. Long time no see." He'd seen her three days ago when she'd stayed with him and Meyer.

"Uncle Josh!" Sophie grabbed his hand. "Come and see my room." He wasn't even in the foyer yet and Sophie was amped. He felt a sick jealousy that it was Kimmy who'd provided her with a living space so exciting she acted this way. Usually the little girl was a little more reserved.

“Did you eat all the desserts or something?” he joked, stumbling into the foyer. A vacuum ran somewhere deeper inside the house.

And what a house.

“Wow,” he whispered, mouth tucked in a glum line. The place was sleek despite the historical aspect; minimalist, maple flooring, ochre-painted walls, modern furniture.

“You have to take your boots off, Uncle Josh,” Sophie instructed him, showing him by pointing to an assembly of fine footwear along the wall. Sophie was all dressed up for today’s event. Someone had done her hair up in a pretty style, cute little pigtails. She wore a black dress and white socks and black slippers.

As he leaned on the wall and toed off his boots, Sophie poked him in his fat stomach. “What’s in there?”

Not a fat stomach, it was the gifts he’d brought. He told her, “Gifts, Sophie.”

“For me?”

“I get you gifts all the time,” he said and booped her nose.

“Okay,” she said, grabbing his hand again now that his boots were off. “Come and see my room.”

A far too familiar voice from a side room adjoining the hall beyond the foyer: “Give him a minute, Sophie.” Kimmy Chang, calm and assured; instructive.

Josh looked to the left and saw her. The sight was like a jab in the stomach.

Kimmy stood in the center of a home office; tall and impossibly thin; glamorous yet subdued. Fucking beautiful face with those dark, sly eyes, her hair pulled back. She dressed all in black; black skirt, black turtleneck, long thin legs clad in black leggings.

They stared but didn’t speak. Neither showed an expression.

Kimmy said to Sophie, “Let him sit. After we’re done you can take him to show him your room.”

“Okay,” Sophie said, slump-shouldered and dispirited. But there was another little girl her Uncle Josh was here to see today.

“I can’t wait to see your room,” Josh said, placing a hand on Sophie’s tiny shoulder.

God, she was such a good little girl; all Meyer’s, a human his stupid-ass cousin could live his life for.

Sophie showed him a goofy grin and then she was trotting off deeper into the house, headed toward wherever the vacuum was working.

Then there were two.

And he wished the vacuum would shut the fuck up.

Kimmy crossed her arms over her slender chest, and for the first time ever he felt robbed of seeing her carrying a child; seeing her long frame host another being planted deep inside her, her belly expanding into a taut melon ready to crack its rind as it ripened. When she’d lost their baby she’d had the smallest paunch. He longed for those days of harrowing failure when everything was so simple because there were only the two of them. Maybe a deep-planted seed had better opportunity to grow.

He stopped the dread. His hands sweated, turned to fists, and his teeth squeaked as he clenched his jaw against betrayal and hurt and the sharpest knife anyone had sunk into him.

Kimmy raised her chin, eyeing him. “I’m so happy you came, Josh.”

He nodded, looked around, not knowing what to do with himself. It would be so fucking easy to toss his gifts for this baby that was supposed to be his onto the desk with the computer, then skedaddle the fuck out of here, get the fuck out of hoity-toity Unionville, blast home and get into sweatpants, play some Xbox with Meyer and order a pizza. Just check the fuck out.

He sighed like a man enduring a hardship. “How was your housewarming?”

Kimmy nodded, appraising her afternoon. “It was good. Thank you.”

“All your renos done on time?”

Kimmy looked around the room, shrugging. “It went well, Josh. And, yes, we got everything done on time.”

“Sophie tells me what’s going on.”

Kimmy smiled and the sight hurt his heart. He didn’t show it. “I know she does.”

But now he stood silent, not wanting to compliment her on her new house, not wanting to give her any satisfaction for moving on so well without him.

Kimmy’s smile faded, and she assumed a more serious expression. “This is a big day.”

“I know,” he said. It had nothing to do with the house, it had everything to do with a tiny human who Kimmy hosted in her belly for a little over nine months. His hand slipped inside his leather jacket and pulled out his present. He waggled it for Kimmy.

The sight of the teddy bear made her smile and her eyes went glossy. She approached him and he fought the urge to run out of the house. She took the teddy bear and looked it over.

“Alpaca,” he said. “It’s made from alpaca fur. He’s wearing a, a *charro* outfit. A horse rider. I bought it in Baja.”

Kimmy held it to her chest, smiling, eyes looking sad and watery, tucking down her chin to clamp the big teddy bear to her. “It’s perfect, Josh,” she said.

He slipped a hand into his jacket and produced another item: a handmade maraca.

Kimmy took it, the beans shaking inside the shell and producing the familiar sound. Kimmy shook her head, trying to clear the sadness from her

eyes. “Great, Josh,” she said, overwhelmed, passing them back to him. “You can give them to her yourself.”

And suddenly it got very hard to breathe. His knees jellied and the room wobbled. Kimmy passed the gifts back to him and he tucked them back into his jacket. Maybe he wouldn’t even take the jacket off. Maybe he would just do this part and then leave. The knot bloomed in his throat again and he couldn’t swallow. No words came, and all he could do was nod.

Kimmy frowned and held his upper arm. “Are you okay?”

His body seized and he was hyper-aware of her hand on him. “Fine,” he said, tight and hard, but it was better than muteness.

“I’m really glad you came,” she said and let her hand fall from his arm.

Josh pinched the bridge of his nose, muttering, “It’s like a dream. I feel... I feel like I’m dreaming.”

“Come to the kitchen. We can get you some water.”

He shook his head and took a deep breath, hating the dread and anxiety robbing him of masculinity in this powerful moment.

“Come with me,” Kimmy said, walking past him, smiling kindly, still hugging herself, padding the hardwood hallway of her home in slipper-feet. The vacuum was off now, and when they entered the kitchen Hyun was there with Sophie. Sophie was sliding the vacuum into a broom closet, Hyun wore yellow rubber gloves, wiping down the counters. Her eyes dashed up to meet his.

And he recognized the look on Hyun’s face. It was the expression he’d seen when he looked at his mirror reflection in a hotel room in Rome, wondering what the fuck was wrong with him. Dread, fear, worry. He was no threat to Hyun. Unless...

He and Meyer had joked together late at night playing video games having a few brewskis, saying how Kimmy and Hyun made a good couple. They would keep a good house, they’d joke. Meyer would never say it outright but would always insinuate that Hyun had a crush on Kimmy. They

would laugh at their own predicament, saying those two women of ours running an efficient household and here's you and me—and then they would snicker about the state of their apartment with the beer cans and the pizza boxes and the game controllers and remote controls. But now it was really happening.

And here was the deadbeat dad, come to be the hero; Hyun was the one who stayed with Colleen during the day when Kimmy went to work. In Hyun's eyes the once valorous young man married to Kimmy had been reduced to a bum. And maybe a threat.

He nodded in recognition, wanly smiling. "Hi, Hyun."

Hyun smiled like all was well. "Hi, Josh. So glad you made it."

Kimmy asked Hyun to get him a glass of water, but Sophie interjected. "I'll get it!" All three watched Sophie get a glass from a cupboard using a chair, then going to the fridge's water dispenser to fill it. She brought it around the island, saying, "Can I make Uncle Josh my ice cream for dessert?"

Kimmy smiled, watching Sophie, her face downturned, the long tendon in her neck standing out against her tawny skin. He knew what it felt like to kiss her there.

Hyun said, "She has an ice-cream maker."

Josh accepted the glass Sophie handed him, surprised now to feel the dread had eased. He smiled too, saying, "She's told me all about the ice-cream maker."

Kimmy held Sophie against her side, rubbing her shoulder. "I've also told her a hundred times today she can make you ice cream."

Sophie said, "Maple and coffee and walnut. All your favorites."

Josh sipped the water, then drank half the glass all at once. He put the glass on the island counter. "I can't wait, Sophie."

Kimmy said, "Do you want something else? Something stronger? I think the caterer left some beer." She looked to Hyun and Hyun made like

she was ready to go check if Josh wished it.

“No,” he said, shaking his head, feeling guilty his wife thought he might want alcohol to get him through this monumental moment. “No, I don’t need beer.” *Just a Lorazepam or two.*

Kimmy looked around, no one else saying anything. “Okay. Come sit in the other room with me, Josh.”

She left Sophie, turned and headed out the other side of the kitchen, to a large family room at the back of the house that looked out over the small backyard. The lawn was mowed, the gardens clipped and trimmed; someone had bundled up the more vulnerable trees with burlap to protect them over the winter.

Kimmy gestured to a spotless ivory leather couch, and he sat down in the corner. Kimmy sat catty-corner in a matching padded chair.

Josh’s heart pounded a hundred miles an hour. He rubbed his sweaty palms on his knees. “I should have come before.”

“It’s okay, Josh,” Kimmy said. “You should have. But you’re here now.”

He took a few breaths to steady himself, proud of the strength he conjured to endure this moment.

Kimmy said, “Do you think you’re ready?”

He nodded.

Kimmy reached over and held his hand. Her touch was warm and gentle and he felt his eyes swell with emotion. He looked down to regard their combined hands and noticed for the first time since he arrived that she wore her wedding ring. He thumbed it. Held her hand a little tighter.

Kimmy called out to Hyun over her shoulder. “Hyun, can you bring in Colleen?”

Chapter 4

Colleen

While they waited for Hyun to return with the baby, Kimmy got up and crossed the room. For a moment he feared she would leave through the room's other doorway, but instead she fetched a box of tissue and returned to place it on the table at his side.

A door squeaked, a knock sounding down the hall, and an enormous jangle of fear and dread had him shaking in the couch. Those sounds were Hyun collecting the baby to bring to him. *His* baby, Kimmy claimed. She'd sent him pictures and he'd looked at them and he'd put them in a folder on his phone and never looked at them again. It had been this way for months. Now the time was here. The urge to flee never came. It was a blessing.

Out in the hall a shadow passed across the wall and he drew in a deep, preparatory breath.

This was really happening.

And then Hyun filled the doorway, passing into the family room at the back of Kimmy's new house, holding a blanket-bundled baby at her chest. He wiped his eyes with his knuckles and waited.

Hyun passed the baby into Kimmy's arms and Kimmy—god damn it, motherly Kimmy, *holding a baby*—held Colleen for a moment, waiting for Hyun to leave. “Thank you, Hyun,” she said aside, and Hyun nodded as she left, though Kimmy didn't see it.

With the baby in her arms, Kimmy brushed the curled fold of a blanket away from the baby's sleeping face so Josh could see her. Kimmy smiled and he could see the pride she held for this thing she'd created. *Maybe with another man.*

"She's Colleen," Kimmy said. "Colleen Waters."

Josh had to pull away; emotion soared through him like a katabatic wind cutting through a canyon. When he looked away, all he saw was the pale puff of a readied tissue; he snatched it from the box and pushed it into his eyes.

Kimmy said, "I want you to hold her."

He moaned in his throat, cleared his eyes, returned his gaze to Kimmy and Colleen. Kimmy rose and stepped closer, stooping to present him with his daughter. He accepted the bundle, tears blinking in his eyelashes, his back heaving with hidden sobs. He gritted his teeth and looked at the baby through wet-warbled eyes.

She was just a tiny innocent thing; eyes closed to the world, unknowing of her own existence and place in the world. Her slim lips were pursed into a pinky little turtle's beak. His hands trembled with her feathery weight in them.

Then he jumped when Kimmy touched him. She stroked his hair above his ear, then ran the backs of her fingers down his bearded cheek. "I'm going to leave you alone for a few minutes with your daughter. Is that okay?"

It was hard to speak, but he managed to squeak out a thank-you.

Kimmy turned and left the room, pausing at the door for one more moment. He turned his attention to Colleen. Colleen Waters.

* * *

The last image of Josh as she left the room would stay with her forever. Josh with Colleen on his lap, the sun on the garden behind them, Josh's tender pose. It would be a beautiful image to memorialize. But she had to leave him, had to give him time with Colleen.

A few steps down the hall, she paused, frozen in place, suspended in a neutral zone where two poles tugged in opposites, wanting to return and witness Colleen reveal truths to her father, knowing she would let him have his moment without her adulteration, and that Hyun would convey her to the kitchen.

She crossed hands over her chest, leaning her back on the wall, listening for any sounds from Josh. She hugged herself tighter, rolling away, hurting nipples crushed under her forearms.

Before the kitchen, she straightened her clothing, checked her reflection in the hallway mirror, then padded into the kitchen. Hyun stood at the fridge with the door open, eyes blank, unmoving.

"Where's Sophie?"

Hyun blinked and stepped back to close the fridge door. "She's reading."

Both of them looked around the kitchen, the moment bloated and uncertain. Kimmy went to Hyun and Hyun leaned into her. She folded arms around Hyun, and Hyun rested her cheek on Kimmy's collar. She held her in silence, soon swaying with her in comfort.

Hyun said, "He looks good."

Kimmy nodded and rested her chin point on the crown of Hyun's head.

* * *

Fragrant, blissful, and blameless.

The baby woke in slow increments, sensing a disturbance in its familiar world. Eyes twitching, nose wrinkling, the mouth opened and closed.

Colleen was a perfect thing. Red-faced and curious, comically perturbed, hands moving under the blanket. He parted the folds and she raised little moving fists.

And then the eyes. God, the *eyes*!

Colleen woke and regarded him with kind eyes the color of dark honey.

“Oh my god. Oh my god,” he whispered. *His mother’s eyes.*

A wild vertigo swooned his brummy mind, breath and heartbeat stolen from him.

Then it returned all at once, the vertigo gone and replaced with sudden, *infinite* resolution. His heart pounded the strangest joy he’d ever felt in his entire existence. His temples sounded off like booming taiko drums; he chugged sweet air and held Colleen close to him, her skin on his cheek.

But she gripped a tiny fistful of beard hair.

“Ow, ow,” he said, chuckling, holding her tighter.

God, she smelled like blueberries.

Her lips smacked near his ear. She mewled. He kissed her brow, held her back to regard her again. And she regarded him. Those familiar eyes looked deep into him, and he opened the door wider, wanting her to step inside.

“I wasn’t ready,” he pleaded, tears on his cheeks. “I’m so sorry, Colleen. I’m so, *so* sorry.”

Colleen’s face scrunched up, she blinked and looked like she would cry but changed her mind. She squirmed and grunted, little hand out and searching. He gave her his finger and she squeezed.

* * *

Fifteen minutes ticked by at the same mucky pace the last seven months passed. Every second batted on dread and drama.

Fifteen minutes would be enough time. Enough time for Josh to look at Colleen and make his decision. He could run. But maybe he would stay.

The sun was setting off in the west, the sunny sky high above the trees shading a deep starry blue, the horizon washed in the color of lemon-cream. She'd changed clothes. She'd got comfortable. Now in her bedroom she moisturized her wrists and hands and stared at the sky.

Satin robe, satin pants, buttoned shirt.

Fifteen minutes passed, and she closed the blinds and headed downstairs.

* * *

Colleen craned her head to the side to see her mother coming in.

"She's here," Josh whispered. He thumbed Colleen's soft cheek, and brushed her wispy fair-haired lock away from her brow. *Fair-haired!*

Kimmy had changed. Standing now like she was ready for bed; satin pajamas, an expensive robe that swept the floor. Her makeup had been cleaned away, her hair untied and hanging around her shoulders. The expression on her face showed a sickly anxiousness, and she shuffled around to the leather chair again. She sat down without making a sound, her eyes falling on him, roaming the sight of him holding their daughter. She rested a cheek in her hand, looking tired and drawn.

He returned his attention to Colleen, bouncing her in his lap, still humming away with syrupy relief, a rumble in his chest. Colleen's weight in his hands tingled his fingertips like magic.

Kimmy said, "I have the paperwork."

He didn't think she'd meant for that to sting, but it did. His assumption was the paperwork she referred to would be a paternity test, and it was a reminder he'd been away from his own daughter her whole life and it was his own decision.

A decision forged in heartbreak and fear.

He shook his head and stroked a thumb on Colleen's delicate brow. She became disgruntled, scrunching her face up and showing her toothless grimace.

"I don't need the paperwork," he said.

Kimmy was silent, and Colleen mewled. Kimmy leaned to the side and snatched a tissue. He looked up and saw she was crying. She covered her eyes with a hand balling the tissue. "I have proof. That's all. I have proof."

"I don't want to see it," he muttered, eyes turning down to his daughter. Maybe if Kimmy had showed him proof he'd have been here sooner. "You could have told me."

Colleen squealed and bawled now, hands reaching up in the air, her red face reddening. She had a delicate cry.

"I think she wants her mother," he said, offering the swaddled bundle back to Kimmy.

"She's probably just hungry," Kimmy said, slipping off the seat and taking Colleen in her arms. Josh took the chance to get a fresh tissue for his own eyes. Kimmy returned to the deep cushioned chair and reclined this time. She soothed Colleen, bouncing her gently in her arms, shushing her with gentle whispering. She unbuttoned her satin pajama shirt. "You don't mind?"

He shook his head no, hypnotized by the sight of his wife this way. Nothing like how she was when they parted. Yet she was the same woman.

Kimmy opened the shirt, Colleen complaining. Her bared breast was plumped, tumid, the nipple changed, swollen in size for its new function. He should have looked away, but he didn't. Colleen searched and found the nipple, and the crying ceased as she fed from Kimmy. The only sound now was the wet suction of his beautiful daughter nursing from her beautiful mother.

Kimmy whimpered with the discomfort from Colleen's need, her expression tightening. Yet her eyes stayed on Colleen, watching her with love. After a long mesmerizing moment, Kimmy turned her face to his. "I could have told you. But I . . . I would have robbed you of this moment. I wanted you to see it with your own eyes, unswayed by *anything* I might tell you beforehand."

Shame burned his cheeks and he knew he'd gone as red as Colleen's little face. "I should have come already."

"No, Josh. Whatever time you needed, you took it. I don't blame you. I wished you were here, but you weren't. You're here now."

He nodded, wiping his eyes with the tissue. "She has my . . . Has my mother's eyes."

Kimmy smiled, regarding Colleen, still suckling. "She has beautiful eyes."

He reclined in the couch, that golden moment of time he'd just spent with a life he created beginning to lose its glow, the emotion fading; fading or pushed away by the horrors of the past; all the bad that brought them to this solitary quasar of possibilities, a man with a wife and daughter, a wife with another man, a home. A whole life that had moved on without him in it. He stared at the ceiling listening to the bizarre sound of his daughter suckling from her mother, feeling a thousand miles distant from the point in time he most identified with: the time his wife betrayed him and lied to him and cheated on him, tormented him and sought his destruction. His heart increased with rapid weight and he felt himself wanting to sink through the couch, into the basement if Kimmy's house had one, down into the realms below where torment such as this was normal.

Kimmy said, "Are you ready for some dinner?"

He thought she'd said it to Colleen, but he tilted his head downward, seeing his daughter satiated, eyes closed again, peaceful, Kimmy's shirt closed over her bare breast but not buttoned.

He nodded. “Yeah. Yeah, I am. We should . . . We should talk.”

Chapter 5

Twelve Crops of Fruit

Josh asked her if it was them dining alone, and she told him it was.
“We need to talk,” she said.

Josh agreed with her. “Right. We do.”

Hyun had set the table for them. A place setting for two, Kimmy at the head of the table, Josh’s place setting at her side. While it was early, the brighter outside light had faded from the windows, leaving the dull reflective squares in the color of unwashed denim.

She had never been more nervous in her life. Josh sat at her new dining room table, a long washed-oak handcrafted table she and Hyun had bought in Guelph and had delivered.

Josh.

A man it had taken a whole year to prepare for. So much had to be in place before she would ever be able to receive Josh as a guest in her home. Really, in *their* home. She had used their money as a down payment and Josh had never even asked her why the money was gone.

The beard was an amazing contribution. Josh hid behind it (and she had no idea his beard would be so thick), but also projected a masculinity that surprised her.

Their dinner was a buffet style, the servings presented under covers on the table’s center, congregated to one end. She removed the closest lid

covering the pottery casserole dish, saying, “I made dumplings.”

She watched Josh’s thickly bearded face, looking for a smile. He showed a reluctant one, a mildly pleasant curve restrained by pain.

“You love them,” she reminded him.

“I know I do,” he said. “That’s why I’m smiling. I do love them. I always did.”

She closed the lid and dipped her chin. “Hyun made them. I was . . . I was in Cambodia for the whole last week.”

Josh looked away. She saw the strange injury her husband suffered from her proxy-made dumplings and reached out to hold his wrist, showed him her most earnest expression describing the demanding week she’d just endured. “I wanted to make them for you, but I couldn’t. It’s my recipe. My mother’s.”

“I don’t mind that, it’s . . . Dumplings are the last thing we need to talk about, don’t you think?”

Her hand slipped from his wrist and she sat back in the chair. “We have a lot to talk about. There’s Colleen...”

Josh’s mouth tweaked to one side, the sign of a smile. She leaned forward again and touched his arm, rested her hand on it. She smiled as well, so deeply relieved that Josh accepted his daughter. Saw that she was his daughter with no extracurricular convincing.

Josh turned her way. “It’s a beautiful name, Kimmy. You must be happy about it.”

While not intended as an insult, there was a twist in what he’d said, one revealed in his tone; an unthreatening snideness. “Yes,” she admitted. “Eileen . . . Eileen had a baby boy. Andrew. He’s gorgeous.” Colleen was their mother’s name. If Eileen had given birth to a girl, Eileen would have been the one who named their daughter after their mother. Kimmy had got there first.

Josh lifted the lid on the casserole dish and loaded two dumplings onto his plate. “You’re good at getting what you want.”

“Just fate, Josh,” she said, hurt by his barb. Benign as it was, Josh still had shields up, wanting to resist her. Maybe still hating her.

Josh bit into Hyun’s dumpling. “Someone’s looking out for you, I guess.”

She studied his profile, watched him chew. Josh had endured a terrible year. All the things his wife had done to him, then, according to Meyer, Josh had to take a leave of absence from Swanson. For mental health. Sophie had reported back that Uncle Josh was fine, but Sophie also conveyed a hidden worry. While Sophie reported Josh was “fine,” Sophie didn’t like how Josh had changed. And he had changed, she could see it herself now. His eyes betrayed a lot of concealed wounding.

She moved some dumplings onto her own plate, but had lost her appetite. “Meyer said you’re going back to work.”

Josh nodded. “Yeah. It’s time. I’m going back in on Wednesday.”

“The same as before?”

“I don’t think I’ll be going to Rome anytime soon, but, yeah, the same as before.”

Josh would have to earn their trust again. Have to show them he was still the solid and dependable guy he had been. Swanson couldn’t change his employment terms, not when he’d suffered a breakdown of sorts. He’d been in Rome for almost four months after they’d separated. That meant the last eight months he’d lived on disability. “It was your mom who told me you were going back. Meyer only confirmed it.”

Josh chewed and swallowed. “You talked to her this week?”

She nodded. Josh’s mother only knew they were separated, not that she’d been pregnant, and not that she’d borne her granddaughter. “On Facebook,” she said.

“Yeah. Your dad messages me on Facebook, too. Just checking in with me. Or he used to. I haven’t heard from him in a while.”

“He doesn’t like being online,” she said, turning her eyes down. “He asks me about you all the time.”

Josh leaned back from the table, sighing, his brow looking heavy. “I don’t think . . . I don’t think I want to eat.” He lifted his glass of sparkling water and sipped. When he put the glass back down, his eyes looked across the table, away from her. “How about your work? Meyer said you went back right after you gave birth.”

“I did,” she said.

“Says you’re not a lawyer anymore. Hyun told him you’re an executive.”

Her stomach tightened. Her own brow slumped, an oncoming storm on the horizon set to rock this table with some pretty big waves. “That’s right.”

“It looks like you’re doing well.” His eyes roamed the room.

“We can figure out the money later. I don’t want to talk about that tonight. I want to talk about us.”

“I don’t care about the money, Kimmy. You took the money to buy a house. Buy a house for our daughter. That’s what we saved that money for.”

She exhaled, bowed her head, determined not to sully the evening with talk of money. “It’s more complicated than that.”

“I bet it is,” Josh said, nodding.

“Okay,” she said, voice faded to a whisper. She cleared her throat and took a deep breath. “I’m at Stone. Stone Brokerage.”

Josh didn’t blow up, didn’t storm out. He accepted it, rolled it over in his mind then closed his eyes. “You told me you left and burned your bridge.”

“I did. All of that was true.”

Josh opened his watery eyes and regarded her. “Doesn’t sound like it was true.”

She didn't respond right away, letting Josh rebuild his confidence after the news she remained at Stone, determined there would be no fight between them. She said, "It's not the way it was before."

Josh rolled his head away, looking like the urge to flee had hooked him. "That's good," he said, crackling with dry sarcasm.

"I'm not in my old position," she said.

Josh groaned, the groan dragging out to a breathy chuckle while he shook his head. She saw the insinuation now, the dirty double entendre: *we all know what position you used to have*. Josh picturing his wife on her back with her legs up.

"I run it, Josh. I run Stone. I run Stone in Toronto."

Josh stopped wagging his head, the attitude of the long-suffering man fading for a moment as he contemplated the pronouncement, his eyes darting over his plate and the untouched food. "But that was Devlin's job." He looked her way, brow crinkled.

"Devlin moved away, Josh," she said. "Very far away."

Josh eased a little but there was no mood for relief. He nodded his head, pursed his lips. "How far?"

"Vancouver, I think."

Josh sat back from the table, stored energy building up and riling him. "Oh. I was just there a few months ago, I could have visited him."

A small snuffling laugh escaped her and she smiled. Josh didn't. Josh didn't see any humor right now. But it wasn't that there was anything funny, it's just that there was no other more fitting response from the man she'd married. It was the perfect "Josh" response.

But Josh grew sombre. "That explains you and him."

"Me and who?"

"You and Stone," he said, jaw muscles flexing. He regarded her. "You and Devlin's dad."

“Oh,” she whispered, retreating from the table now, too, sitting back and crossing one leg over the other. “It does.”

* * *

Kimmy reacted with calm control; somewhat bothered, yet ready to address the hardships of life to her long-suffering and milquetoast man. “I heard about the picture,” she said. “The \$14,000 picture.”

Josh snorted, bothered, annoyed, not finding any humor in Meyer’s callous labeling of his own cousin’s heartbreak. And hurt that Kimmy *would*. “Well, it was a strange way for me to find out.”

“Should I have called you?”

He grumbled, annoyed with her, studying her, divining her attitude from the words she used. They were challenging and dismissive. Before he could even consider a response, Kimmy had a follow-up.

“Did you call me when you dated Karina?”

He thumbed his cheek, looking near her but not at her. He hadn’t expected her to say that. “Maybe you have a point,” he said, regretting the sharp turn dinner had taken. Maybe she didn’t think he had the right to question her dating choices. They were married but separated. But not legally separated. They had a child together. And yet, he hadn’t talked to her. He hadn’t come to see his baby. But now that he had come, it was so clear: the longer he stayed away, the longer it was possible Colleen was his child. By staying away, he’d preserved the fondest of his possibilities: that something was salvageable from what he’d considered the most important aspect of his life; a sound, loving relationship with the woman he married. He said, “I don’t want to fight.”

Kimmy put her elbows on the table and intertwined her fingers, regarding him through slimmed eyes. “How is Karina?”

He shrugged. “We’re not dating.”

“You were, though.”

“Kind of. Yeah, I guess. It’s not what you’re thinking.”

“I don’t think about it, Josh. We’ve been apart. I have no right to make any claims of dismay I might have about it.”

“So, Stone, huh? How did that happen? I mean, the last time we talked, you know, face to face, you told me you burned the bridge, you started something you couldn’t stop. You told me I’d try to save you, and you didn’t want that. Yet, here you are.” He gestured to the table, then the house. He gestured toward her. Looking beautiful. Nestled in a perfect house. With their baby. Wearing fine clothes. Back to work. No maternity leave. No maternity leave because she had Hyun. “How did you end up with everything? How did you wind up with everything, and I have nothing? What was it that I might have tried to save you from? Because, you know, I *didn’t* save you. I stayed away. Far, far away. For months. In Rome.” He scoffed, remembering the hateful resentment he could sometimes feel toward her, all of it racing back now, just when he’d thought they could find some reconciliation. There was something clear now. He slumped, felt the sick swirl of jealousy. “Someone else saved you. *He* did. Devlin’s dad.”

Kimmy lowered her hands, still interdigitated, but more like prayer now. She looked at the food on her plate. She nodded, almost imperceptibly at first, then enough for him to recognize it as affirmative.

She’d told him to stay away. She let another man save her. A savage pain bloomed in his heart, fat petals of sick jealousy unfurling inside him, bloating under pressured turgor. He groaned, unmanned, easing back from the table and looking away from her.

How could she still hurt him so badly when they’d been apart so long?

Chapter 6

The Longhouse

Kimmy pushed her plate away. He did the same. It was a mistake to come for dinner. He should have come a long time ago. Come to see Colleen.

Elbows on the table, he rubbed his cheeks then cupped his hands on his face and breathed. He said into his hands, “I want to be in Colleen’s life. If that’s all right with you.”

“Josh, of course,” she said, her tone superior, chafed by his request.

He dropped his hands. “Do you think I’m being dramatic?”

Kimmy retreated, stung by his defense. She looked down, nodded, realizing maybe her tone was equivalent to rolling her eyes. Dismissing him.

She said, “We’re not going to eat. Can I show you around the house?”

“I’d rather talk.”

Kimmy looked away, to the door that would lead them out of their stuffy confinement. “Then let’s take a walk. We can go outside and have privacy. You can yell at me.”

“I’m not yelling.”

“Raise your voice,” she offered and shrugged. “Do whatever. You can tell me what you think of me.”

She wasn't taking no for an answer, standing now, touching his arm, encouraging him to go with her. He stood and followed her out the door, into a hallway beside the room where he'd first met his daughter. Now he was rubbing his brow, wincing from the emotional overfeeding and all the sick hurt in his heart that it conveyed.

Kimmy exited the house and held the back door for him. The colder night air hit his cheeks with a welcome snap that widened his eyes and woke him up. Kimmy closed the door and walked past him, out into the grass in her slippers. He followed her, staying on the brick walkway because he was wearing socks and the grass would be cold and wet. Kimmy turned, saw him a few arm lengths away and looked down at his feet. She corrected her path and met up with him on the walkway. She looked fantastic. Healthy, but a little worn out. Her eyes were tired, but nothing could stop the beauty showing in her cheekbones and jawline, and the easy grace in her long limbs and lithe body. Even under the unstructured pajamas and the robe, she showed a gentle poise.

She said, "How do you want it to be with Colleen?"

"She's my daughter. I want to be her dad." He shrugged, not feeling confident enough to set forward a time structure or make any demands. He didn't have the willpower right now to fight her if she rejected any of his claims. "We should work that all out later. Not tonight."

"This must be big for you."

"That's an understatement," he said.

She turned her face to his and he looked down. Kimmy reached for him and plucked a hair from his sweater. Her fingers were long and fine, pulling the hair away, long and black.

He sighed, said, "I just, I'm blown away how you've moved on without me. You have everything and I have nothing and I'm an afterthought."

Kimmy tugged on his elbow, both his hands stuck in into his pockets. "That's the old woe-is-me Josh."

He looked to see her smiling, those tired eyes showing warmth and not disappointment.

He said, "Tell me I'm wrong."

She nodded her head to the side, toward a carriage house at the end of the driveway, the driveway extending from the road, past the main house, and along one side of the backyard. He checked to the right, saw his Nissan still parked there (not a lot of car thefts in Unionville), and followed in Kimmy's path to a door at the back side of the carriage house. She pulled a key from her robe's pocket and unlocked the door, stepped in and turned on a light. She encouraged him to follow her in.

The carriage house was a two car garage with a second floor, and the back door opened into a tiny foyer and a set of narrow stairs that led up to the second floor. The small space smelled like paint and drywall.

Kimmy walked up the stairs and he followed. The top of the stairwell opened to the right onto an open living space and a kitchen. She flicked more light switches and the room lit up. There was a leather couch and a TV, a table to eat at, and the kitchen was warm and inviting with under-the-cabinet lighting and terra cotta backsplashes, the amenities in glossy black.

"This was the renovation," she said, gesturing to the room, putting her hands in her robe pockets. Her head angled to the side, lips pursed, watching him.

He stared back.

Kimmy rubbed her neck like it was sore, grimacing, then speaking very quietly, saying, "I did it for you. I want you to live here."

Josh rolled his head on his neck, feeling for the first time today some sort of tugging heartstring, some sort of connection to the woman who'd gutted him. When he regarded her again, he could see her eyes were wet and shining.

She said through sad-garbled speech: "I want you to see our daughter every day of her life." Her voice broke up, and she had to wipe tears away

with the back of a wrist. She sniffled, trying to restore her façade, extending an arm and holding out the carriage house key for him to take. “There’s a bedroom and a bathroom behind that door.” She jingled the key. “Come, I’ll show you.”

Josh took the key, one part of him fighting against her, wanting to reject it, another part so relieved, so happy he wouldn’t be excised from Colleen’s life. And, god damn it, *happy* that Kimmy wanted him. Or at least didn’t want to make their daughter’s life difficult.

Kimmy turned away, walking to the door beyond the kitchen table, pulling from the other robe pocket a scrunched up tissue. She wiped her nose, put the tissue away, and opened the door at the back. Josh trudged behind her, wanting to live here, wanting to be in his daughter’s life every day, but hating this *supportive* aspect; of being in his *wife’s* house. Of being an add-on to his busy wife’s fabulous lifestyle. Of sitting in this fucking apartment and watching some luxurious motor coach pull into the driveway, Kimmy trotting off in high heels to go into the city with her billionaire boyfriend. And here her husband would sit; a voyeur. A loser.

The bedroom was furnished, a queen-size bed, masculine bedding, a chair, some dark furniture, and windows at the front of the carriage house looking down onto the driveway. He entered the bedroom, hands in his pockets, heart heavy, mood growing dank and swampy. He walked to the window and looked out to see his Nissan parked where Devlin’s father would park when he came to pick up Kimmy. Maybe it wouldn’t even be Devlin’s father, maybe Devlin’s father would send a service to pick Kimmy up, escort her into the city where he probably had his own skyscraper condo that showed all the twinkling lights of the city like sparkling jewels.

He turned away and faced Kimmy, not wanting that scenario to play out in his imagination to its lurid conclusion.

Kimmy stood with hands clasped at her front, looking hopeful. Like this in-law apartment would suit him; this was the fitting place for her husband;

a prison cell where he could sit in purgatorial reverie, watching his wife live an amazing life, and he would be relegated to house duty, taking care of Kimmy's offspring like Hyun. Hyun stayed here for free, Meyer said. Hyun had her own room, rent-free, and Kimmy even leased her a car. Hyun didn't work. Hyun went to college at night and took care of Colleen during the day.

When he said nothing, Kimmy stepped to the side and pushed open another door, showing him the bathroom. Then she resumed that hopeful pose, tall and thin and elegant in her satin robe, hands clasped at her front.

Josh walked back to her, looked into the dark bathroom. They stood close together, almost touching; he could hear her breathe. She smelled amazing; like pale perfume and something else. Something motherly. He leaned his shoulder on the bathroom's door jamb and regarded her. Her eyes looked weak and tired, the hopeful shimmer fading. He leaned his head to the side until his skull touched the sharp corner-edge of the jamb, eyes staying on her. The apartment offended him and yet charmed him as well.

His daughter Colleen lived in the main house; the new, sole importance in his life. And this gesture of Kimmy's was kindness, not antagonization. He'd love to tell her to go fuck a duck, and he'd get an apartment nearby. But he couldn't afford that. He'd been on disability for months now. He'd gone through his personal savings buying Meyer his birthday gift and taking that exorbitant cross-country bike trip. Kimmy had taken their house fund and bought a house.

In that case, the apartment was rightfully his.

But to sit here and watch...? Sit here and watch his wife...?

He said, "What's it like with him?"

"Who?" Her voice cracked when she spoke, and she touched long fingers to her collar.

"You know who. Stone senior."

She nodded and looked down. "Keith."

“Keith Stone, huh? You and him. He’s a billionaire. Least that’s what the article said.”

Kimmy looked up and regarded him plainly. She said no more.

He said, “Were you with him when you were pregnant? Or is this a new thing?”

Kimmy exhaled, wincing, like she didn’t want to talk to her husband about the man she was dating.

“Does he ever come here? Does he come to the house?”

Kimmy stepped away, showing him her back, head bowing. “No, Josh,” she said, her voice barely a whisper.

“I want to know what I’m getting into.” The question was reasonable.

Kimmy rubbed her brow. “I’ve only gone out with him a few times.”

“How old is he?”

“Fifty-six.”

Now he wished he could *stop* asking questions. That old rolling angst began swirling in his guts, racing his heart with something like hate and lust. Keith Stone was a fucking asshole. His parents had talked with Keith Stone back in those olden days about his son’s bullying and come home saying it. “*What a fucking asshole.*” And his mom almost never swore. And that’s the man who was in his life now. Without his say.

He lurched away from the door jamb, a surprising swell of old fears and passions pushing past the cobwebs the medication had spun in his brain. His heart raced and his muscles swelled with the rush of adrenalin.

He had closed the distance between him and Kimmy, looking at her slender shoulders, wanting to grab one and spin her around, demand from her an explanation on how one woman could be so terrible.

“I can’t stay here,” he said in a low growl of simmering anger.

Kimmy turned now, expression harrowed. “Josh, you have to. Please...”

He shook his head, “He’s fifty-six, how can you even...” His hands went to fists, his jaw clenched and his brow lowered, his mind’s eye flashing all

kinds of wicked and dirty scenarios he didn't want to see. Kimmy held her throat and watched him, eyes glimmering with wet.

He wanted to claw away his own skin and climb out of himself. But Kimmy regarded him with earnest hope. Like she needed him here. But what about *him*? What about what *he* needed?

How about what Colleen needed?

He rubbed his brow, pumping the brakes on runaway emotion, nodding, huffing air through his nose like a bothered bull. The anger rose again. "Are you fucking him?"

Kimmy closed her eyes and looked away. Then stepped away. He wanted to grab that shoulder again and spin her to face him.

"Tell me," he said, demanding to know what he was getting into.

Even though she faced away, he could see Kimmy nodding.

Chapter 7

Acherontic Wings

This time when he wanted to spin her around, he couldn't stop himself, putting his hand on her shoulder and making her face him. "Just fucking tell me, Kimmy."

Kimmy turned up her palms, like she didn't know what he wanted to hear or didn't know how to tell him. Or maybe didn't think any of this was his business. This made him the maddest.

She paused, mouth open as her brain searched for impossible words. "It's nothing, Josh," she said, looking away. "It's nothing real."

He shook his head, looking away as well, an acid coal beginning to singe the center of his chest. There it was. The finale.

No hope now, is there, Joshy?

Hope for what?

He said, "I didn't know what would happen when I came this weekend. Didn't know if I should come at all. Not because I didn't want to, but maybe you would scream at me for not coming already, for—"

"I'm not angry, Josh," she said softly.

He ran his hand through his hair. "I know. I know you're not." He dropped his hand to his thigh. "I didn't know that it would be like this. If I came this weekend, that it would be like, like this..." He gestured to the room and then toward her. "And that you'd ask me..."

“I just want you to know I want you in my life. I want you in Colleen’s life. I’m trying to welcome you.”

He looked up, he looked down, his heart wringing out in his chest like a swim towel, the sticky sap of heartache slithering through him like treacle. “Okay,” he said, admitting silently to himself now that this in-law apartment was an act of kindness. It wasn’t her fault she’d begun some other affair with an older man. I mean, he’d stayed away for, like, a year, so what did he expect? And he’d dated Karina—or at least gone out with her a few times in ways that friends didn’t do. But this all felt so unfair. So cold.

But not unfamiliar. Not unfamiliar at all.

It felt like all those old searing prongs felt when she’d last lied and betrayed him to his doom. Pulled the rug out from under him, suffocated him with it, rolled him up and pitched him off a deck into frigid lake water. All to get what she wanted. And now she had it all. If she kept her ex-husband in this apartment like a flower in the attic, then she would have everything.

“I’m welcome,” he admitted, hands out like he was surrendering. “But it’s not fair how you have everything.”

Kimmy wasn’t shocked or offended by his claim, saying only, “I don’t have everything, Josh. You’ve only been back in my life for an hour. There’s so much you don’t know.”

“So, tell me then. Tell me what I don’t see.”

Kimmy chewed her cheek, and the way she’d inclined her head and looked to the bedroom floor a meter away from his feet, he knew she didn’t want to talk about this.

“You have our daughter. You have our home. You have an amazing job. You travel. You have Sophie. You have Hyun as a helper. And you’re with a billionaire.”

Kimmy didn’t look up, but she stepped closer to him, eyes traveling to his chest, her hands reaching for him. She put her palms on him and it made

his heart gallop in his chest. His temples throbbed.

“I do what I have to do,” she said, and looked up to meet his gaze. “But I love you. It’s you that I love, Josh.”

That hot coal flared like an ember in a breeze, and though he wanted to grit his teeth and spit vitriol, he held her upper arms. Forgot how fine she was, how wonderful her slender arms felt in his grip. Kimmy was close to tears again, and what he saw in those dark eyes was earnest communication. Like a silent voice begging for someone who held their fate to spare them. To not do what would be so easy for them to do.

And right there a hopeful spark lit a flare that illuminated some of the kinder aspects of his life with her. There were things about her he loved. And it wasn’t long ago. In fact, the time he’d spent hating her was very brief. The time he’d spent loving her was long. And it was good.

His hands stroked her upper arms, his neck swelled with the pounding blood. He felt wide awake and electrified. He felt like he could crush Kimmy if he wanted. Like a pop can. Or spiritually, too. He could walk out on her and she would think of him every day for the rest of her life and it would hurt her. She would think of him every day she looked in their daughter’s eyes and saw a piece of the man she’d ruined. He could kiss her. He could throw her on the bed in this dim bedroom. He could fuck her. He could bend her over and fuck her. His muscles were like cords; he could pick her up and toss her out the window she expected him to sit by while she cavorted with the father of his high school bully. He felt strong like the day he’d thrown the chair at Devlin.

He gripped her skinny arms tighter and yanked her close. It was she who kissed him. It was Kimmy’s mouth who sought out his. Not the other way around.

With their mouths together, their breaths intersecting and finding sympathetic pace, their bodies pressed, a lot of the good and true love they’d felt rang in his mind like a distant church bell. His hands stroked

from her upper arms down to circle her wrists. Kimmy melted against him, his kiss like a port-connection supplying her with power. The lightness of her body raced his heart. It felt wonderful to have her body sealed against his own. She was light and nimble and unique; he'd missed how it felt to hold her.

When he'd held Karina, the dissimilarity ached under his fingers; a foreign terrain daunting him with the demand for familiarity. But conversance required sacrifice and venture, and the journey seemed steep uphill. He'd not been up to the task. Not fit enough for travel.

Kimmy's landscape was familiar. It was easy travel; touch was informal, unpretentious. And obliged. She was his to touch. Even if another man had entered her life, Kimmy was his by law and by surrender. Kimmy had said so herself on the altar the day they were married.

He broke their kiss, and Kimmy looked up with wounded eyes. He had trouble deciphering the source of her wounding. What would make those eyes hurt?

He said, "You want me to sit here in this room and watch out the window as your life moves on?"

"No, Josh," she said, brow knitting.

"What do you see in him?"

Kimmy looked up and away, seeking to rest her cheek now on his chest again. To escape his questions. To deny him the truth. He wouldn't let her hide, taking her shoulders and holding her in place.

"His money? His power? You like being in the paper?"

Kimmy stared back at him with dull, sober eyes. She said nothing, like a woman waiting out a storm. Just watching.

He tilted up his chin, almost sneering. "What else, Kimmy? Does he do bad things in bed?"

She winced, turned away a measure like his words disgusted her. He asked her, "Is that it?"

She shook her head no imperceptibly, but not enough he didn't notice. It was a dismissal. Kimmy thought she was so much better than his petty grievances. Was that it?

"Tell me. What can a fifty-five year old man offer you? Money and power. You don't think that's it? What else? Does he have a big horse dick like his son?" He sneered again, disgusted by his own words, but loving the juxtaposition of his awful wife and her lover and now her lover's father; sin upon sin. Sin with no end.

Kimmy closed her eyes and breathed. When she opened them again, quiet and stony, she said, "What if it's all of those things?"

He let her shoulders go and made a satisfied sound in his throat. His wife's depravity confirmed. She was the wicked woman he knew her to be.

But he hated her unbothered acceptance; her casual dismissal of his complaint, the arrogant establishment of how low she would go to get what she wanted.

He shook his head, showing her contempt and a dismissal of his own. If he was braver he would tell her in words. Tell her how she was nothing to him. Tell her how she was beneath him.

"You wanted to know, so now you know," she said. "What are you going to do about it?"

"What's there to do?" He jabbed his hands toward the bedroom window. "I guess I'll sit here to make you happy. I'll sit here and make your life complete. How does that sound to you?"

Kimmy looked down, put her hands out and touched his waist. "You don't have to, Josh. It's up to you." She slipped her thumbs into the belt loops at his hips and pulled his pelvis into hers. She whispered, "You can always close the blinds."

His jaw dropped, and he regarded her with awful reproach. He shook his head with comical disbelief, amazed at how she could coil and strike

like a snake, when she'd been so sweet and innocent since he first arrived in her lair.

She tugged the belt loops again, instigating, bullying. Challenging him. "It's up to you what you want to do."

Their eyes met again. All the things he'd wanted to say to her in his darkest times tumbled on his tongue. It felt good to imagine saying them, but even the smallest actual utterance would put a barrier between them that maybe he couldn't afford if he wanted to raise a child with her. But saying nothing felt like letting her win. Letting her get away with it.

He stood upright and strong, not backing down from her even though he bit his tongue.

She knew it, too. Smiling wanly, eyes hooded, lips pursing. "I know you hate me."

"I wish I cared enough to hate you."

She flashed him a degree-wider smile. "You care. You know you do."

"Why do you want to torment me?"

She showed grave concern now. "I don't, Josh. I don't want to torment you. I want to love you and I want you to love me." Her hands left his belt loops and pressed on his lower back, just above his ass. She stared into his eyes. The look was deep and probing.

She kissed him again and he let her, twisting his head on his neck to form a better seal against her plump lips. He pressed his pelvis into her. She was soft and receptive, hips moiling against him, locating his hardness, pressing into it.

The kiss broke as her stomach squashed his rock hard erection, and she looked in his eyes with a hunger he hadn't seen in over a year. He pressed his brow to her brow, both of them breathing heavy. Pure liquid hate rushed through his ears with a whoosh. Hate not for her, but for his own weakness. His sexual reception to the worst his wife offered.

He shook his head no and stepped back. Kimmy was undeterred, untying her robe's satin belt and letting the folds fall open. He kept shaking his head side to side, simple defiance against her inexorable progress. She tossed the robe to the bed.

"You've been with him?" His voice was a low and mean rumble.

Kimmy showed no reaction to his question, cocking her head like a wise corvid, studying him, pursuing him, stepping into his personal ring, past his shields and armor and where she could sink her poisonous blade into where he was soft and squishy and most vulnerable. He looked away, turning his mouth corners down, like the sight of her disgusted him. She kissed his chin, kissed his neck. Her hand smoothed between his legs, long palm and fingers soaring over his aching denim bulge. He said, "What are you doing?"

"You're my husband, Josh." Her hand stroked up and down, squeezed. His knees jellied and the room swayed. He inhaled a sharp intake.

He turned his head farther, but she kept kissing his neck and jaw. She said, "You think you're just going to sit and look out the window?"

All sorts of freaky endeavors flashed in lurid porno clips; Devlin's cock against his own cock, Kimmy taking Devlin deep inside her while he watched; an old man with white hair and a sagging scrotum under his decrepit horse cock pounding into her while Kimmy squawked in time with his thrusts.

Her hands came together at his waist and undid his belt. She was looking in his eyes. She said, "You're my husband, Josh."

Chapter 8

Into the Void

Josh gripped Kimmy's wrists, stopping her from getting what she wanted. "What are you doing?"

Kimmy closed her eyes, and her shoulders slumped in a way that convinced him of her disappointment.

He said, "You can't just drag me into bed. You can't steamroll me that way. *Fuck*, Kimmy..." He shook his head, dismayed. "We used to have so much fun together—and now it's like *this*."

Kimmy slipped her arms from his grasp, stepping back and smoothing her hair. "We did."

"And now you summon me here and I see my, my fucking *daughter*..." He grabbed a handful of hair, a touch of madness seizing him. "And you want me to live here. Want me to sit and watch your life, but you also want me in bed...? I have fucking whiplash."

"Good, Josh," she said. "Have whiplash. Live here. Love Colleen. That's all I ask. I don't expect you to give the tiniest care for me, I don't deserve it, but don't—"

"Don't what? *Not* live here? *Not* love Colleen? Why would you think I want you to touch me like that, to, to...?"

"I'm sorry," Kimmy said. "That was unfair. I shouldn't have kissed you, I shouldn't have—"

“It’s not that. I mean, I feel it too. I feel like...”

“You shouldn’t. You shouldn’t feel anything for me. I went too far right now. I love you. I can’t help how you feel about me, but I don’t want you to hate me. I want you to be happy. You say I have everything, but I want *you* to have everything. *You*. I want you to have it all. I . . . I came on too strong.” She held up her palms, showing she would pump the brakes.

He turned away, walked to the window, looked out at streetlight filtering through a fading maple canopy to rim light his Nissan. The driveway. The house. The *home*. The place where everything he’d ever wanted in this world resided. A family. A daughter. He touched his forehead to the window’s chill. “You’ve got it all. You can try to make me feel better by bringing me to bed, but can’t you see how I feel? Fucking me is patting me on the head, telling me I’m a good boy for coming to your house. You’ve got everything. What do you need me for?”

Kimmy took a long time to answer. Someone walked a Scottie dog on a leash past her house. At last she said, “I need you because you’re my husband. That’s why I need you.”

He let the curtain fall and turned to face her again, hands in his pockets. She stared back, hopeful, hurting, desperate. The pale light shone past his shoulders and bathed her in a lunar glow. He said, “You just want your daughter’s father around so your daughter won’t hate you.”

Kimmy’s eyes widened. Instead of rearing from his attack, she nodded, eyes on the verge of tears. “That’s it, Josh,” she said, “let me have it. I deserve it,” batting her fist on her slender chest.

Her harrowed look lured him. Now he said, “You want me around because if I *wasn’t* around you worry people might think you’re a *failure*.”

“That’s true,” she said, nodding, eyes wet. “I would think that. It doesn’t mean I don’t want you around for other reasons.”

“Like what? What is it that Keith fucking Stone can’t give you that I can?”

Kimmy shook her head in that way that people do when they knew so much more than you, chuckling now and stooping to retrieve her robe from the foot of the bed. She lifted it, poised like she would don it, but then holding it to her chest and staring at him. Her eyes shone wet, but there was something else there, something sparkling amongst the dullness she'd shown him with those eyes since he'd arrived. She said, "He can't always get it up."

The answer shocked him, coming at him unexpected and unwanted. It disgusted him. "He *what*?"

"He's not reliable, Josh. How about that?"

His eyes narrowed, a certain measure of indignation soiling his view. Kimmy of the high-paying job, of the high IQ and the littlest beautiful baby girl and the big house. But she was Kimmy of the wicked darkness, too. The sexually depraved woman he'd married. The one who'd ruined him, broke his heart and broke his trust like a china plate on a granite floor. She'd fucked Devlin Stone and gaslit her husband up and down and sideways. She'd lied to him and manipulated him and toyed with him. She'd fucked Devlin Stone in Cayman, fucked Devlin Stone in his apartment, fucked him right in front of her husband when it came down to the wire.

His heart beat stronger and his nostrils flared. He stepped closer to her.

Kimmy raised her chin, unafraid. "Yeah. He can't get it up."

Josh stepped into her space, the two of them eye to eye.

She said, "What if I need you for your dick?"

When he stepped back, Kimmy dropped her robe to the floor and clutched his sweater, not wanting him to flee. Echoes of arguments past arrived; how he was the one who was so quick to run away. Run so far away it took a year to come back to her even though she bore his child. But no one could condemn him. The betrayal had been so stark and punishing,

his retreat was for the preservation of life. Devlin and Kimmy had pushed him to the borderlands of madness.

“You don’t have to sit here,” Kimmy said, nodding her chin to the window. “It’s your house. Take any room you want.”

His hands went to her wrists again and this time he didn’t pull her hands away. He let her hold him in place.

Kimmy’s lure was impossibly strong; up close like this, her body touching his, looking deep into her quavering black eyes. They were married; he’d just discovered a precious pink bundle in the main house that was definitely his. Falling into bed with her would be so easy. Voices spoke to him in whispers, telling him he *ought* to do it. That it would be wrong not to.

You’d have a home. A wife. A baby.

Everything he’d ever wanted.

He said, “What if I want the bedroom?”

“Take it,” she said. “Kick me out. I’ll stay here. If it means you’re in Colleen’s life—in *my* life—this room is where I’ll stay.”

It was all too much. It was all too much and coming all at once. If only he hadn’t run so far away. If only he’d adjusted to her rise from wickedness in acceptable increments. Maybe then he could trust her words. Trust she told him the truth.

He turned with her, putting her back to the bed and sitting her down. He stood above her, and she regarded him with the pleading eyes of a pauper.

“Banish me,” she said. “But don’t abandon me. Please.”

He cupped a hand to her cheek, angled his head, looked in her eyes, deeper this time, wanting to connect with her, wanting some way to know when the words she spoke were the truth. Kimmy held his wrist with both hands, letting him in her black windows, like she wanted him to know nothing hid there in the dark, waiting to pounce on him.

He lowered and prowled over top of her, Kimmy surrendering, easing onto her back while he got over her. His face hovered over hers, studying her, Josh now assuming the pose of the studious raven.

“I love you, Josh,” she said, and he believed her.

But he did nothing, stayed over her, Kimmy with her hands at her chest, wringing them with worry. He pushed them apart.

Pushed them apart and then unbuttoned her pajama top, slowly exposing that ribbed plain between her breasts. Putting his hand on her bare skin, looking in her eyes, wondering how the hell he was here in this room with her, doing the thing he was doing. Considering the things he considered.

“You’re with another man,” he said.

“I’m not with him, Josh,” she said.

He flinched with surprise as her hand palmed his arousal over his pants. It felt so good. So right. So fucking sexual. Sexual in all the worst ways.

Sexual in the way that had fizzled his feelings for Karina.

“I’ve missed you so much,” she said, and once again he believed her. “I need you, Josh. I *need* you.”

She raised her chin, showing him her long and vulnerable throat. He couldn’t stop himself if he wanted. His mouth went to that spot under her ear and kissed her there. A place he loved to kiss her. Kimmy moaned an unbelievable sound of whimpering satisfaction. She squeezed his dick. He kissed her harder. Her two hands came together again, moving fast to undo his pants, to free his aching hardness.

This was the last thing he’d expected coming here tonight.

A grim part of him had accepted he would visit and find Mr. Stone here, some of Mr. Stone’s friends, a bunch of unfamiliar faces. A wife moved on. A woman from his past. And he thought he might take one look at Kimmy’s baby and hand it back. Not seeing his mother’s eyes there, but seeing the devil eyes of her new beau’s son.

But this wasn't anticipated. How could he imagine everything trying to fit back in place this way? How could he anticipate the overwhelm he'd feel when he held a tiny life that was one-hundred percent of his loins?

"Oh, god," he sighed, that overwhelm manifesting, swooping away with his consciousness like a mouse in the beak of a large flying predator. Kimmy's warm hand had closed around his naked cock. His breath came in heavy panting. He flexed his cock in her grip, a sexual eagerness swelling his being, a long-forgotten joy quashed by betrayal and corruption.

His kisses traveled from that sweet spot on her neck, along her sharp jawline, finding the wet dampness of her perfect mouth. He kissed her, pushing her head back into the bedding she'd set up for him to stay in her life.

Kimmy jerked his cock, and the pleasure stole away his forethought, turned him to meaningless goo.

He hadn't had sex in a whole fucking year. No one had touched his dick but himself in that time.

His hand circled her throat and caressed her collar while he kissed her and his consciousness held on for dear life. The idea that she wanted him ached in his heart. Kimmy wanted him. Desired him.

His kiss retreated and he struggled to manufacture a plan of sexual attack. Kimmy controlled him with her hand on his erection, gone slick now, too, his balls overflowing with wet need.

"I need you, Josh, I need you," she whispered, thumbing the slippery groove on the underside of his cock head, putting white blobs of lust into his dark vision.

"You just need a hard dick," he growled, loving the way Kimmy could rob him of reason, flood his senses with the darkest syrup.

"I do," she gasped. "I need my husband's hard dick so *bad*, Josh."

He thrust his cock through Kimmy's grip and she knew how to handle him the way he liked. "He can't get it up?"

Kimmy sighed and gasped, bit her lower lip. She moaned, then whispered, “He can fuck with it, but it’s limp. It’s big but it’s floppy, Josh. I need a young man. I need my husband. I need the man I fucking love.”

“You don’t love him?”

“Josh, I’ve never loved anyone else but you. *Never.*”

And suddenly the idea of Kimmy having sex with Keith Stone didn’t seem so surreal or so terrible. It seemed like everything was fitting back into place.

He swatted open one side of her pajama top, exposing her swollen teat, the nipple darker, fuller than he’d ever seen it. His hand went down the front of her pajama pants, and holy fuck, she wore no underwear. Just her pussy, wet and needy. Shaved. Shaved for Keith Stone, but it felt amazing just the same.

Chapter 9

Root Congestion

Josh was beautiful. Beautiful, but so vulnerable. Despite his sojourn and his exile, he still showed aversion to her touch. Timid. Like a victim. Gun shy. The harm she'd caused him was heartbreaking.

His hard cock was in her hand, his mouth on her skin, her aching nipples aching even harder, hurting and wet—now, of all times, leaking when she had the man she wanted in her bed.

A sojourn of her own, an exile of her own, had brought her to this point, and now she was prepared to ruin it all by lying, by deceiving, doing all the things that had sent her into lonely and deserved despair.

She let go of his cock, slipped her hands around to his bare back, hugged her cheek to his chest, and closed her eyes. If she let him go and he departed, jumped out the window and flew off into the night, everything would be over. Nothing would ever be the same. She kissed the warmth of his sweater, knowing the risk; stopping now when the ball was rolling would cease their progress and could cast them apart again. And she couldn't bear that.

But Josh sensed the change, coming to his senses, swimming up from the dark depths where she had sunk him, words like heavy chains dragging him down where the light couldn't reach. A place she knew he liked. A place he wanted to spend time in. But not like this. Nothing could be more

roundly wicked than taking his game piece and pushing him back to the start when he was so close to freedom.

Josh abandoned her, but not the bed, falling off to the side, laying on his back and blocking his eyes with an arm. His cock stuck up out of his open pants, hard as steel and shining wet.

She palmed her forehead, closed her eyes. Getting what she wanted without coercion was a path that would take time to learn. Tonight the stakes were high, but deception was too great a risk. She imitated Josh, resting a forearm over her brow, her other hand closing her pajama top. Two married people who'd faced sheer devastation, laying in bed together, hiding from each other though they were touching.

She lowered her arm, cleared her thoughts, scooted up onto the bed, drawing her legs underneath her; she curled her body around Josh's head and shoulders, caressed his hair and stroked his beard. Josh removed his arm and opened his eyes. She thumbed his chin, loving every angle of his perfect face. Josh tucked his erection into his fly and closed it. She kissed his temple.

But sensing he could sit up and abandon the moment, leave her swimming in its sweet wake, alone again like she'd been alone for a year, had her surging forward, not even having a plan. Acting on honest instinct.

But then again, just a crafty angler giving a trophy fish some more line.

She said, "I lied about Devlin's father."

Josh nodded, expression somber still, mouth tucking to one side—a sign of the psychic wounding she so casually reintroduced to his life just because she wanted him to stay.

"We're not together," she said. "We've never been together."

Josh's brow crinkled. She stroked her palm over his jaw, liking the beard under her touch. He said, "What do you mean?"

She told him she was sorry; Josh sat up, and she was sure he would bolt to the door. How would she even stop him? He regarded her over his

shoulder, bewildered and bothered. She sat up as well, cross-legged on the bed's center. She intertwined her fingers and hooked her thumbs. She said, "I've attended a few functions with him. It's for work, but also he doesn't want to go alone. He's not interested in me. Not in that way."

"Why would you tell me...?"

"I, I don't know, Josh."

"You were just, just what?—trying to get me in bed?"

She shrugged, feeling foolish, but grateful he hadn't walked out of the room.

Josh looked away, puzzled, struggling to make sense of her inane actions, getting him in this room and practically seducing him. "Am I that predictable? Do you think I still want that?"

She stopped twiddling her thumbs and held her head instead, both hands on her brow and temples. "I'm ashamed," she said. "I just . . . Meyer told me about how you saw the photo..."

"And how I reacted. And you think, what? That means you can play me like you used to?"

She swore he was looking to leave, and she scooted closer, putting his back and rump into her crotch, long legs on either side of him. She threw her arms around his shoulders and hugged her cheek to the back of his neck. "Don't leave me, Josh."

Josh slumped, but she detected no seizing of muscle or tendon, no preparation for flight. Only slump-shouldered defeat. The last thing she'd wanted tonight. The very last thing. She'd foreseen wonderful things. Seen them with crossed fingers. Like Josh with his baby. And Colleen would look in his eyes and Josh would right away be a changed man. He would stay in Unionville tonight. He would sleep in her bed. She would wake up with him.

She said, "I haven't been with a man, Josh. Not since the last day I saw you. I've been so busy. So busy trying to make things right."

“I... I wasn’t with Karina... I wasn’t—”

“You don’t have to tell me.”

“I just couldn’t... I didn’t want to do anything with her. I think I just needed a friend.”

That was like a knife in her heart. Josh had gone to Karina and Karina had been there for him after all the harm his wife had done. She’d almost killed him.

“I don’t want to talk about bad things, Josh. I don’t want to talk about the past. Tonight, can we just talk about the future?”

Josh’s chest and shoulders expanded in her clutch as he drew in a deep breath and let it out. She accepted it as an answer in the affirmative. “Stay, Josh. Stay the night. Stay here. I’m so glad you came.”

“You should hate me for how long I stayed away.”

She dug her chin into his back. “I don’t.”

“But you’re punishing me.”

While she surmised his proposal, her grip on him lessened and Josh stood up from the bed, leaving her there alone. He crossed to the dresser and braced himself, two hands on it, hunched over in a way that reminded her of the time he’d hurled the office chair at Devlin Stone.

“I’m not trying to punish you.”

Josh tossed his hands up like he was tired of arguing the same point. “You could have told me you weren’t seeing Devlin’s dad, but you used it against me instead.”

“I’m not against you, Josh. I want you to be happy.”

“By lying to me?”

“Josh...” Now she was exasperated too. Wishing Josh could see into her heart and know she meant him no harm. She only wanted good things for him. “I... I pass you a crayon and you just start coloring. I don’t have to lie. I don’t have to manipulate. You do it all. You take it to the endpoint, running as fast as you can.”

The way Josh stared back, hollow-cheeked, showed her how hurtful her words were, even unintentionally. Josh wasn't ready for this conversation. None of this was what she'd wanted for this night.

Josh sighed and leaned his backside against the dresser. "I don't even know who I am anymore. I sure don't know who you are." He tossed his hands up; letting fate make his choices, adrift at sea. "That's *my* fault for staying away for a year." He regarded her. "But look at you now. I don't even recognize you. Do you recognize me?"

She nodded. "I know what you're saying, but I do see you, Josh. I really do. I recognize you."

Josh smiled, a weak one, but she was happy to see it. But its presence also summoned another thought: *this man is so done with you, his smile is his way of showing how you can't hurt him anymore. You don't mean anything to him.*

But Josh said, "You're persuasive. You could persuade me to do anything." He gestured toward the bed; the place where she'd tried to seduce him with words from their dreadful past. She looked away. He said, "Is that what you want for yourself? Is that what you want for me? To ease me into satisfying place? And then when I'm there, what then? What do you see for yourself when I'm no longer a problem?"

She wiped at her eyes, then regarded him. "You're not a problem."

"A wrinkle," he said. "A wrinkle you need smoothed."

"Do I make you feel like that?"

"Of course. Can't you hear me saying it to you?"

"You're not a wrinkle." Anger had tightened her voice, raised it. "You're not some imperfection in my life. You're the only thing that I want. That I desire."

Josh shook his head, lips slimmed to a thin line. "I'm not worthy of your desire. Don't you see it? What could I ever offer you? I've seen what

turns you on. I've seen the things you like. You *showed* me how you measure a man."

They had both raised their voices. Josh's body tightened, and she saw him like a coiled spring, ready to bounce right out of Unionville and away from danger. She couldn't even be mad at him anymore for his tendency to flee. It had been a life-saving mechanism.

She bolted from the bed, wanting to be close to him before he disappeared, putting her hands on him, touching his arms, looking into his eyes.

"No one could ever hurt me like you hurt me," he said. "No one ever."

A cold knot formed in the center of her chest. It was an awful thing to hear. Most awful because it was true. There was nothing to say. She said, "Maybe no one would love you enough to try."

"You *wanted* to hurt me? I always thought that."

"No. I wanted to hurt you in the way you flirted with." She let go of his arms, waved her hand, dismissing the ugly alley the conversation kept finding its way to.

"That's a lie. A year-old lie. You know that. It was camouflage. You wanted it to hide the evil you did."

And that was true. This wasn't an ugly alley they had to avoid. It was incontrovertible truth that neither of them could escape. She'd just lied again—anything to avoid the sharp edges of their past. Just not tonight. Not the truth. Another time, yes. But tonight she wanted him to be happy. Happy to be here. Happy for his gift.

She said, "Okay. Yes, you're right—"

Josh held up a hand to stop her, expression uninterested and dispassionate. It tightened the frigid knot; she'd never felt more distant from Josh than right now. In the last year, he'd been physically removed from her life, but she conjured him in her thoughts every day, motivation while trying to build the scaffolding of repair that could unite them again.

But tonight was the launching ceremony, and things weren't going well. Her ship would sink. The craft she'd fashioned for them wasn't seaworthy at all.

"That's it," Josh said, waving his hand now, the one to dismiss their entanglement. "I don't want to talk about this. Not now. Not ever." He dropped his hand, stared at her a moment longer, eyes watery and mournful, brow creased. He shook his head, like he'd almost wanted to continue, but knew there was no point. He turned to leave.

The sight of his familiar back broke her resolve, and right now, she would do anything to make him stay. She'd thought teasing him with his obvious interest in some relationship with Devlin's father could tickle him, lure him into their old games—done now only in the safety of their own home. But that was an awful mistake. Apologies formed on her tongue, pleading arguments appeared in her foggy fore-mind. Anything, anything to make him stay. She would fall on her knees, she would fall on her sword. She begged him.

"Please, Josh. Please, don't go. I can't go on without you. You don't even know what it's like. You don't know what I would do for you..."

Josh turned his face over his shoulder, puzzled and perplexed by her sudden wheedling cries. "I'm not leaving, Kimmy," he said, low and plain. Calm. "I'm going back to the house. I don't want to be in here with you right now. In this prison. Sophie..." He pinched the bridge of his nose, pausing for a moment. "Sophie made me ice cream. I don't want her to think I forgot about her."

Chapter 10

Departure's Hour

They ate Sophie's homemade ice cream in awkward silence. The sounds of spoons clanking on pottery were too loud. Josh sat in the same spot where he'd first met his daughter, Hyun sat on the other side of the table, and Sophie sat with Josh, peppering him with questions, while Josh asked her again how she made such good ice cream. And Sophie would answer with amusing insight, telling her uncle how it was all in the quality of the ingredients, that there were no additives in her ice cream, only real cream and real candied walnuts her mom let her buy at the grocery store and how she put in real maple syrup, not that flavored corn syrup. Josh was playful with Sophie, but still somber. Kimmy felt in sympathy the hurting of Josh's stomach, the uneasiness he felt being reunited with the woman he believed had caused him the greatest harm in life.

The urge to express herself whole and heartily was sedated by the history of her harm. She would come on too strong; she would spook him; she would say the wrong thing; fuck, she would try to seduce him into bed with lurid talk of another man, like she used to.

But Josh had enjoyed those times. It wasn't her imagination.

Once Josh finished Sophie's ice cream she was convinced he would announce it was time for him to go home. She set her spoon down, unable to finish.

From the other room came the cries of a waking baby. Kimmy set her unfinished bowl on the table. Hyun moved like she would go, but Kimmy told her she would get her.

“She’s had a big day today. I thought she might sleep straight through.”

Hyun insisted. “Let me go. You sit with Josh.”

Kimmy said, “I think she might be hungry.” But Colleen wasn’t hungry. Just bored or restless. But if Hyun left her alone with Josh, Josh would take that opportunity to depart. He wouldn’t if she’d left the room; he would wait to see her again.

Wouldn’t he?

* * *

Kimmy left to take care of Colleen, and Josh set his empty bowl of ice cream down on the table near Kimmy’s. He said, “I have to say, Sophie. That was one of the finest ice creams I’ve ever had.”

Sophie beamed, and Hyun said, “And Josh has been to Italy.”

He smiled and said, “So, I know what I’m talking about. You, Sophie, have a talent for frozen desserts.”

Sophie went through a series of deflections, bashful, saying her mom helped her and how the machine did most of the work, but Josh persisted. “Thank you, Sophie. I enjoyed it immensely.”

She shrugged one teeny shoulder. “I know you like maple walnut.”

“Thank you for thinking of me,” he whispered.

Hyun said, “We should get these bowls in the dishwasher, Sophie. And it’s almost your bedtime.”

Sophie looked to her mother, then back to him, her face frozen in a slack sort of worry. She said to him, “Are you going to stay over?”

He smiled, held her arm. “Another time, Sophie.”

Sophie seemed undeterred, asking her mother if she could get them drinks. A heartbreaking distraction from a little girl living a disjointed life.

Why don't you stay, asshole? Your baby's here. Your wife is here.

Hyun said, "I'll have a green tea. Can you take the bowls and put them in the dishwasher, please?"

Sophie agreed and stacked the ice cream bowls on one another, all the spoons in the top bowl and then held them precariously at her waist, toddling out of the room. Hyun stayed seated.

Josh said, "She's so grown up now. She can load the dishwasher?"

"She doesn't do it at your place?"

"I guess we all just pitch in," he said, leaning forward, clasping his hands together, feeling uncomfortable alone with Hyun.

"I think you should stay."

Josh looked up and regarded Hyun. Hyun usually quiet and one to keep her opinion to herself. There was a certain disgruntlement evident in her gaze. Like maybe she didn't like Josh as much as she used to. And why the hell would she? Hyun sat in his place. Hyun had been with Kimmy when she gave birth. Hyun witnessed his disregard for Kimmy and his own baby, but without the knowledge of why.

"You do?"

"If you don't want to be here, you should go. But you're here. You're here for a reason, right?"

"Of course, I—"

"There's nothing for you at Meyer's."

Josh closed his mouth. "I know."

"There's everything for you here." Hyun checked over her shoulder before speaking again, as if wary of Sophie returning with green tea.

"You've been gone too long."

Josh rubbed his face and took a deep breath. He steadied his gaze on Hyun. "And how about you? How would you feel about that?"

“If you stayed over? Why would I care?” She stared at him steadily but her jaw muscles rippled as she clenched her teeth.

He thumbed over his shoulder, out the window behind him to the carriage house. “And what if I stayed here for good—stayed out in the apartment?”

Hyun looked away, troubled, pursing her lips. “What if she didn’t care about you?”

“What do you mean?”

“What if she didn’t want you here? How would you feel?”

“Not good.”

Hyun looked his way again. “What if Kimmy moved on without you?”

“It’s like she has.”

“It’s not like that at all. . . . Imagine a time where she stops trying so hard to win you back. I don’t think you would like that. I don’t think you’re willing to watch her move on without you. You just like punishing her.

“You think that’s what I’m doing?”

“What other purpose does it serve? I don’t see any reason a man would act like you are.”

“Maybe that’s the problem. Maybe you’re not seeing something.”

Hyun sighed and crossed her arms, checking over her shoulder once more to make sure Sophie wasn’t returning. “I know what she did to you. I know everything she did. I know that as much as you hate it, there was something in there that you liked. Or at least something you had Kimmy believing you liked.”

Josh stood abruptly, anger rising in his blood, looking to bolt. “And the money for a house like this? Where did she get the money? I don’t care how much Stone is paying her, this house is out of her budget.”

“Ask her yourself. Don’t ask me. For once in your life, confront her. Make her tell you what you want to hear.”

Did he hide from the truth? Did he let her get away with lie after lie, and in time she thought telling lies her husband wanted to hear was better than telling the truth?

Now Sophie was returning, with teacup on saucer, blocking the easy exit from the hallway. Hyun got his attention before he could consider fleeing from the room's other doorway, saying, "Kimmy punished herself Josh. I saw it. I held her hand through it."

"Hey, Sophie," he said, acknowledging his niece, arriving with an expression seeking praise for her dutiful nature. "You're allowed to use the kettle?" Steam rose from the teacup.

Sophie said, "We have a machine."

Hyun said, "She's allowed to use the Keurig."

Sophie set down her mother's tea and Hyun ran her hands over her daughter's shoulders, turning Sophie to face her. "Your Aunt Kimmy works very hard, doesn't she?"

Sophie nodded, confused but agreeable.

"She worked hard to make this home for your Uncle Josh to return to. She's done a lot to win him back."

Sophie agreed with this as well. Hyun circled her arms around Sophie and hugged her from behind, her chin in Sophie's collar. She said to Josh, "You should be flattered. I would be."

* * *

Kimmy wasn't in the other room, nor was Colleen. He paused at the crib. Empty, a blanket folded over the rail. A humidifier ran in the corner by a rocking chair, and the mobile above the crib still spun, geometric shapes in bright metal splintered the lamplight into sparkling reflections that danced on the walls.

He headed up the stairs, no one in the kitchen or in the office, up to the second floor, following the hall to the only room with a light on. Kimmy stood in the room at the end of the hall, the master bedroom, rubbing lotion on her wrists, looking at herself in the mirror. She acknowledged his presence as he leaned a shoulder on the door jamb, nodding his way but returning her attention to her reflection.

On the far side of the room, a small bundle kicked feet against the silk-case of a fuzzy pink blanket, obscured by the spindles of a white crib. A white noise generator set a low and peaceful fizz by the bedside.

He stepped into the room, circling behind her toward the crib. Photographs set in folding frames lined the dresser at his side. Black and white photos from their wedding. A photo of them together in color taken in Kingston when they were practically kids. Kimmy looked like a kid; so did he. He'd known her a long time.

Colleen mewled in her crib. He stood over her, watching her, those beautiful eyes closed, whatever disgruntlement had her complaining ceasing and she began to settle. He turned to Kimmy, her back to him, but aware of him, her eyes tracking him over her shoulder's reflection. Crossing the room to her seemed inexorable. She was tall and lean, her hair pulled back, working lotion between long fingers.

All of this could be his. This house was his. That beautiful baby was his. This gorgeous, cunning woman was his. How much, though, did he like playing with fire?

He kissed her neck, her head tilted aside, eyes closing. He loved kissing her here. Loved it. His hands caressed the robe's silk where it touched her hipbones.

"You smell amazing," he said, and she did; talcum and musk and sugar.

She smiled in the mirror, and something gave way inside him, something like wire or cord; a tether. Seeing her smile at his kiss so

honestly encouraged a swell of hope into his darkened heart. He hugged his cheek to her neck and held her for a long moment.

“What happened, Kimmy? What happened when you left me? You left *me*.”

“I left you because I love you.”

“I know. You said that. But what happened? You stayed away. You broke me and then you stayed away.”

“Because I was ashamed, Josh,” she whispered. Her nails stroked through his hair.

“You should have ended it.”

“I was pregnant with our baby. I didn’t want to end it.”

“You just needed time away? Did you think I would hurt less that way?”

She palmed his cheek, and he lifted his head, looking at her reflection. There was a lot unsaid in her shimmering eyes.

“What am I missing?”

“I was ashamed. Ashamed of the things you know I did.”

“Yeah?”

Her lips pursed, parted, then pursed again. At last she said, “And ashamed of the things you didn’t know.”

He stepped back, letting his touch fall from the silk, a hot and sick feeling tightening his belly. Those old blasts of betrayal battered his shields. His heart raced. Another step back; Kimmy turned to face him.

He said, “What don’t I know about?”

Kimmy looked down, lips slimming, biting them, then looked up. She said, “I stole money, Josh. A lot of money.”

Chapter 11

The Way That Runs Among the Lost

She continued. “I told myself it wasn’t stealing. I deemed it as *reallocation*.”

Josh was far behind enough she took it as proof he had heard no rumors beforehand. He frowned, brow crinkling in complete bewilderment. “Stole money from who? From me?”

He thought she’d meant the money she took from their account to buy a house. Not a heist. She’d told him. But that was the only thing Josh could conceive. Not what she’d *really* done.

“From Stone Brokerage,” she said. “From Devlin. Him specifically.”

Josh’s face went through elastic movement as he showed off an impressive range of contradicting emotions, rage through humor. Then put his hands on his hips, turned away, shaking his head. He faced her again, gesturing with jerky hands, wanting to know more, saying, “What are you *talking* about?”

“I took money, Josh. I took money from Stone.”

“You mean...”

“Money that wasn’t mine.”

Disgruntled Josh returned. Bothered Josh. Maybe there was something masculine about him when he did this that she secretly enjoyed. He rubbed

his brow and made that pained face. It was almost *paternal*. Like a bothered father. He was going to be a noble father. Colleen was a lucky girl.

But right now Josh had this other problem. This woman in his life who caused him much consternation and worry, but a woman he loved anyway, as much as he didn't want to sometimes. Josh had an enduring love. She wanted him to see it in her, too.

At last, he said, "Why? Why would you do that?"

"I don't even know," she said, shrugging a shoulder. "I never hoarded it or, or kept it. Not cash or anything. I diverted money Devlin had stolen himself, and—"

"Wait, Devlin stole money?"

"Again: *diverted*. He . . . he just copied some things his dad did. Moving money to avoid tax, moving it to shell corporations, and, and . . . the money goes to these corporations, stays a while, moves to another . . . I moved it to buy clothes and dinners and—"

Josh palmed his forehead, full realization coming to him. "That fucking suit you bought me."

"Yeah," she said, nodding.

Josh paced. She let him work out what he was feeling, gave him space. He said, "You would buy shoes, and I would know they were, like, a thousand dollars, and I would think that seems reckless. And then . . . Sometimes I would think I should stop you. That you were spending money you hadn't earned yet. But you know what? I trusted you. I . . . I always think you know what you're doing. I should have said something. I should have—"

"No, Josh. You're right. I knew you trusted me. I knew you wouldn't say anything about it."

"And if I did, you'd just talk circles around me."

She raised her eyebrows, an instinct to defend herself spiking up, but ultimately failing to launch, pulled earthward by the lies she'd spun around

the man she loved. "I would."

"I'd get mad you were spending our money and that the only reason you were even working at Stone was so we could afford a house." He paced again and Colleen grew agitated, sensing her father's perplexity. He stopped and looked at Colleen in her crib. "You were supposed to get in and get out, make enough money we could be halfway to owning a home."

"I know."

He braced himself on the crib's rail, hands gripping the wood. Colleen eased. "But it wasn't our money," he said.

"No."

"It was Devlin's." He turned. "And what was Devlin doing with it? Avoiding taxes?"

She chuckled. "He had his own accounts. In Cayman. His war chests, as he called them. He wanted to start his own company."

"Doing what?"

"Shipping."

Josh didn't get it. Just staring at the floor between them and shaking his head, not one to indulge in conspiracies of nefarious business behavior, not one to see far ahead into the schemes of the wicked.

"That's what his dad does," she said. "He wanted to take money out of Stone and start a competing boutique, handling some specific lines."

"Like illegal things? What?"

"No. That wasn't the plan. But I wouldn't put it past him. Land lines up into the north. Not terrible ideas, but he's just not the man who could do something like that."

It was too much for Josh to contemplate. And he didn't care, anyway. Didn't care about Devlin anymore. "You're telling me you were just Robin Hood? Is that how come you're not in jail?"

At the mention of the word *jail*, all that dread she'd experienced when she'd first split from Josh came rushing back. Her hand went to cover her

stomach. Some nights she'd cried thinking she would go to jail pregnant, or worse, that all her worry and suffering would end her pregnancy. That her own actions—her *sins*—would end her baby's life. That the punishment for what she'd done would be another miscarriage. She would roll on the bed clutching her belly praying and crying and swearing to God she would make things right. That she would never do wrong again.

"I'm not in jail because I made everything right."

"You gave the money back?"

She rubbed her brow now, acting like Josh. Josh thinking it was as simple as that. "No, I, uh, showed them what I'd done, and . . . they were more interested in, in..."

"Who's they?"

"Stone. The real Stone. His lawyer, some other executives. They..."

"You ratted Devlin out?"

She nodded. "Yes. I did."

Josh smirked and chuckled, though showing no humor in his eyes. She wasn't sure what amused him; Devlin's demise or his betraying wife's endless treachery.

She said, "It was the right thing."

Josh nodded, saying, "I guess." He turned away, stood over Colleen now.

Their daughter had fallen asleep during her mother's terrible confession. She shouldn't be so lucky as this: to admit all her wrongs from such a wonderful location; a warm room in a quiet house, shared with her husband and baby girl. But perhaps doing the right thing brought its own rewards.

"Devlin told me everything. He showed me how all of it worked."

"You ratted him out?"

"I did. His punishment will be severe and long-lasting."

Josh found no joy in that, staring empty-eyed at sleeping Colleen.

She said, “At some point, you know, diverting that money, I think I just wanted to hurt Devlin. I wanted to sabotage this thing I had going on. A good job, good pay. I never thought Devlin was a good person. I never liked him. Maybe I had a hopeful glimmer every so often that I was wrong and maybe we could work something out, you know...?”

Josh turned his head toward her. “Stay at Stone?”

“Do what we were doing. Which would mean you had to be willing to—”

“Suffer?”

“Yeah,” she whispered. “Then at some point I... I just wanted to hurt him. Really get him back.”

“For giving you a job?”

She turned to look at Josh, his expression stony and unconvinced by her virtuous retelling of the summer she’d done all the worst things imaginable and no one stopped her. “For offering me a job that was more than just a job. For offering me so much, for luring the darkest parts of me to the surface, wrangling that evil amphibian out of the water just so he could present it to you like a trophy.”

Josh said nothing, only cocked his head and showed her more stoniness.

“I know,” she said, voice soft and airy, unafraid to admit his unspoken accusation. “It was in me. I did those things. I did all of them. No one made me do them.”

Josh looked down again at Colleen, and she was happy to stand at his side and not say anything. He smiled, admiring eyes washing over his baby daughter.

He faced her then and held her neck, his hand warm, peaceful. “That’s why you’re still there?”

She leaned her head into his touch, loving his palm on her skin. “I showed them Devlin’s plan. Showed them why it wouldn’t work. Showed them how it could work.”

“Keith Stone’s not in love with you?”

“No. He’s divorced. He doesn’t really date. Not that I know of. . . . He’s not like how you’re thinking.”

“He’s not like Devlin?”

“No. He’s scary. He’s not all talk. . . . It’s long hours; it’s no fun. No fun at all. It’s nothing like it was before. Now it’s all work, no play, and it’s *hard*. The hours are long. Nothing is as glamorous as Devlin made it, but . . . the pay is good. The pay is great. I’m good at what I do.”

“And that’s kicking Devlin out of the nest. Taking his spot. Making *his* money.”

She didn’t react to Josh’s harshness. She said, “But I will *not* fuck it up like he did.”

Josh heaved himself off the crib, rubbing his head and walking away, back to the dresser, looking at his own reflection. “And I see this picture in the paper. You and Keith Stone.”

“Meyer said Steve sent it to you.”

Josh said, “The \$14,000 picture.”

“At least it got you to my door.”

Josh looked offended in his reflection. She joined him at the mirror, putting her hands on his shoulders, pressing her chin to his back. He said, “That’s what you think?”

“Am I wrong?”

“I should have been here before,” he said. “Did you pay Steve to send me that picture?”

Her eyes darted up to meet his in the mirror. He was joking, smirking to one side. “I knew you would come when you were ready,” she said. “And I would wait.”

“Your message made it all the way to Mexico,” he said. “I opened my phone, and I saw you had moved on, and anything I’d hoped for passed me by.”

She slunk her arms around him, hugged his shoulders harder. “It was business. I attended as his guest, not his date.”

“You weren’t wearing your wedding ring.”

“Of course not. I wouldn’t want anyone to think I was married to him. I had no idea anyone would take my picture—”

“It was right out front of the venue. It was an event where they take pictures. It’s the whole point of going.”

“I had no idea the paper would print *my* picture.”

“You looked incredible.”

“Thank you,” she said. “I’m sorry you saw it. I’m sorry it upset you. I’m sorry it ruined your trip.”

“It didn’t. Meyer just says that. I bitched and moaned the whole morning and maybe I bitched at him, too. We squabbled. He was mad at me. Then he goes over the handlebars and he blames me.”

“He’s only joking.”

“I know, Kimmy. I know.”

“You had to end your trip, sell the bikes . . . I know all about it.”

“It was an adventure,” he said.

“You needed an adventure.” She pressed her cheek to his collar, and he held her wrist.

They stayed like that and the moment was long and peaceful before Josh said, “Keith Stone didn’t give you money for the house?”

She let him go, amused by Josh’s attachment to male involvement in her affairs, but disappointed that there were things he wouldn’t let go. She’d done it to him, yes, but he did it to himself, too. She stepped back and sat on the bed, and Josh turned to face her.

“No, Josh. Keith Stone has nothing to do with our house.”

He huffed a breath, looked around the room, brow pinched. “Then how the hell can you afford a place like this? How much is Keith Stone paying you?”

Chapter 12

Let Them Wait Here

Kimmy scratched her neck, stalling before she would answer. It was too good to be true anyway, that his wife had done so much to bait his return when he should have run to the hills and never stopped after her betrayal. He stepped away, lured now by the real bait that had bargained his return. Colleen slept in the crib by the bed, where he should lay his head every night. Kimmy turned her head to follow him, then sat on the bed, crossing her legs.

“We had a lot saved,” she said.

“I know how much we had,” he said, then lifted Colleen from the crib mattress and held her to his chest. Those darling eyes opened and scanned his for a second. Then she screwed up her face. She didn’t cry, though, and he assumed she liked him. “And it wouldn’t be enough to get a loan for a house half this value.”

“And then, uh, I had a bonus from Stone.”

“A bonus?” He turned with Colleen in his arms, and Kimmy smiled at the sight.

“The money I took from Devlin was his father’s money. I reallocated from Devlin’s theft. I, I convinced Keith I’d done it on purpose.”

“Why would you do something like that on purpose?”

“To send up a distress call, you know, a smoke signal.”

“And he believed you?”

Kimmy bowed her head, played with the lapel of her robe. She was a liar. A weaver of webs. And she’d done it again to get out of the theft. Maybe she’d worked Keith Stone in circles like she’d done to her husband.

She said, “I had to convince them I wasn’t doing it to test the system before I stole a much larger sum of money. But since I took quite a bit, and I could account for what I’d spent, and it was all on work-related, well, *luxuries* . . . Anyway, in time, yes, he believed me.”

“How much did you take?”

“A lot, Josh.”

“A million dollars?”

“God, no, Josh. No, it wasn’t like that. It was, it was 75k.”

Josh braced Colleen and reeled. That was a serious crime. A felony amount. Worse than that. “How are you not in jail, Kimmy?”

“I did it in the open. It wasn’t a secret, really. Sometimes I thought Devlin knew I was doing it and didn’t care. He loved doing *wrong* things.”

“They gave you a bonus? You *stole* from them.”

“A bonus minus the 75k,” she admitted, showing an expression acknowledging they were right to hold it back.

“You stole from them. They hired you. They fired Devlin—Keith’s own son. And they pay you well.”

“It didn’t fall in my lap, Josh. I did the wrong things. Very wrong. And for a while I was pretty sure I would give birth to that little bundle”—she nodded to Colleen, held in his arms—“behind bars. But I worked my ass off to make it right with Stone. I worked my ass off to make it right with you, too. I did it all for you. All for us.” She nodded to Colleen again, smiling this time. “I want us to be together. It’s the only thing I want in life.”

He sighed at the weight of her words. All the things a man like him would want to hear. But trust was something he could never afford with Kimmy again. He’d surrendered trust to her when they married, and she’d

done the worst things imaginable. He could never be vulnerable with her again. He came to the bed with their baby and sat at the edge, Kimmy near the center, cross-legged and surrounded by the shimmering folds of her robe.

“So a bonus got you the house?”

She didn’t answer, and he turned his attention from Colleen to her. She shook her head no.

“No?”

“It wasn’t that much money. But it helped. And, uh, I, um, I got help elsewhere.”

Whatever it was, it bothered her. But this time he didn’t jump to the conclusion she was on her back for the money. That wasn’t her. She didn’t fuck Devlin for money; she fucked him for the dark thrill. And Kimmy here tonight didn’t seem like the same woman pleased by dark thrills. He asked her where she got help.

Now she compressed, taking the robe’s lapel and tightening it around her collar, drawing up her knees. “I wanted a house for us. Not just any house, but a house of our dreams. You know?”

He nodded and waited for her to continue.

She exhaled, long and drawn out, taking her time with this. “And to make it right with us, um, I couldn’t have lies, you know, surrounding us. Where we have to pretend certain things when we’re with friends and family. So, uh, I went to my, to my dad.”

He frowned with sharp disbelief. “You *told* him?”

She raised her eyebrows, gaze cast out long across the room. “I did. Not everything, Josh. But I confessed to him. Told him what I’d done.”

“The money?” He tried to picture her father hearing she was a thief.

She crinkled her brow, like his remark surprised her. “No. No, not that. That was just business. I sorted that out.”

They stared at each other and both could acknowledge their disconnected perspectives. But Kimmy defended herself no further. “I told him I’d been unfaithful, and that we split up and that I was pregnant, but I had ruined my marriage.”

“Was that when he stopped talking to me?”

“I don’t know, Josh. But listen, he *loves* you. He thinks you’re better than me. I broke his heart, Josh. He wants us to be together.”

“He bought the house?”

“No. No, it’s not like that.”

“Then tell me.”

“I told my dad what I did. I even told my sister. I wanted them to know. I failed.” She shrugged, smirking a wounded smile, taking some enjoyment in her ability to admit her defeat. “I failed but I’m going to make everything better. I had enough for a down payment and my future earnings are good. But the job is new, and the bank didn’t think I, uh, qualify.”

“So your dad did what? Gave you money?”

“No, just cosigned. No money. It’s not his house, Josh. It’s our house.”

Now her smile seemed purer, and she leaned closer so they could both look at Colleen’s sleeping face.

“You could have bought another house on your own—a less impressive one.”

She looked up at him. “Yeah. I could have.”

“Why here?”

“For you. I want us to have everything. I want our daughter to have everything. I want family.”

Colleen opened one eye, gurgled, then fidgeted into a more comfortable position. He carried her off the bed and returned her to her crib without rousing her. She settled, and he watched her for a moment before turning back to face his wife, sitting like a queen on their bed. “It’s all too perfect,” he said.

Kimmy looked disappointed and rubbed a shin under her robe.

He said, “I feel like I’m missing something.”

“Ask me, Josh, and I’ll tell you the truth.”

He rubbed a hand through his hair, knowing he was missing something, but not trusting he had the mind to track it down. He said, “Your dad, he just, what, accepted what you’d done? What you’d told him you’d done?”

“Well, he’s very angry with me. Worse.” She looked around, then sighed. “He’s disappointed. But he loves you. And he loves me. And my *god*, he loves Colleen.”

Josh rubbed the back of his neck, but came up with nothing. He shook his head. “I just still don’t understand how you ended up with everything.”

“I didn’t, Josh. I didn’t end up with everything.”

“Look at all you have.”

“When I convince you to stay, *then* I’ll have everything. And so would you.” She smiled again, showing much affection and hope.

He came to the bed, knelt on the mattress, then sat across from her. “If you had me, then you would have everything. Is it because you want me or is it because without me you can’t hold your head high, you can’t be proud of your daughter in front of people who know you, because they’ll always think in the back of their head that the baby is Devlin’s?”

It injured her, hearing claims like that again from her husband’s mouth, but she took a breath and nodded, reached for his hands. He gave them to her. “I want you, Josh. And no one would think that. Just look at her. She’s as sweet and innocent as you are.”

They stared into each other’s eyes for a while. So much of what she said seemed true. And if it were true, this was a personal triumph. For your wife to see her badness and her betrayal and concoct the grandest gesture for her husband’s return. Doing everything right and by the book. All for him. All for his return.

He leaned closer, and she did too, coming together until their heads touched. He smoothed hands over her shoulders. Their mouths grazed, and this time, he wanted her. Wanted her back, wanted to return, wanted every gift she'd arranged for him. He kissed her slowly, and her lips trembled against his own. She touched his face, her fingertips going through his beard again. It felt so good to have her mouth on his. To touch her shoulders and to have her touch him.

But an unstoppable nagging distraction waved in his periphery. This was Kimmy doing her thing again. Ask me anything and I'll tell you, Josh. Knowing her simple husband wouldn't have the nefarious mind to ask the right question. The right question for him to ask her would be: *will you tell me the thing you don't want to tell me?*

Their kiss broke, and she smiled, loving eyes looking deep into his. He let go of her shoulders and sat back.

She said, "That was nice. I've missed that so much."

Colleen coughed and murmured, then mewed a little, but she settled. They both regarded the crib, waiting to see if their daughter would need help. She returned to slumber.

Tales of stolen money, of subterfuge, of high-level corporate gamesmanship; betrayal, wickedness, infidelity, humiliation. His wife *humiliated* him. His *bully* humiliated him. They'd worked together to do it. He'd broken his brain. He'd had a daughter and never came to see her. He suffered panic attacks. He rode a motorcycle down to Mexico and bought himself a leather jacket. And now they were together again. In a beautiful home with a beautiful baby. And no one punished Kimmy Chang. Not even when she stole \$75,000. It was like she was untouchable.

He regarded Kimmy, then looked to the crib. Back to Kimmy. Kimmy rested her fingertips on his kneecaps in gentle claws.

He closed his eyes and groaned. Something slithered in his viscera, a creature from another time one year ago. "Oh no," he sighed.

“What?”

He looked at her with her mock concern, her pretty face showing innocent puzzlement, her delicate brow showing the tiniest crinkle.

He said, “Does Keith Stone think Colleen’s his granddaughter?”

Chapter 13

The Quiet Shade of Verdant Groves

He knew her answer before she spoke it. The way she paused, held her tongue for as long as she could—all the familiar traits of his deceptive wife. The stalling was a sign. Betrayal still sung in her choir. But at least he could detect it now. Whatever charm she'd had over him before had waned; he was no longer so eager to lap milk at her feet, to seek equilibrium and acquiesce to insanity in order to establish it. Before she spoke, he smiled.

Kimmy saw his smile, and guilt and shame burned on her cheeks. She lowered her head and closed her eyes. "I never told him so, but he may think it. Yes."

At last, some dam upstream broke, and floodwaters swelled his riverbanks. He covered his mouth with a hand to stifle...

Stifle what?

Laughter came. Real honest-to-god laughter. Totally and completely unexpected. And the more he held his hand against its swell the more the laughter's flux taxed the restraint. He blurted air around his hand and could no longer contain it.

Kimmy showed pure offense. Kimmy showed the expression of an insulted aristocrat. Now he laughed hard enough he bent at the waist and put his hands on his knees.

But as quickly as it came, it subsided; like a quick summer rain swamping runoff over sun-baked earth until the beaten land remembers how to drink it down. He regained his composure and stood upright again, Kimmy still offended but subdued. Colleen woke and babbled, and he wiped his eyes.

Kimmy regarded him, beginning to accept the deserved reaction. Colleen's babbling became another sound. Laughter. Kimmy said, "At least we know somebody likes your laugh."

He looked over at his daughter in her crib, awake now and happy, kicking legs and moving arms, making a sort of rolling reedy chuckle in a manner mimicking her father's. Now he laughed again, but small and quiet; more the sound of someone in awe. He said, "She's got my laugh."

"Don't rub it in," Kimmy said.

Josh turned again and hefted the little pink-swaddled bundle into his arms. "I guess she doesn't want to sleep. Is she hungry?"

"No, not now. Maybe just curious. She hears us talking."

"She's never heard that before." He returned to the bed with her in his arms, lively and wriggling, her squirming body surprisingly strong. He bounced at the knees lightly, rocking her in his arms. When he looked up, he saw Kimmy watching them, her eyes wet. She smirked and blinked, looked away and wiped her eyes. It swelled his heart to see the happiness he and his daughter would give her. He twirled with Colleen, and Colleen liked it, squealing and gurgling, and he made baby sounds at her, still rocking and bobbing, then sat with her on the bed beside Kimmy again. He kissed Colleen's brow.

He said, "You're going to let that man think something so awful?"

Kimmy said, "Keith believes it's possible but he's never asked me outright. He's afraid of the answer. . . . It benefits me for him to think it."

"So you let him."

"So . . . I let him."

He said, “What about me?”

Her lips slimmed, and she nodded. “I know. She’s yours. You want everyone in the world to know she’s yours.”

He admired his giggling daughter for a while longer. He said, “I don’t know what to do, Kimmy.”

“Talk to me. Tell me what you’re thinking.”

He sighed and hesitated, knowing it was all so tiresome now, and despite the pain of the past and the promise of the present, the future seemed so unclear; a point of stasis, a point of balance on a beam, where lost footing could produce the pain of the before or the promised hope of the present’s thereafter. He said, “It’s all so small and far away. When I think of *him*—and I don’t—the lasting image of him isn’t as some asshole jock bully, it’s him on his hands and knees, crawling around on the floor after I hit him with a chair.”

“I’m so glad for that,” Kimmy whispered.

“And Rumble, too. Why did I ever waste my time worrying about any of them? They’re sad. Pathetic. Useless! So far away from who I am or who I want to be. Or anyone I would want to associate with.”

“That’s so good you think like that, Josh,” she said, leaning closer like she might touch his hand or his arm or Colleen.

He said, “It’s you I’m afraid of. You’re the reason I stayed away so long.”

Kimmy retreated with a hefty sigh and gathered the satiny fabric around her legs. Her chin turned down and her brows bowed in glum arrows.

“I’m sorry,” he said. But facts were facts.

“Don’t be sorry,” she said. “I don’t deserve it. I don’t even deserve you being here tonight.” She looked up, eyes wet again, brows still straining to support the weight of her emotion. “I want a chance. That’s all. I want a chance to prove myself to you. I want you to let me try.”

They regarded each other for a long moment, their daughter gurgling, making noises like she'd like them all to get that laugh going again if they could because laughing was fun. And, fuck, what Kimmy asked was reasonable. And what she'd done in preparation for the request was noble and honest. And difficult. She'd fought jail, she'd fought Devlin, she'd fought with Keith Stone. Done it until she got her way. Done it until she had everything she wanted. But the ultimate prize was Josh Waters. And god damn it that was starting to feel really good. He looked around the room again. This could be his bedroom. This baby was his. That wasn't going to change. But this beautiful woman, as frightening as she may be, could be his, too. If it were up to her, the deal was done. She'd pass him a pen right now and he could sign his name on the bottom line.

This *was* the place where he should be.

"I don't want to stay in the garage," he said. "If I stay."

"You don't have to."

"Why did you offer that first?"

Kimmy considered it, lips moving around, trying to form how she'd phrase it. "I don't want to be presumptuous. I didn't . . . I didn't want to scare you off."

Josh closed his eyes, trying to conjure in his imagination a bright and happy future. It was easy to grab referential pieces of his past to paint the picture; there'd been the happiest times with Kimmy. But there was the black veil of betrayal dimming the light from those golden memories.

He said, "Uh-oh."

Kimmy said, "What?"

"I think she might have just pooped. I felt it on my arm."

Then there was no need for further consideration; the smell revealed the truth.

"Oh, yes, she did," Kimmy said. "Pass her to me. I'll go change her."

Josh withheld Colleen, hesitating, unsure. "Uh, maybe, I could..."

“You *want* to?”

He said, “I do.”

Kimmy smiled and gestured toward the bedroom door. “Be my guest. Everything you need is in the bathroom, first door on the left, opposite side of the hall.”

Josh admired Colleen, aggravated by whatever had messed up the comfort of her diaper, scrunching up her pretty face and getting ready to complain. Kimmy asked him if he’d like some help and he told her he’d be okay.

“I’ll figure it out.”

* * *

Josh returned with Colleen, grinning, Colleen babbling softly, wearing a new onesie under her blanket. She asked him how it went.

“I wasn’t prepared for that,” he said, returning Colleen to her crib.

She covered her mouth with a hand, watching Josh get their daughter settled. He stood over the crib, hands on hips, still grinning. She said, “It’s surprising sometimes.”

“The diaper?” Josh turned to the bed. “Yeah. It was crazy. I had to bath her a little. Is that going to be a problem?”

“With her sleep? No. She’ll settle.”

They stared at each other again, but this time the barrier that had existed between them softened. Josh’s humiliating laughter had changed something. Once he’d laughed, it looked like it might come a lot easier the second time. And though she’d been angry at first, tension had eased in the time she’d sat in the room alone listening to Josh in the bathroom, hearing the water running, knowing he would take his time and get to know the many moods of Colleen. And love them all.

“I’d like you to stay,” she said. “We can . . . We can talk in the morning. Have some breakfast. You don’t have to take the apartment. We have one more guest room. It has a pullout.” *But it would be so much better if you accepted my bed.*

Josh’s lips slimmed and he showed a graver expression. “I had Colleen in the bath, and I was thinking...”

“Go on.”

He sat on the bed with her again. “You were worse than him. You know that?”

“I do. Of course.”

You were worse than all of them. You were supposed to be on my side.”

“I know.”

“You’re just like them. You’re no different.”

She exhaled a wounded sound. “I, uh, yeah. But I’m not. I *was*. I was for a while. But . . . I saw myself in them. I saw myself in them and that’s what broke me. Broke my spell. Shook me awake.” She shook her head and looked around. “Everything here, everything I’ve acquired is all the reason I did it. They’re not things. You know that, right? I don’t mean I did it all for some stuff. I did it to provide. I would do whatever it took. Maybe it was because after we lost our first . . . I would do anything to make a family, like the ultimate lashing out for a nest. I wanted everything Devlin had. He didn’t deserve it. *We* deserved it. I wanted to take a piece of it. I wanted to take *all* of it. But I wanted it for us. And for some *possibility* that’s now alive and slowly getting sleepy in her crib.” She looked aside to Colleen, legs still kicking gently, but her babbling gone away.

She looked back at somber Josh, lips plump and misaligned, eyes turned down but still aware of her, staring at her lap. “The depravity I *could* have sunk to with Devlin was bottomless. What we did might only have been the tip of the iceberg. Maybe, just maybe, your reluctance saved me.”

Josh grunted and looked up, soured by thinking of the awful things he knew she'd done with Devlin Stone. He leaned to the side then, putting his legs out, shifting so his head lay on the pillow. Laying on her bed in jeans and a sweater, his shirt collar disappearing under his beard. He looked up at the ceiling. She lay down next to him, putting her head on a pillow and laying on her side. Her hand crested his woolen shoulder.

“It would be too easy to think that.”

“There's truth in it,” she said.

Josh closed his eyes. She said, “I saw myself in them—Devlin and Amy—and I hated what I saw. I finally hated myself. That's why I left. I saw Amy for what she really was. Dumb. Privileged. And all the trimmings amounted to nothing. Shoes, clothes, trips. All the affectation of big business. And the *depravity*. A whole wardrobe just for depravity, something in every style and color.”

Josh's eyes stayed closed. He said nothing for a moment, then, “I just want to go to sleep.”

She smiled and her breaths went shaky. Maybe he would stay. Her cheek slipped down the pillow until her chin touched his shoulder; her hand still caressed his arm.

Chapter 14

A Thousand Voices and an Effigy

He stayed overnight. Then he stayed every night for a week.

On the first Sunday, he'd gone back to his apartment and packed a few things, telling Meyer he didn't know what he was going to do yet, but he was in love with his baby and he had a lot of lost time to make up for. Meyer'd asked what about Kimmy, and he'd took a deep breath and held it. He didn't know. He'd said, "I want to be in that house with my daughter." If living with his daughter meant living with Kimmy, that's what he would do. So despite only packing a single bag for the next week, it was kind of unsaid between him and his patient cousin that their roommate love affair would now end. No more late-night movie binges, no more video games to the dawn's early light, no more cracking beers and shooting the shit. Meyer would be all alone again. It was too bad things hadn't worked out with that girl Quinn. Josh had really liked her.

Josh bid Meyer farewell, and although they both knew they'd see each other all the time, the last six months with Meyer had preserved Josh's sanity, and he hoped he'd been good company for Meyer.

He stayed with Kimmy in Kimmy's house, bought for them. His house. He stayed in Kimmy's bedroom. His bedroom. They went to work, and they came home and they had dinner with Hyun and Sophie and Colleen. They watched TV together. All of them. Having the larger group in his house

made the transition of living with Kimmy once again a little easier. There hadn't been much pressure on having things to say or working things out anymore. There were chores and there was a baby and there was always something to do. Then they went to bed together and went to sleep.

They weren't intimate during the week, though he'd considered it twice. That changed on Friday.

* * *

On Friday, Josh went home early from work. The first week back at Swanson had been a wild success. He'd come back home to the gang at Swanson and found them exactly where a guy like himself would want them: missing Josh Waters and needing his return, and the return of his expertise. At lunch on Monday, Harjeet ordered pizza for a lunchtime party, welcoming his return. And the best part of his return was how it felt right. He returned to Swanson healed. It would take some time to figure out how it happened. One thing was for sure, coming home from work every day to a beautiful home in Unionville and his wife and his incredible baby certainly aligned all the facets of his broken psyche. Nothing about it felt wrong.

Since he'd come home early, it meant he could care for Colleen and Hyun could spend time with Sophie before she delivered her to Meyer for the week. And Hyun had an evening class tonight. Josh had thought about it a lot. Last night trying to sleep and today at work. Tonight would be the first time he and Kimmy had an evening together. Just the three of them.

Hyun took Sophie out for dinner and would head to class after she dropped Sophie at Meyer's, so Josh said his goodbyes to Sophie and told her to say hi to his dad. Hyun and Sophie left.

Now it was him and his baby.

He fed Colleen in the kitchen, still wearing his suit pants, the jacket and tie off. Putting her on a high chair like his dad had done with him. Breast milk was in the fridge, and he warmed the bottle in a saucepan, bringing it to body heat temperature. After she was fed, he walked around the main floor with his daughter, looking out all the windows with her, telling her how leaves changed color and they fell from the trees but that they returned the next spring, better than ever. Then it was upstairs for a nappy exchange, getting her into clean diapers, and taking her to the crib so he could get in the shower and clean himself up.

In the shower, his mind wandered to the evening ahead. It was him and it was his wife and it was their baby. A real family. It was exciting.

And another thing: they would have sex tonight. He and Kimmy would re-engage in the intimate arts. He could feel it in his bones. One bone in particular, already responding, preparing for the duties ahead.

Only thing was, the more he thought of being with Kimmy, the more frightened he became. Not scared of the Kimmy of old, but scared to reunite with the Kimmy of before. The mild-mannered one. The kind one. The one he married. That Kimmy made him feel uncomfortable now. He wouldn't know how to act with that one. The Kimmy who'd set him on fire last year and burned him to a crisp...? Now that one excited him. He knew how to behave with that one. That Kimmy took the lead and told him to do what she wanted. Lied to him when they both deep down knew she was lying. That was the Kimmy he wanted to have sex with.

But that was something he knew to keep to himself.

* * *

Out of the shower, he found Colleen awake and babbling, and he went to her, lifted her and took her downstairs, brought her to the room with the window to the garden. She played for a while, taking things he handed to

her and studied them or tossed them aside for some new object for perusal. He could get her to giggle by making the right face. And sometimes when she wouldn't giggle at a face he made, he could get her to giggle with a tickle. It was cheating, but he liked the sound of her giggle. When he exhausted her, she fell asleep sitting up, then teetered to the side, like a sawn tree. He called out *Timber* and held her before she toppled. Then he took her to the side room with the main floor crib and set her in for a nap. It was past four, and Kimmy would be home in an hour or two. He could nap as well, sit down in the chair where Kimmy would feed Colleen, and drift off. In his own home. With his baby at his side.

But sleep never came. He dwelled on thoughts of reignited intimacy. It worried him now that the time was closing in. The TV watching would be easy. Making and eating dinner, also easy. But intimacy?

The idea unnerved him. The discomfort intimidated him.

When she'd tried to engage him, seduce him practically, in the garage apartment, he'd almost crawled out of his skin. Was it that Kimmy showed weakness? A weak Kimmy didn't interest him. Not when he knew it was all an act. Maybe that was it. Dishonesty in intimacy.

Then, before he contemplated it, he was checking to make sure Colleen still napped, then sneaking back upstairs to the master bedroom. He slowed, hesitated, as the truth of his sudden quest dawned on him. But why deny it?

His finger tried along the edge of Kimmy's dresser, going to the top drawer on the left. The one where she stored her underwear. Her panties.

Sexy things? Lacy stuff? He opened the drawer to find a disappointing array of underwear that looked to be based on comfort over sex appeal. All of Kimmy's underthings were folded in small, tight rectangles, stuffed in neat piles along the Y-axis so she could index through them and find what she was looking for.

And what are you looking for, Josh?

A pair of green satin things. Panties she'd worn to a tryst with one well-hung sexual dynamo named Devlin Stone.

His riffling fingers found no trace of the panties he sought. He pulled the drawer out further. Still no sign of his prize.

And that had to be for the best. Wasn't it?

There was a box at the back of the drawer and he was pretty sure he'd hit pay dirt. This box would contain her more impressive undergarments. But as he wriggled it out of its nest at the back of the drawer, he could tell it didn't contain underwear. Too heavy. And by the sound of it, the box contained only one thing sliding around inside. The box was long, like a box sent with flowers. Maybe Keith Stone secretly sent her flowers. Maybe she liked them and kept them preserved as a memento in the back of her underwear drawer.

But again: the box was too heavy.

He placed the box on the dresser's top and lifted its lid. The item inside shortened his breath. He gasped, horrified. Revulsed.

Inside the box lay dormant an enormous rubbery dildo; flesh colored, molded sack. It had to be ten inches long. A thick, veiny monster that resembled the thing that Devlin had between his legs. The thing Kimmy loved. He shoved the box away to the far side of the dresser, then with gritted teeth and angry movements, he covered the disgusting phallic effigy and shoved it in the drawer where he found it.

* * *

The discovery aroused him. As much as he hated it, sitting by himself in the window room with his arms crossed and muttering to himself, the arousal was real. Now tonight couldn't get started fast enough. But with heightened arousal came heightened wariness.

Yes, he was aroused—but now had convinced himself Kimmy had left the grotesque dildo there for him to find in order to spark his arousal. When he was aroused, Kimmy was in charge and he couldn't lift a finger to stop her. And that was his own doing.

There was one piece of his jumbled puzzle to set back in place. A thing he always shooed away or wandered around. There was no denying how it still turned him on. Not the betrayal. No way, not that. The things she did to hide her betrayal. Those fun times he thought there was a game going on, and Josh and Kimmy Waters were the only players. Those times where the things Kimmy told him were tabulations meant for a shared thrill. A husband and a wife figuring out what made each other's darker parts tick. A thick, veiny cock about a foot long; a cock that would touch a hidden trigger, a place only whispered of in hushed tones among the mere mortals. Most of them not even believing such a place existed. But, oh yes, it existed. It did, at least, within his wife. It existed inside Kimmy. And she needed the thing in the drawer to get that itch scratched. But did she think of Devlin when she used it to make herself come? This last year, when they were apart, why would she masturbate with a huge dildo thinking of her husband? No, she would think of the man who gave her the real thing. Then maybe later, when her heart rate came back down to normal and she wished she had more help with the baby, then she would think of Josh. Her husband.

He heard her car arrive in their driveway.

Chapter 15

Dim Suffusion Veiled

She arrived home on a Friday night, stomach knotted with dread. There was a chance for a good evening with Josh, but uncertainty gnawed away. Hyun was gone for the night, taking Sophie with her and dropping her off with her father. Then a night class. She and Josh would be alone tonight for the first time. Intimacy would occur.

Should occur.

And what if it didn't?

Josh rejected her advances. Although they'd been subtle—perhaps Josh required stronger prompting.

Out of the car, crisp evening air nipping at her cheeks, she approached the front door and pushed it open. The house greeted her with warmth and welcome. So many times when she'd done the worst things with Devlin Stone, she'd told herself—and told Josh—that a family home like this was why she worked for Devlin. And that was where they ended up. Where she'd intended all along.

Josh sat in the main floor baby's room, beside Colleen's crib. Colleen slept peacefully. The sight of her husband and their baby, bathed in a soft glow, sent a swell of contentment through her. She leaned on the doorframe, smiling. It had been a good week, having Josh back in her life. Josh was

sensitive, brittle even, and she worried about handling him with the care he needed. She couldn't bear the thought of breaking him again.

"Hey," Josh said, voice quiet. "How was your day?"

"Tiring," she told him. "But I've been looking forward to tonight all week."

Hurt still lingered in Josh's eyes. She loved him, and she was willing to do *anything* to make this work again. It had been so good for so long.

"I'm going to go get out of these work clothes," she said, pushing off the doorframe. "Put something more comfortable on." With one last glance at Josh and Colleen, she turned and headed to the stairs. She stopped and called back, "Do you want to order in?"

Josh called back that he did. That encouraged her. This week had been wonderful, but with Hyun here, it wasn't like the way her and Josh's life had been like before Devlin Stone re-entered their lives.

Once in the bedroom, she slipped off her suit and hung it up, untied her hair, and removed her shirt and threw it in the laundry hamper. In the bathroom she brushed her teeth and rinsed with Scope, but was too exhausted for a shower. There was a chance nothing would happen between her and Josh tonight. She unhooked her bra, breasts tender and full. She'd pump before dinner.

Then she caught sight of herself in the mirror, a stark contrast to the woman she used to be. Stoop-shouldered, eyes heavy with fatigue, hair disheveled—a far cry from the polished, killer woman who would have been stepping out for a night of whiskey and laughter at the Royal York a little over a year ago. But that life, as thrilling as it had been, held no substance. This—the sore back, the aching head, the desperate need for a pumping session—this was real. She wouldn't trade this for anything.

A fresh swipe of deodorant, then she slipped into her silk robe. She tugged open her underwear drawer, looking for a fresh pair, and recognized

right away that someone had been through her underthings. Someone looking for a green satin pair, she was sure.

She slipped off the robe and the panties she wore all day and ran the hot water for a quick shower. Tonight would be the night Josh returned to her.

* * *

Josh was in the kitchen when Kimmy returned about a half an hour later. Obviously showered, wearing that long silk robe. She looked revived; she hadn't seemed so lively when she'd first come home, but now she moved with a renewed fluid grace, swishing into the kitchen and coming right to him. She touched his shoulder as she reached for the fridge, saying, "What did you order?"

He turned to regard her, now no longer touching his shoulder, pulling out a bottle of mineral water. He said, "I didn't order anything. I don't know any of the restaurants around here. I don't know what you like. What's good?"

Kimmy pulled down a glass from the cupboard and came to the island next to him, setting both items down on the counter with a heavy knock. She sighed and pondered. She said, "Do you want Chinese?"

"Sure," he said. "Whatever's good." His eyes stayed on her, studying her. She hadn't washed her hair, but she'd brushed it while it was damp. Though it was long and she still sported bangs, the hair at the sides of her head swept around her ears. She had a long, beautiful neck, and he loved her jawline. He reached out and touched it, running his thumb from the edge of her chin to just underneath her ear. Kimmy covered his hand with hers and regarded him. They stared at one another for a long moment without saying anything, and for the first time this week back with her, he felt a little like in those days between the miscarriage and the high school reunion where his wife had messed around with Devlin Stone. That wasn't

a perfect segment of time, but he'd loved her in it; the miscarriage had changed their relationship. It had made them—or at least *him*—wary of the other. For the first time, he'd felt unsure of their future. He'd forgotten about that because that feeling had become insignificant about eight weeks later when he'd begun suspecting something was going on behind his back.

Kimmy inched closer and closed her eyes, lowering them first and regarding his mouth. He kissed her and held her neck. When their kiss broke, she said, "Get me the phone. I know what to order."

* * *

Kimmy ordered from a Chinese restaurant in Unionville. The menu was in Chinese and she spoke the order to the restaurant in Chinese. They ate dinner—amazing jelly fish and shredded turnip, and soy-stewed egg and salted duck—then cleaned up and watched TV. They brought Colleen out to the family room and Kimmy watched while he showed Colleen toys and played with her and got her on her feet by holding her hands.

And in that moment, with the sun gone from the sky, leaving just yellow trees against a sky like dark denim, there was sacred beauty. Kimmy sitting and watching him, looking incredible with her hair framed around her face, no makeup; a mother. A working mother. A woman that had done terrible things to him. But a woman that had done hard things to earn him back. And he deserved all of this. He deserved the home; he deserved his baby, and he deserved Kimmy. Kimmy was a product of his own machination. The things he had done made Kimmy who she was. He'd considered Kimmy quite a bit this afternoon, sitting here with their daughter and waiting for her to get home from work. He'd tried last year making her into something he desired. He tried, and she'd played along. But the whole time, the worst things she'd told him in fantasy were true. She'd done them behind his back. They'd played with some of the darkest fantasies he could

imagine, and they'd been incredible. Kimmy made them real. And when they were shown to him as real, he'd rejected it. He'd even run away thinking he would never return. And if it weren't for this baby daughter whose tiny little hands gripped both his index fingers, maybe he never would have come back. What was certain to him was how much the fantasy had played in his mind. How much power those fantasies had. And who was responsible? Josh Waters was. Josh Waters was his own worst enemy. Kimmy had said it many times, and it was true. Kimmy was evil and wicked, and she'd betrayed him—but he'd framed the playground they'd played in. He'd given Kimmy the ingredients, and she'd cooked the meal he'd asked for. The one she'd already been cooking.

He lifted Colleen now and held her. He said to Kimmy, "I'm going to stay. I'm going to stay here in the house with you."

Kimmy nodded, slow and unemotional at first, then her eyes welled and she moved to the side table and snatched up a tissue to blot them.

He said, "I'd be crazy not to," then looked down at Colleen, so in love with her. Yes, she had his mother's eyes, but she had Kimmy's cheekbones; she had Kimmy's mouth, had her smile.

When Kimmy spoke, her voice was shaky and unsure. "I want you here, Josh. I want you here with me so badly. I'd do anything to have you here."

"I know you would," he said, and thought of the toy she'd set up where she knew he'd look. That was on him. His first reaction was anger at her manipulation, but sitting in the house she'd bought for them with his daughter in his lap, his righteous indignation paled.

Kimmy slipped off the couch and sat on the floor, scooting to close her arms and legs around him, their daughter in his arms. "I love you, Josh. I love you so much. I'll never betray you again. I'd die before I did it."

He didn't know what to say, but he liked hearing the words. His lips slimmed, and he nodded along with her words.

She said, “I’m sorry, Josh. I’m sorry for the lies and all the bad things I did to you. I loved you the whole time I did it, but that changes nothing. You didn’t deserve that. And I don’t deserve you here with me after what I did.”

No, she didn’t, but she’d sacrificed a lot to prove herself to him. It would have been so much easier for her to move on without him. It would have been easier for him, too. But what was easy wasn’t what was best for Colleen. The two of them together, with renewed devotion, was the best thing. As hard as it was, it was worth it. It was the only thing that mattered.

Now he sighed long and hearty, bowing his head until his brow touched Kimmy’s cheek. He kissed her neck; soft and slow at first, then slower, with more lurid implication, sucking hard on her skin, pulling it away from her tendon, suckling. Kimmy moaned. “Let’s wait,” she said, touching his jaw, pulling back so she could look into his eyes. “Wait until Hyun gets home.”

His heart sank, remembering even though he was reunited with his wife, their life wasn’t as simple as it had been. They had a roommate and they had a baby. At least they could rely on their roommate to watch the baby when they needed time alone.

“Okay,” he said, kissing her cheek one last time before he returned his attention to their daughter, babbling away in his lap.

Kimmy reached in his lap and hefted Colleen up to her bosom, cradling her for a moment before standing, then padding out of the family room and to the room down the hall where they kept Colleen’s crib. He sat on the floor still, weight back on his hands, staring at the space where his wife and daughter had just been. His heart pounded behind his ribs and his temples throbbed. Not hurt, not pain; no, *excitement*. That woman who’d birthed his daughter had so many dark ways to rip orgasms from him. And now that he’d kissed her, sucked on her neck, told her he wanted her and wanted to stay, that dark part of his mind knew the bad things he loved would soon come his way. Hyun couldn’t get home fast enough.

Kimmy returned without Colleen while he was still on the floor. He looked up and Kimmy untied her robe, showing him she wore nothing underneath. Bare tawny skin. A shaved mound. Her body toned and sleek, her nipples hard enough to catch the weight of the robe's silk and keep the lapels from closing.

Chapter 16

The Touch of that Sacred Spear

When he first fell in love with Kimmy, she had been nothing but a skinny teen—no bumps or knobs to consider. Tall, slim, but unnoticeable. With his hands roaming her skin now, Josh wondered how he'd never seen what Devlin saw. Devlin Stone had perverted her, opened up something inside her that was dark and sexual. But Devlin Stone didn't put it there. It was inside her already. Kimmy herself had said that Devlin encouraged her darkness to the surface. And she groomed herself in a manner that revealed all those wicked tendencies. Under his hands right now was the exact same woman who he'd married and committed himself to, and built a life with.

They were on the couch, making out like lusty young people. Kimmy wore nothing under her robe. The robe was open, and he lay on his back with his wife on top. Kimmy humped her bald sex against his aching member. His hands coddled, smoothed, and squeezed her ass and the backs of her thighs. She was warm under his touch.

They were waiting for their babysitter's return. He'd never been more eager to see his cousin's ex-wife.

At last, they heard Hyun's arrival home. It was after 10:30. His hands were on Kimmy's round but narrow ass, riding it up and down and guiding her hips to hump against his own. She was soaking wet. He was hard as a rock. Kimmy broke off their kiss and slunk away from him, her eyes turned

out behind the couch and past the garden to the garage, where he once thought she'd wanted him to live. She closed her robe and tied it at the waist. Her eyes were watery, her cheeks blushed, her lips swollen and puckered. Desire burned on her skin. Josh sat up and looked out to the garage to see Hyun's hatchback pulling in.

"Finally," he said with comic indignation.

Kimmy smiled but then showed him one of those faces that encouraged him to mind his manners.

"Only joking," he said.

Kimmy left him on the couch, moving back to the chair. Josh adjusted his erection under his pants and sat upright, crossing his legs. They'd been making out like that for a whole hour, with only one interruption from Colleen. They listened as Hyun came in through the side door and into the kitchen, and now Kimmy said to him, "Why don't you go upstairs, and I'll talk to Hyun?"

That was fine with him. He was ready to blow. The last thing he wanted to do was sit around and try to act casual and make small talk with Hyun, when all he wanted to do was get his wife upstairs and relive some of the better moments of their devilish desires. He told her to go on ahead, that he needed a minute. With the pants he was wearing, there would be little chance of hiding his arousal. He'd rather wait for Kimmy to go in and talk to Hyun, and maybe he could sneak up the stairs without having to say a word.

Kimmy smiled in a way that sparked that dark fire in him again. It was a wicked smile. The smile of a wrongdoer. She got up from the chair and came to him, putting her hands on his thighs and her knee between his open legs. She kissed him fully. Lips soft and fattened with passion. She moaned while she kissed him and that drove him wild. She wanted him. She really wanted him. This was no put-on, no act. He was darn certain that Devlin Stone was gone. Long gone. Kimmy never mentioned him. He wasn't

hiding upstairs in their bedroom, ready to jump out and torment him like he did in those high school showers with his oversized organ swinging between his legs. And Kimmy wasn't going to set him up to be humiliated. No, this was them in it together again. Whatever strange sexual proclivity that had metastasized in him during Kimmy's affair with Devlin could now be explored. His greatest fears had been laid bare. They'd been made real. But everything was in place again. And with everything in place, they couldn't just go back to the mundane. Kimmy loved her wickedness, and he knew it. Kimmy would use her wickedness to light up the tenderest parts of his battleground with military-grade guidance systems.

While they still kissed, her hand went down and grabbed his turgid column and squeezed. She made a satisfied sound that had his core tightening. She couldn't wait to get it out of his pants and do things with it he could only imagine. They'd been apart for so long, but when they'd been together, there had been no greater satisfaction in his life.

She slipped away from him, still showing that wicked smile, saying, "Meet me upstairs." Then she put on her slippers and swished from the room, down the hall, and into the kitchen.

Josh lay back on the couch, feeling his body shake with the beat of his heart. His cock ached. His pulse raced. He wished he could teleport into the bedroom. His erection did not subside. He stood up and found out he was right. The front of his pants were tented out, his knob end trying to poke a hole through the fabric. He couldn't walk around with a pillow held to his lap. Even his untucked shirt did nothing to conceal his frenzied state.

"Fuck," he moaned, his voice a whisper. He squeezed his own hardness, then followed Kimmy's wake, going down the hall and around the corner, pausing and listening. He heard Kimmy talking in the kitchen. He could slip upstairs unnoticed if he tried. He got around the corner unseen, made it to the stairs, then stopped. Kimmy and Hyun had been talking low, but now they weren't talking at all. He edged to the end cupboard and peeked into

the kitchen. Kimmy held Hyun in a strange embrace in front of the fridge. Hyun looked sad. Like she might have been crying. Her face was downturned, and Kimmy rested her own forehead against Hyun's temple. It was strangely intimate, but they'd been together during a trying time and he was glad Hyun had been there for Kimmy when he couldn't. He left them alone and slipped upstairs without them even noticing.

* * *

Hyun's tears traveled her porcelain cheeks. She hid her face from Kimmy, ashamed. Kimmy rubbed Hyun's shoulders, soothing her, needing her to maintain composure.

"I'm sorry," Hyun said, pinching her brow, squeezing the tears from her eyes like she wanted them gone. "I knew it was coming. I've been expecting it."

"I know," Kimmy said. "You just came home from class and—"

"I'm fine," Hyun said again and sniffled, but she wasn't.

Kimmy stroked Hyun's neck and hugged her. "You know this is the way it has to be," she whispered.

"He's Colleen's father," Hyun said. "I know, Kimmy. I know. I'm fine." This time when she looked away, Hyun sobbed once, a mournful sound. Kimmy hugged her harder and rubbed a circle on her back.

* * *

Josh was in their bedroom, sitting on the bed and waiting for her. She'd expected him to be under the covers and ready for sex, not wearing anything, but he was still dressed. Elbows on knees, hands clasped together and facing the dresser. She stepped into the bedroom and closed the door behind her, stepped towards Josh and saw what he was looking at. There on

the dresser was the rubber-flesh facsimile of Devlin's size. Cartoonishly large, looking almost unreal. But the measurements were not quite far from reality. It wasn't two-toned like Devlin's cock was, and it never could do the job the way Devlin did it, but it represented Devlin nonetheless. She stopped short, surprised to see it there. She hadn't expected Josh to be so bold. She would have suspected that Josh would have found it and put it back and never mentioned it again. Maybe not never, but not this way. Not so abrupt or confrontational.

He said, "You left that for me to find."

She relaxed a little. "If I wanted to hide it from you, I would put it with my paperwork."

Josh finished for her, saying, "Not with your underwear." He was expressionless and not like the man she'd been making out with for the last hour. He looked up now to meet her gaze. "Do you miss him?"

She continued to the bed, stood before him, and brushed his cheeks with the backs of her fingers while he looked up at her. She untied her robe and showed him her naked front. Josh kissed her stomach, and she pulled his cheek to rest there. She said, "I thought we were done talking about the past."

"That can't be true," he said. "If it were true, I wouldn't be sitting here asking you about that thing on the dresser. You put it there."

"You looked for it."

He said, "I wasn't looking for that. You know what I was looking for, and you wanted me to see it."

She gripped the hair at the back of his head and guided him to look up at her again. She said, "Because I know you like it, Josh. I want to give you the things you like."

Josh sighed, but not from exasperation or frustration. It was a happy sound. A satisfied sound. He kissed her belly, brushing his beard against her sensitive skin. He said, "I made myself so vulnerable to you."

“You did,” she said, playing with his hair.

“I confessed things that were so sacred. And you accepted them. But you still lied to me.”

“I did,” she said, thumbing his hot cheekbones, feeling love for him despite the truthful accusation.

“You lied to me when I was at my most open. There’s nothing to lie about anymore, Kimmy. I know what you did. I know you hated what you did, but I also know you didn’t hate every minute of it. There were times you really liked what you were doing—what Devlin was doing—so don’t lie anymore. Just tell me the truth. Everything will be so much better if you just tell the truth.”

She lifted a leg and dropped a knee on the mattress between his open legs, nuzzling it into his crotch. “What do you want to know?”

He looked up at her, steadfast, sure of himself. “I want to know if you miss Devlin.”

She exhaled, looked down between them, then back into his eyes. “I miss the good times.”

“There were good times with him?”

“There were incredible times, Josh.” She flashed a sad smile. “There were times he did things to me I couldn’t believe.”

Josh’s jaw slackened, his cheeks hollowed. He couldn’t believe she would tell the truth—and he didn’t like the truth. The truth offended him. It jarred him. But they both knew the truth turned him on. All those times she’d lied were good times. All the times she’d spoken Josh’s fantasies were good times. Sometimes they were truths and Josh turned them into fantasies. But no matter the anguish he’d suffered, he couldn’t shake the way his fantasies tickled him.

She thumbed his jawline, the sad smile turning upbeat and reassuring. “You’re safe now, Josh. The boogey man is long gone. I’m all yours. You’re all I want.”

Josh stared up at her, expression calm, but eyes blazing with lusty expectation. “Tell me when it was incredible.”

She brushed her fingers through his hair. “The first time he fucked me, I passed out. He fucked me senseless. When I came to, he ordered me IV hydration and a B12 booster. Bedside at the Royal York.”

Josh paled in exquisite, blood-draining horror. She guided him to his back and got over top of him.

Chapter 17

We Now Know Good and Evil

Kimmy got over top of him and his hands went inside her open robe and onto her naked waist. Husband and wife alone on a Friday night, their baby with a sitter. Date night. This scenario's implication was ripe with kink and debauchery. This was marital playtime. And it was only the two of them. It was intimate. A time for two married people to explore some fantasy realms for their own pleasure.

But why did it have to be that way? Why did it have to be so sinister? So kinky; so debauched?

Because he liked it that way.

Scar tissue had grown over the wounds of the past. Maybe the new and thicker tissue strengthened him. How could harm come to him with Devlin so far away?

Kimmy's mouth slipped apart from his, and she stroked his cheek. She said, "I miss you more than anything. I've missed you so much this last year. I miss the times we shared more than any of the times I shared with Devlin." The hand that stroked his cheek moved to his chest, and Kimmy ran her nails down his stomach, then grabbed his erection through his pants. "And I miss this dick more than I miss his."

"I don't think that's true," he said.

Kimmy looked at him, unsure, fondling his hardness—then smirked as if she decided he was joking. She said, “I think you miss it more than I do.”

“Miss what?”

She said, “I know you, Josh. I know that time when you thought it was just me and you, and Devlin was this sexual *thing* lurking outside our perimeter, you were at your happiest. You love the dirty talk. You love the things we did.”

“I know—I’m the one who said those things to you. But you made them true behind my back. Twisted reality with my kink to serve yourself. Not me. You served yourself.”

“You loved the things I did when they were fantasy.”

“You lied. You betrayed me,” he said.

“I did,” she said, studying him, sucking her plump lower lip and running her teeth across before letting the lip pop back out again. “But that’s all gone now, Josh. Washed away; the debris sent down the river. Right here and now is all that matters. I want to give you everything you want. And I know what you want.”

He closed his eyes. “I don’t even know what I want.”

“I’ll show you,” she said. “And you stop me when I’m wrong.” The hand that had stroked his cheek lay flat on his chest, then she dragged her nails down his stomach. She raised up and backed off of his body. She grabbed his belt with two hands, unbuckled it, opened his fly and drew down his zipper. With one strong movement, she pulled his pants down to his knees. His rock hard erection pointed to his chin, throbbing and aching. The fresh air touching the hot skin got him hissing a deep inward breath. Every iota of his being rushed between his legs like that was all that existed.

She lowered her eyes to his erection. His wife seeing it for the first time in a year. Measuring its inadequacy with her eyes, measuring the shortcoming in the task she needed it for. Her pleasure spots were tucked inside her where her husband couldn’t reach.

She said, “You miss Devlin’s cock more than I do, Josh. You love the idea of him fucking me. You love the idea of the pleasure his size would give me.”

He groaned with strange pleasure and a rising anger. No, not anger. Umbrage. A year later and he still had to hear about Devlin Stone. Still had to hear about this other man who’d done things to his wife her husband couldn’t do. Had to hear about it and hear his wife twist it into something for him to enjoy.

She gripped his thighs just above his knees, then ran her nails up to his hips and he almost passed out. He shuddered, and his fingers trembled. He could feel her breath against his cock.

“You wish you could do to me what he did.”

Josh groaned again, louder now, hating her words. Her words angered him. But while they did, they also brought something slick and oily that coated his skin and seeped into his pores, nourished parts of him with an indescribable pleasure.

Over her shoulder now he could see on the dresser that Devlin replica. That enormous fleshy cudgel. The effigy of the real over-sized implement that had fucked his wife senseless countless times last summer. The one his wife had come on over and over again. The one that had touched some trigger inside her. He closed his eyes tight and rolled his vision upward. Kimmy’s tongue pressed between his testicles, shoving them to the sides, then running a flat swath up the middle of his shaft and to the tip of his cock. Her hand took the base, two fingers and a thumb, angled it upward and sunk him inside her mouth. The most heavenly feeling he’d ever had. Her mouth was warm and wet, and when it moved against his turgid arousal, his whole body tightened, and bright blobs of light danced in the charcoal landscape of his shut-off vision. She drew her mouth up and down, her cheeks hollowing with the exquisite suction.

When they'd first reunited last week, Kimmy had seduced him in the apartment above the garage. She'd tried luring him to bed with nefarious conjecture and innuendo. All day today, he'd anticipated tonight's intimate possibilities, wondering if it would happen. Knowing it probably would. But he hadn't anticipated *how* it would happen. The default fantasy would be him and his wife rolling around in the sheets, kissing, and then making love. Instead, it was the same sadistic games they'd played a year ago.

He hadn't been with anyone in over a year. He'd come close to it with Karina, but nothing ever happened. They'd kissed, he'd handled her breasts; he'd even slipped a hand down her pants. But nothing had progressed. Everything had been stunted. Muffled.

Kimmy's mouth worked masterful pleasure. She knew exactly how to bring him to the brink of ecstasy and then pull him back, teasing him until he couldn't take it anymore. Her lips were slick cushions, her tongue nimble. She took his hardness deep, sucking and swirling her tongue around the base, then pulling back slowly, drawing the ring of her lips to the tip, before plunging him into her mouth again.

Josh's eyes rolled back in his head as he let out a low moan. He couldn't believe how good it felt, how skilled Kimmy was at this. And . . . how she'd done this kind of thing for *another* man. Wicked thoughts teased him. She'd been sucking cock for the last year. Sucking other men's cocks. She'd sucked off everyone at Stone; every lawyer, every client, every foreign businessman. Kimmy landed contract after contract for Keith Stone because no one could suck a cock like her.

His hands went to trembling fists as this awful *imagined* scenario did the work he liked, got his balls climbing into his body, getting ready to gush their load into his delivery systems. He held his breath tight in his quaking chest, sucking in his stomach, reeling those perverted thoughts back, not wanting to come so soon, not wanting to disappoint his wife and ruin her night of sex with a premature release.

But Kimmy moved her head up and down, picking up the pace. His hips bucked involuntarily, his body responding without his approval. Tension doubled inside him. The pressure mounted as she brought him closer and closer to the edge and seemed willing for him to go over.

Now he rushed to push away the thoughts of her sucking off clients, sucking cocks for financial gain. But it left him thinking of Kimmy sucking Devlin's cock. Sucking Devlin off in Cayman while her husband waited for her in the hot tub. A chump. A cuck. A man whose wife ran games around his impotent ass.

His breathing went ragged as he rumbled closer and closer to the knife-edge point of no return. He tried to hold back, to make it last as long as possible, but it was no use. Kimmy's mouth was too good, her skill too perfect.

With one final deep thrust, this time of his own propulsion, he let go, his body convulsing as he began to ejaculate in Kimmy's perfect, beautiful mouth. Kimmy pulled away, smiling wide with her wet lips, a satisfied sound in her throat as she watched him come. Her hand stroked his cock as his semen spurted, painting creamy lines on his trembling stomach. The moment was incredible, the release *so* powerful. But as it receded, he was left with guilt and shame. Kimmy stroked his dick. It looked unimpressive in her hand. He'd seen her wrap those long and elegant fingers around Devlin's beefy girth. His head fell back, the crown hanging between his shoulder blades. The happiness and feelings of explosive joy waned to nothing, and his eyes fluttered open to stare at their new bedroom's ceiling. Kimmy played with his softening penis, but he was too sick to look at it again, see its size in her hand, knowing the size that turned her on, knowing the size she liked.

He sighed, anguished and saddened by the state of things. Kimmy would have kept sucking Devlin's cock. He bet she let him come in her mouth. Bet she loved the taste of his semen on a Wednesday afternoon

lunchtime fuck session behind her husband's back. The fading of his hardness ceased. These awful thoughts piqued his cock's interest.

Maybe Kimmy was right. Maybe she knew what he liked and maybe surrendering to her wickedness would bring him satisfaction he couldn't imagine. As long as she was faithful.

He sighed again, but the post-orgasm ennui had settled, and he didn't feel so bad anymore. He raised his face to see Kimmy standing now, letting that silky robe fall off her smooth shoulders and show him her body. His wife was a mother now, but she looked much like she had during last summer's horror. Her lean body and long limbs; the perky little breasts, the tawny skin. He smiled, seeing something in her eyes that he liked. For the first time, maybe not so ashamed of his own desire.

He didn't have to ask her for this. He didn't have to skirt around the ways to frame this kink he'd developed. It was out in the open. It was fair game, and shame was observed at a different scale than it had before. The details of his bizarre arousal were known to all. She knew what he liked, and she could deliver.

He could lament how now when they're united in intimacy, they're not making love and writhing in the sheets, they're playing games and toying with the darkness that separated them in the first place—but he could also accept the state of his being and move on.

Pearly islands scattered on the flat plain of his stomach.

Kimmy, totally naked now and fully aware of how good she looked, said, "It didn't take very long, did it?"

The answer was obvious. He would say, *Did Devlin last longer?* And then Kimmy would tell him about the marathon fuck sessions she and Devlin used to embark upon. His cock hardened further. He kept the question from his tongue, still wary of embarrassing himself.

Kimmy turned to the dresser, and he thought for a second she would bring over that Devlin replica and compare it to his own erection, so they

could both see the dimensional difference between her husband and her accomplished lover. The way she'd done with the actual flesh and blood cock monstrosity in that Yorkville hotel room. But Kimmy returned with a pair of pale yellow cotton undies from her drawer. She hip-sat beside him on the bed, smiling an honestly happy smile, and patted up the splatter, wiping his evidence away before tossing the underwear toward the bathroom door. She said, "You're still hard."

"I took a year off," he said, like an explanation for his immediate arousal in case she knew the perverted thoughts that has quickened his pulse and flooded his erectile tissue.

"We have a lot to catch up on," she said, slinking along beside his body and beginning to remove his shirt and sweater. He assisted her, and they got him as naked as she was, both of them on top of the sheets and bedding. She began kissing him again, and though he still felt stiff and awkward with her, he could feel his joints warming up and his heart beating faster, wanting more and more from her. Kimmy rolled so she was on top of him, straddling his hips, the point of his erection touching an ass cheek. Her long, silky black hair fell around his face as she lowered her mouth to his, kissing him lovingly and touching his face.

Then they worked the bedding out from under them, getting themselves under the sheets and cozying against each other. There was an indescribable joy and homeliness to feeling her nakedness against his. The places where she was cool; the places where she was warm; the places where she was hot and wet and sticky. His hands went all over her body, finding their way to the top of her thighs, just below the crease of her buttocks, the place that used to get her excited. She squirmed and sighed and moaned and she kissed him some more. Her hand found his genitals, and she caressed and coddled his sack and stroked his hardening cock.

She asked him, "You came so fast—you're ready to go again?"

He nodded, looking into her eyes, seeking courage to ask what he suspected she wanted him to ask. He said, “You didn’t want me to come in your mouth?”

“I wanted to see you come, baby,” she said, and kissed his chin, stroking his cock underhanded.

He said, “Did he come . . . Did he ever come in your mouth?”

Once the question was out, his cock went to steel. She hadn’t even answered him yet.

Kimmy chuckled an appreciative sound, feeling his cock swell in her hand. She said, “Yeah, he did, Josh. He came in my mouth.”

His knees squeezed together, and his cock spewed slippery excitement into Kimmy’s grip. She stroked him faster.

She whispered, “Devlin came in my mouth, and you tasted it.”

He groaned with the most awful, exciting joy. His heart pounded and disgust flooded his mind. He said, “What? What do you mean?”

She said, “I’d suck off that huge cock and then I’d come home and kiss you on the mouth.” Her grip tightened on his cock, electric pleasure thrumming from his pleasure point and throughout his body. He coughed and groaned and writhed while she jerked his cock and followed his twisting head, whispering some more wickedness in his frightened ears. “And he’d fuck me, too, Josh, and blow his load so deep inside me. . . . And I’d come home and let you eat my pussy.”

“What?” He gasped, horrified. “You did?”

Chapter 18

Man Will Hearken to His Wife

Josh didn't say to stop, so she continued. "He came in my mouth, and I liked it," she said, studying her husband's profile, getting off on his poignant disgust. Her hand measured his resultant arousal; his cock hard as steel in her grip. "You know you liked it, too."

Josh shuddered, his head pressing back into the pillow, his back arching. What she said was true; Josh couldn't deny it. She should have told Josh sooner. Told him all the things he feared were true. Instead, she'd sought some sort of endpoint where Devlin had been subdued and she had better control at Stone. That's where it had ended up. She had control. She had what she wanted. But if she'd invested in Josh's kink and sealed his desirous deals earlier, maybe she could have spared him the hurt she'd caused. "I wish I could have told you, Josh. I wish you could have enjoyed it. I wish so many things." His cock had returned to full hardness, and the way she spoke to him and the way he reacted, they might as well have been in Cayman or in the old apartment, whispering nasty things and playing games. Those had been fun times; intense and exploratory. In the bizarrest way, it had opened her eyes to Josh and his psyche and the worry and fear her husband held. Those times had been an erotic catalysis; and it had been wasted on Devlin Stone and the job she ended up taking from him, anyway, without the need to tread further down his ridiculous paths. "I never should

have kept from you the things I was doing. I should have told you.” Josh’s cock flexed in her grip, his lips sucking into his mouth as he fantasized who-knew-what, weaved whatever tormented web using her supporting words for his spider silk. “We really could have had so much fun together. You wanted the things I did, and you’re right, I took them from you and did those things for selfish reasons. I stole it from you. I stole all those things you wanted and I ruined it all.”

Josh groaned and nodded, his eyes closed, sealing himself alone with the dark chimera behind his lids. His body felt so good and homey against hers. His body blessed her bed. Her leg slid up his, her inner thigh coasting over the top of his; she straddled him, reached behind and palmed the base of his cock, pressing his length along her wetness, sliding her sex up and down with a curl of her pelvis. His cock was perfect; his cock had performed the designed function. He’d given her Colleen. “This is the cock I’ve missed, Josh,” she said, easing her hips back, angling him to enter her body. She sank his erection a few inches inside her. “Not Devlin’s. Sex with Devlin was nothing without you. You made me like it. You made me want it. You gave it value.”

Josh stared back in wide-eyed awe. His eyes trembled with the edging of horror, but she showed him with her expression and the rolling of her hips how she meant what she said. None of what she’d done had any meaning without Josh. She caressed his cheek and sank his cock all the way inside her. It had been more than a year without real sex. More than a year without a blood-pulsing cock inside her. Toys weren’t even close to equal.

Her hips rolled and roiled with his cock seated inside her. She moaned real moans and breathed deep, loving the feel of his arousal. Loving the knowledge that her lurid words could command Josh. She hunched closer to him, his beard brushing her cheek as she whispered in his ear, “I know you can’t love me the way you did before.” Josh groaned with emotional hurt,

but she lured him closer to her, continuing, “But I want you to love me. I want you to love me in some new way that works for you. Works for us.”

Now she rose to sit squatted on Josh’s hips, running her nails on his chest. Josh joined the action now, his hips responding to hers, beginning to moil, his cock like a hard bar inside her. His hands came to her hips, held her there, bracing her as his thrusts gained fervor. She rocked with him, both of them building a pace they liked, their connection wet and slippery and so, so good.

She arched her lower back, leaning away, Josh’s hands spreading onto her hips and over the plain of her belly. The pleasure grew stronger. She rolled forward, thrashing him with her hair. She slowed, gripped his chin, held his handsome face steady, saying, “We can’t go on with me apologizing every day. That won’t work. I’ve apologized. I’ve done what I could to bring you back to me. Just love me; hear my promises and love me.”

Josh’s eyes stayed open, his hands going up and down her ribs, expression blank, bearded cheeks hollowed; his lips parted. “I love you, Kimmy. I do.”

She gasped a satisfied sound, lunging forward, one hand bracing her weight on the headboard, her chest over Josh’s face. She arched her back and sighed as Josh suckled her nipple. The new angle of entry was exciting, and as Josh sucked her sore nipple, she bucked frog-like on his spear, each little thrust blipping white pleasure in her brain. “I know I was bad,” she said. “I know I did everything wrong. But you have to know: I would have gutted him for you.” She withdrew her offered nipple, Josh wild-eyed, blown away and hot as a glass furnace now, any misgivings or reluctance turned to a molten, vitreous state. “I would have served Thanksgiving dinner with his head on a platter. Just to make you smile. Just to make things right.” She smiled and then bit her lower lip to quash it.

But Josh saw her in that moment in a way she hid. His eyes quivered.

She curved over him, her face over his, both of them rocking faster now, their thrusting squeaking the expensive mattress. “I would have broken him,” she said. “If you wanted, I’d make him do things to make us laugh. To turn us both on.”

Josh believed her. “You would have,” he whispered.

His faith restored her. If he could believe she would do that, he would also believe none of the harm she’d caused him was for the purpose of harm. “I hurt you, Josh. But what I wanted most was your transcendence. I wanted you to shrug off Devlin’s juvenile mantle. You’re so much more than he is.”

Josh’s mouth opened and closed, trying to say something but not knowing what to say. She had strayed too far from fantasy and dosed him with emotional concepts that he would argue against. But she couldn’t stop talking.

She said, “I would have got Devlin on his knees and made him suck your cock.”

Josh grimaced, nowhere near as turned on by the idea as she was.

She retreated from vivid imagery, saying now, “I would have broken him. I did it all wrong, but I wanted to break him for you.”

Her posture slackened, her rump squashed down on his thighs, his steely hardness not fading, still raging straight and stiff in her pocket. Josh studied her, his soft eyes roaming her naked body, wondering if she told him the truth. And what would he think of her if he deemed her truthful? That she was good? That she was noble? Maybe he would hear this confession as sin. As a promise of her powerful malice. It could frighten him.

“I did it, anyway,” she said. “But it was too late to be any good for you.”

Josh’s voice was a whisper. “You really did that?”

She bit her lower lip again, her hands fanning on Josh’s sweaty chest. *Fuck, she liked that beard.* She nodded, her hips sticking on a nice point

near her G-spot, doing swift jerks on it, her eyes closing.

“You kissed me with his come in your mouth?”

Her eyes opened again, her features relaxing to an inscrutable mask, assessing Josh’s judgment before she spoke. The sparkle in his eye showed ignition—Josh’s motor ran at speed and the clutch fit right into place. She furrowed her brows in an impish arc; a cartoonish representation of the dimwitted moll, worried she’d done her Dapper Dan wrong.

Josh’s brow lowered and he grumbled with some locomotive desire, heaving her to her back with his hips and getting on top of her, her legs falling wide to accommodate him. His hand closed on her collar, then stroked her throat, his thumb caressing her tendon. There was anger in his eyes. Anger and disgust; but Josh sweetened that emotion with lust’s coarse sugar.

“You have to be kidding me,” he said, voice low and disbelieving.

She humped up her hips, wanting him back inside her, feeling the light weight of his upright organ slip along her membranes. She mewled with need, showed him her frustration.

Josh’s hand closed on her neck and pushed her back into the pillow. She writhed on the bed, humping her hips higher, Josh not giving her what she wanted. She chuckled and rocked her head side-to side.

Josh’s mouth found hers, his grip loosening, his thumb caressing. He put his hand between them, angled his point to her slit and slid himself inside. She cooed and put her hand over his, both of them holding her throat, looking into each other’s eyes, gazing deeply. Josh plunged hard and rocked her. She yipped, then bit it back. He withdrew and plunged again, hard enough to make the bed bounce and rattle on the wall. The corners of his mouth turned down, a sneering anger twisting his brow.

Josh didn’t fill her or stretch her, or touch terrible deep places; Josh was comfort and safety and never danger. Not until now; not until she felt his anger’s grip, felt his frustration and rage. She gritted her teeth, snarled at

him, bared her fangs. Josh showed her the same face. He pounded into her again and again, stabbing deep into her—deep as Josh could go.

And she met his thrusts with her own. The bed shuddered with their movement. The headboard banged. Josh arched his back and pushed himself to the hilt and held it. His cock twanged with stunning stiffness. His hand left her throat and grabbed a fistful of hair, pulling her head to the side and the back until she squawked.

“You’re worse than Devlin ever was,” he said, jaw clamped.

She smiled, found relief from her pulled hair by twisting her head to the side and up to the right. She said, “I hurt you like he hurt you, but he never loved you. He never cared about you.”

Josh roared and withdrew his cock from her hot scabbard, hoisting her body to one side, scrambling to get her on her hands and knees. He’d let go of her hair, and she complied.

Josh palmed the back of her head and pushed her face into the pillow.

Chapter 19

Orbital Mechanics and Entry Windows

That she would *do* such a devilish thing! Kimmy would do the worst things she could imagine; had *done* the worst things, thinking meager Josh might fantasize it; did it because whether it was for Josh didn't matter; Kimmy *loved* it. Loved to torture him in secret. This mild woman he'd married, this woman of once plain sex, and a kind, clean home, was wicked. Perverted. She wore a black crown of poisonous thorn, and wore it with grace. He would never know if Devlin or Amy had started last summer's treachery, or even if it had been Kimmy who'd started it. He'd never know the truth because he'd stepped away from consciousness that night at Tiffany's; had over-indulged and paid the price. Hell, maybe it *had* been Kimmy who'd put it in his ear he wanted to have Devlin fuck her.

Or maybe it had been himself all along.

But he possessed Kimmy now. Of that he was sure. A baby and a house. And sex. Awful sex. *Amazing* sex. The return of whispered treasures, of diabolical sexual exploits that sent his delight into the stratosphere.

He pulled her face from the pillow, hand on the back of her neck slipping to her collar, and guiding her upright, his cock popping out from inside her, Kimmy's back pressing to his chest. He kissed her neck and stroked her shoulder. This was Colleen's mother, and he wouldn't mistreat his daughter's mother. And deep down in his chest's host rock, past the

gangue and under the overburden, lay unexpected and undeserved love, a thin vein of still-sparkling ore. He said, “How can I still love you?”

Kimmy moaned and rubbed between her thighs, like she needed him. Or needed *it*. “Because you *know* I love you. You *know* it. And knowing that means everything.”

The idea rolled in his mind and found no dip nor abscess that would halt it. The idea had racy momentum, and all he knew was he needed an answer *why* he could love her; and her response was as good as any. Fear peeked past the veil when his preconscious whispered he hadn’t the courage to hate her. “You did those terrible things because you loved me.”

The hand Kimmy held between her thighs reached deeper underneath her and found his hardness. She angled his return and guided her hips back so he would enter her again.

He said, “I want to make love to you. I don’t want it like this.”

Kimmy stilled, his length only in her a shallow depth, and what he sensed as disappointment pierced his psyche. Wounded him. Frightened him. “Just one time, Kimmy. I want you as my wife. I want you like how we used to be.”

“I want that, too,” she said. After a moment, she eased forward, let his dick slip out of her, and knee-walked around to face him before reclining on the bed, head on a pillow. Her long legs parted, knees out to the sides, and she wiped her cheeks and then motioned for him to join her. To get on top of her.

A huge feeling of inadequacy seized his heart. A true and primal fear of not being enough. Not satisfying her. Of loving her and suffering under her cruelty, and yet once reunited, failing to please her in the way she liked—a perpetual failure that may have led to their catastrophe. Worry that his wife had gone to Devlin not just because of Devlin’s big dick and money and good looks, but because her husband wasn’t dirty enough. Wasn’t nasty

enough. How couldn't he think Kimmy loved all that depraved sex? How couldn't he believe that she would miss it again in the future?

She didn't love Devlin. She loved sweet Josh.

But she'd loved the wickedness more—and wickedness grew in unimaginable measure when applied in her husband's naive proximity. Being with Devlin alone would never do it for Kimmy. She would just be another wicked widget in the wicked widget factory. And now he could see the betrayal for what it was and how she'd worked so hard to have him back. The act of betrayal and the stark humiliation turned her on. Drove her wild. She'd even wanted to humiliate Devlin. And what would that have looked like? Would it have raised Josh Waters' esteem in her own eyes? Or would she have reveled in humiliating them both at the same time? Maybe she loved disparity and would have experimented in exchanging one man over the other, waging them against one another in value, making sure each of them both equaled the same amount, but struggled in endless turmoil on their designated pans, wanting to make a difference in her measure.

How would he ever arouse a woman like that? How would he do the things that made her go crazy? Without a question, he wanted her to have that sexual satisfaction. To have that erotic joy.

What if she likes other men to come in her mouth and then have her kiss you? Would you do such a thing?

You already did such a thing.

He dropped over top of her, his face hovering over hers. "Why the fuck do I still love you?" Kimmy said nothing and he said, "Why don't I hate you?"

"Do you *want* to hate me?" She touched his cheeks.

He shook his head. "I want to love you. I wish it was easier."

"It will be." Then she kissed him, holding his face, lying on her back. Just the way he'd asked her to. Like the way they were before everything went wrong.

Like the way that provoked Kimmy's disenchantment. The way he'd bored her before.

His hand trembled now, gripping his hardness and swiping the tip along Kimmy's slippery seam. He thumbed it downward and sank inside her hot interior. He went halfway, withdrew and coated his tight cock skin with her slick lubrication. And she moaned. And while she moaned, all he thought was she lied. She betrayed. She made the sounds she thought she should to appease his bruised ego.

But so what? Hadn't she done enough? Kimmy had done so much to restore them, to bring him back to her bed. Did he want her to stay silent while he fucked her?

But now he moaned too, and the feel of her tight wet-velvet squeeze on his member was delight in the purest form. Light bloomed in his mind and he closed his eyes, rolled into her deeper, pulled back and did it again. Kimmy roiled against his intrusion. Wanting him. Perhaps wanting him deeper. Wanting him harder and dirtier, wanting him to do the kinds of things Devlin Stone did to her behind his back. The two of them fucking and sucking and laughing. Luxury hotel suites and fancy restaurants, and Prada shoes and Mercedes Benz convertibles.

Kimmy's pelvis rocked with his thrusts, giving him easy access and eager supplication to his turgid cock. He plowed her with ease. The pleasure was enormous. The fear was greater.

She'd given it all up for this? Given it all up for her okay husband with a mediocre job and soft body and average dick? When she'd had it all? There were things Devlin didn't have that she wanted. There were things about him that made Kimmy whole.

He grunted and groaned, watching his wife's upturned face, positive she *feigned* that look of ecstasy he witnessed. But she overflowed with wet. She made the sounds he liked. And he loved to be in bed with her. Their bed.

He fucked her faster, getting the bed squeaking, feeling his cock steeling harder; he'd lagged at those awful thoughts of inadequacy. But now he was iron again. Rock hard and wanting to come inside her. Wanting to go all night but knowing he wasn't that man. He could be what she wanted since she insisted so much she would do the same for him. He gripped her hair, not with anger or hatred, but out of sheer frustration. He growled at her, "Devlin came in your mouth and you kissed me?"

Kimmy shook her head no, wincing at the pull of her hair in his shaky grip.

He fucked her harder and with urgent need. A man out of control with sexual excitement. "You sucked his big cock and let him blow his load in your mouth."

Kimmy gasped, eyes closed with intense lust, loving his words. freed by them.

"And then you kissed me."

Kimmy shivered with cruel excitement. "I wondered if you could, mm, taste him. Did you taste his, ah, come, Josh?"

Josh's balls climbed high. Disappeared up inside his body. Afraid and belittled and diminished. But swelling with impending release. Filled with seed enough to make them Colleen's beautiful sibling. Their connection slicked with a generous spew of his grease, thrusting into her, wishing he had a monster between his legs so he could punish Kimmy's sex the way it deserved. Stretch her sex to the limit, an enormous cock head reaming her guts before it exploded inside her like a hand grenade, flooding her with an orgasmic payload that rounded her belly once more.

Fuck, they'd come close to enormous destruction.

Colleen *could* have been Devlin's.

It wasn't impossible for it to have happened.

Colleen was all his, but it was *close*.

“You’re so fucking awful,” he said, caressing her throat, racing thoughts of murder flittering over the surface of his mind. Yet so fucking in love. So renewed. The complex thing between them simplified in theoretical equations, chalk on a blackboard. Two sides of an equation. No matter how one changed, the other must follow. And after all the harm, all the betrayal, somehow she’d restored what they had. Had proved to him not only her love but her dedication.

The risk!

Kimmy had risked it all. Risked it all for the thrill. Fucked around without proper protection and almost bore another man’s child.

And the thought scared the shit out of him and drove him wild at the same time.

* * *

It felt incredible to have him inside her again. To feel his hardness thrusting in and out, to hear his breath and feel his body. No man had been inside her since Devlin. It took almost a year for this reunion but it was worth the wait and worth the effort.

She asked him again if he tasted Devlin’s semen on her kiss, and Josh rewarded her with liquid delight and quivering limbs. He shivered with his orgasm’s hasty approach. He sought to rage and rail, but succumbed to his own delight. Easy surrender. For Josh was fictile, and the world around him chose his shape.

And like that, he stiffened, and she closed her legs around him, held him close and held him tight. He bucked and grunted with wonderful release and the woe of completion. He hid away his face in the pillow, their connection warm and sweaty now, but still very nice. She rubbed his back as his seed leaked from their union and his hardness faded. It would return.

She told him: “I’m not me without you. I’m nothing. I wouldn’t know who I am.” And there was more truth in that than she could describe to Josh. A slippery phantasm pastiche would sometimes flicker behind her eyes like a zoetrope, showing trips to Taiwan and high school and happier times at Dalton High and in Kingston, of going to university, of marrying Josh and wanting a family. That’s who she was and she never wanted to forget that. Without Josh, she would be a woman she hated. Who most everyone she knew would hate. Her father, her friends. Even her mother wouldn’t like that person. And Colleen Chang had loved everyone.

Josh stirred, kissing her neck and jaw, showing his face once more. She smiled, patted his bearded face. He was handsome and boyish, and though he said Colleen had his mother’s eyes, she saw only his when she regarded their daughter.

Josh withdrew, and a stream of semen spilled from her, getting her legs closing while Josh rolled away and lay next to her. He gripped her hip and pulled her closer. Then his hand slipped down her thigh and up the back, sending her into shivers, hardening her nipples and making her gasp. He smiled, knowing her spots. —And it made her think of how she’d shared that with Devlin. Intimacy. Not always raw sex, but sometimes a dark closeness she regretted.

There was sadness though in Josh’s eyes, and she could imagine a few things that would bother him. The thing she had said, and his own regret for enjoying it. When she’d said it, he couldn’t hold his orgasm back for long. And the shortcoming. Worried how much bigger Devlin’s penis was, and how quickly he’d ejaculated.

He sat up and left the bedroom, walking naked to the bathroom. He looked good leaner. When he returned he delivered a towel and she fixed it between her legs, remaining on her side and watching Josh’s eyes. He settled beside her, laying the way she was, the two of them close and confidential.

He said, "What would you have done to him, if you could?"

She snuffled a small laugh. "Who, Devlin?" She snuffled again, looked away and then looked back. Josh still stared, undeterred. She said, "I would have broken him. I told you. I was so close to owning him."

Josh smiled too, a sparkle in his eyes. "Tell me."

She breathed deep, adjusted the towel between her thighs. "I . . . I made him as obsessed with my panties as you. Maybe even more." She cupped Josh's cheek and thumbed the corner of his mouth.

He frowned but his smile stayed. "Why?"

"To break him, Josh. He thought it was so funny to do it to you. So I did it to him."

Josh closed his eyes and chuckled. "What did you do?"

She hesitated, unsure of what to say. Then: "I made him wear them."

Josh laughed. "They wouldn't fit him."

"They did," she said. "And I filmed him in them."

Josh's smile and frown faded and he licked his lower lip. The frown returned.

Cold fear formed below her heart and she opened her mouth to speak but didn't know what to say.

Josh sat up, cheeks hollowed and eyes staring.

"I'm sorry, baby," she said, sitting up, following him, touching his back. "I don't want to talk about those bad things. I shouldn't have said anything."

Josh turned his face to hers. "Did you really?" His expression was softer, but she remained expressionless.

Josh looked down and then back up again. "Do you have the video?"

Chapter 20

Plasma Formation

It was almost impossible to read Josh's expression and decipher his motive. Deciphering was one thing; what challenged her most was the suddenness of his surprising apparent surrender; his quick and dedicated return to the fire that had burned him. But, though Josh's features showed tragic lines of worry and the heaviness of existence, there was a familiar gleam in his wounded eyes. Long ago a bad young man had bruised Josh's tenderest part, and sometimes, though the wound had healed, Josh found some strange joy in pressing the old spot and feeling something awful there that maybe reminded him he was a living, breathing man. Yet, she told him, "I don't think it's time for that."

Josh's eyes showed he was undeterred, but he licked his lower lip in nervous preparation before asking her, "Why not?"

She ran her hair back and looked across the room, not sure why she would want him to deviate from his own need—when it would suit her well. *The time wasn't right.* "You're not ready."

Josh nodded once, lips slimmed like he was somehow offended by her rejection. "No," he said, "I think I am."

She inclined her head, regarding him with soft compassion. "How could you be?"

Josh paused, calm, but his eyes flickering. Looking for a reason. He said, “It was a long time ago,” then looked down.

She smiled and cupped a hand on his bearded cheek. “I thought you wanted me as your wife tonight—remember?”

Josh angled his head away, looking up at her, her hand still on his handsome face. He sighed, brow crinkling, concocting an answer. He said, “You wanted to show me how you did it all for me. Made the video. If it’s so bad you won’t show me now, what am I to think?”

She withdrew her hand and held her knees. Possible scenarios played out in her mind; ways Josh might react, how the video might anger him. How it might arouse him. How it might set so many wrongs right again. She turned her face to his. “You *know* what you’re going to see.” *He couldn’t be ready for that.*

“I’m ready, Kimmy. If I’m hurt watching it, it’ll be my own fault. You know you’re going to show me some day.”

“How do you know that?”

“You still have the video?”

She sighed, hugged her knees, lowered her chin. She’d kept the video for Josh.

Josh leaned closer. “Did you keep it for yourself, Kimmy, or did you keep it for me?”

She nodded. “I made it for you. I kept it for you.”

Josh said nothing and they sat together in silence for an achingly long time. Then she slipped off the bed and stood. “I kept it to arouse you. Just you.” She stooped to touch his chest. “You know that, right? I took the video for you. It’s the only reason I took it. And it wasn’t easy to do.”

Josh closed his hand around her over his heart. “But you did it for me, I know. I told you I’m ready.”

She stood again and regarded Josh, seeing his steady gaze, faltering only to flash over her naked body. The phone was kept secure, and she

turned away now from Josh to retrieve it. Into the closet, kneeling under her hanging suits, opening the fireproof safe where she kept all the paperwork, some mementos from her mother, some finer jewelry, and one old iPhone. She thumbed the screen, a little disheartened to see it come to life. If the phone had died, the choice whether to show Josh the video would have been chosen by the Fates. But no, the phone was well and good—the only promising arbiter a red empty-battery sign up in the corner. Time might be on her side. She held the phone to her breast a moment, staring into the hanging suits zipped up in their garment bags before rising to stand again. She lingered in the closet doorway, smiling at Josh, who sat up in bed, back against three stacked pillows, the lamp on, half his body lit in warm light. “Battery’s almost dead,” she said. “Not sure how much you’ll be able to watch.”

Josh’s brow scrunched and his mouth went to one side the way he did when he performed math in his head. He said, “How long is it?”

She regarded him and smiled, waiting for him to hear the double entendre, before deciding the double entendre wasn’t funny, anyway. She walked to the bed on her toes and sat beside him, feet on the floor. “More than we have battery for.”

Josh told her to get a cord and plug it in. “Cords are downstairs,” she said. “I think fate’s working against us.”

“I’ll get the cord,” he said leaning forward, but she stopped him with a hand on his chest.

“You’re staying here. We’ll watch a little first. Okay?”

Josh nodded and eased back into the pillows. She smiled, holding the phone between her breasts. Her nipples had hardened and her tummy livened with this precipice of danger and excitement. This was dangerous sex. This wasn’t mundane. This was electric. She said, “Show me you’re hard first.”

Josh's eyes widened with confused amusement, his head falling back. "What? Why?"

"I want to know your motivation. Prove your intent." Now her hand moved to the bed covers he'd folded over his naked lap, and peeled them back. They both regarded his penis, half hard, inflated but not turgid, sticking out at level.

She moved her gaze from his penis to his eyes. "I'm not showing you until you prove to me you want it."

Josh's expression grew troubled as he tried to comprehend her demand, knowing the demand made sense but just wanting to see the video without restriction. He looked down, his stomach pulling in, his penis lifting.

But when he reached for his penis, she held his wrist. "Don't touch it," she said. "Close your eyes and think about what you'll see."

Now Josh's expression showed a fearful amazement. This small challenge engaged him, locked him in and riled his desire. He closed his eyes as his breaths began to race, coming in heavy chuffs. Her hand caressed his inner thigh. "What are you picturing?"

A deep crease furrowed above the center of his pinched brow. "I don't know yet. . . . Tell me what I'll see."

The caresses on his thigh turned to light nail-raking. "I got Devlin to wear my panties," she said. "The ones you loved so much. The ones you wore for Devlin when you went to his apartment because you wanted to see the pictures Devlin took of my pussy. Wanted to see more of what Devlin saw of me."

"You got him to wear them?"

"I got him *wanting* to wear them, Josh. He never should have messed with my husband."

Josh chuckled and his hardening member nodded between his legs. His head rocked back and he must have gone to his dark fantasy land because she watched his cock rise and lengthen, grow fully erect, pointing straight

up at her. She sighed a satisfied sound he would love to hear, wanting her husband to know how much his arousal aroused her.

Josh chuckled again, breaths quick, eyes open but blinking. He looked down between his legs to see his erection. He snuffled a laugh and flexed his thighs. "I think I'm ready."

"You're not tricking me, getting me to show you this so you can use it against me?"

"I swear, Kimmy," he said, voice quiet.

Her hand left his thigh to rub her chin and neck. "I'm in the video, too, Josh. . . . Are you sure you want to see it?"

Josh's troubled look was exquisite. The delays frustrated him, the indecision, the belief that she could give him this or take it all away, too. Her hand returned between his thighs, but this time she caressed his scrotum with her fingertips, then drew a pad up the length of his trembling arousal. Josh's flesh quivered. Her own heart raced with abundant delight. She'd wanted to show Josh the video but didn't think it would be so soon.

Josh groaned with pleasure at her slippery touch. He said, "Why *else* would I want to see it? You think I want to see *him*?"

"You're going to see him. You're going to see him in my underwear. . . . You're going to see more than that, too."

"Like what?"

"Do you think Devlin's equipment fit in my small panties?" Josh's brow compressed like in anguish. "Oh," she said, soft and embarrassed.

Josh knew why she'd made the sound. He said, "*Mine* fit."

She nodded, pursing her lips, showing him a compassionate expression. "Devlin is a much bigger man than you are. He's taller; he's a thicker guy. . . . And what he has between his legs is *so* much more than yours."

"I already know," Josh said, swallowing with some difficulty, his Adam's apple going up and down.

“You’re going to see it, Josh. See Devlin’s naked manhood. Are you really sure you want to do this?”

“Just show me, please. *Please.*”

She showed him one last wavering look before bringing the phone up so he could see it. She held it in both hands between her breasts. Josh touched her haunch with the backs of his fingers, too worn out with greed to meet her gaze. Embarrassed by his own desire. “I did this for you,” she said. “I wanted to show you, wanted to show you in my own way, in my own time. But if you want to see it now, I’ll show you now.”

Josh squirmed, electrified by the knowledge of a video she held to her chest, writhing with dirty needs. She dropped her hands between her naked thighs, shoulders slumping. She said, “Tell me you wanted it, Josh.” Josh didn’t understand. She said, “Tell me the truth. Tell me you wanted it from the beginning. Tell me you wanted it before I did it anyway.”

“I couldn’t have,” he whispered, eyes pleading for release.

“You must have, Josh. I didn’t want it to happen. Just tell me. Tell me because I want to hear how it would sound if you confessed.”

“I wanted it,” he said. “I wanted it before you did it.”

“Did you tell Devlin to do it? Did you tell Devlin you wanted him to fuck me?”

Josh shook his head no, but she could see cracks forming in his resolve. He’d structured much to bolster his own psyche in infidelity’s aftermath, afraid too much truth would tremble the earth and reduce him to ruins.

“Look at me,” she said, raising his chin with a finger. “I love you. I love you, and this arouses you. Look between your legs and tell me it doesn’t. We didn’t do a single thing right, but here we are, together again and still loving each other. Tell me the truth because you love me.”

A vein rose in Josh’s temple; the cords of his neck stood out. He would never admit his own complicity; she would bear the blame because she was

the stronger of the two. He shook his head in tiny increments, his brain racing with conjecture.

“You want it more than me, Josh. You want it more than me and there’s nothing wrong with that. I love you. I’m so happy to have you in my bed again.”

With that, she released him from the confrontation, stroking his neck and cheek and hair. In *real* love with him. She eased up onto the bed and slipped in behind him, kissing his collar as she got herself into place, the two of them naked in their bed, him between her legs, his hot back on her chest, her chin on his shoulder. She held the phone up so they could regard the screen and opened her photos, scrolling back.

Josh held her wrist, and she stopped scrolling. She waited, and soon he spoke, saying, “I think I asked him. I think I asked him and I’m afraid all of this was my own fault.”

She hugged her arms around his neck and kissed the back of his ear. “None of it’s your fault, Josh. It’s *all* my fault. I did everything wrong.” But here you are with everything you wanted, and I’m the only one to blame. Josh had it all. The house, a baby, a career. His darkest sexual fantasies. His wife working her ass off to give them all they’d ever want. She could take the blame. It would be nice to hear him admit it, but he might not ever know how much wrong he’d done along the way, too.

She lifted the phone again and scrolled to the series of thumbnails showing the afternoon she’d spent in Devlin’s apartment, on one of the days before all the fun with Devlin Stone had ended. She thumbed the correct video and it zoomed to take up the entire screen. Devlin Stone, gorgeous and well-built and hung like a horse and an absolute *savage* in the bedroom.

“Here it is,” she whispered in Josh’s ear.

Chapter 21

Bamboo Wife

Locked in place, Josh watched the screen held before him in his wife's elegant hand. The two of them in longitudinal arrangement, lined up and secured, ready for mach 2 like a charity gifted him a ride in an F-18, and Kimmy was the pilot. But in this strange embrace with his wife, he felt truly in tandem. There were no more lies now. Only truth. *He* was a bald-faced liar if he were to tell Kimmy he never fantasized about this. Kimmy knew he did. And she would be a wicked liar if she were to say it was only pretend. He knew she was a cheater. And he knew she regretted it. What loss had he experienced other than the loss of any innocence? And what kind of grown man wanted to lead an innocent life?

A visual tale unrolled on the phone screen; Kimmy and Devlin alone sometime together last summer. The sight reviled him in an instant, but he didn't look away. Or couldn't. Didn't want to. Kimmy held the phone, so the subject in frame was one high school bully, tall and handsome and rich, and at one time—the very time of this video—he'd been Kimmy's secret but not-so-secret lover. This man and Kimmy enjoyed a torrid affair behind his back and taunted him with insinuations, flaunting their evil right before his unwitting self. They'd humiliated him and treated him with the ultimate disrespect.

The screen showed Devlin in a room, like a bedroom; either a hotel room or maybe Devlin's apartment or Devlin's house near Kingston. Light showed the time of day to be afternoon, perhaps. Devlin wasn't wearing any clothes, at least from what Josh could tell, the view of Devlin from the hips up. One brief glimpse of his dangling package in the dim shade, but mostly Kimmy recorded Devlin from three-quarter behind, Devlin with his back to the room's center, Devlin facing a dresser. And then Devlin's face, caught reflected in the mirror at the dresser's back. That arrogant smirk, those stark cheekbones and hard jaw. Devlin said to the reflection, speaking to Kimmy holding the camera, "You are crazy. I never knew how crazy."

"I'm giving you what you want," Kimmy said to Devlin, her familiar voice thin and distant from the phone's speaker, the sound turned down low.

Kimmy whispered near his ear now, asking him if he wanted sound or not. "It's up to you. I don't want this to be too much all at once."

"I want to hear it," Josh said, but he didn't think he did. He shouldn't even be watching.

Now the camera jostled as Kimmy handed her phone over to Devlin that summer day in a bedroom somewhere, flashes of the floor, a wall, a bed. Then Devlin had the camera, holding it steady and filming his reflection, bare-chested. Josh's eyes went over Devlin's bare chest, wondering how much Kimmy had loved the feel of his skin and muscle under her fingertips—could picture those same fingers cradling the phone before his horrified eyes running over Devlin in sexual exploration.

Then Kimmy came into frame, eclipsed by Devlin, standing close to him at his back, her beautiful face looming at Devlin's bulging, masculine shoulder. She smiled, and her eyes were narrowed into malevolent slits. The sight shocked him. She didn't look like the women with him now; there was darkness in her eyes, and she wore an expression of bad intent. Those long fingers curled around Devlin's hard upper arm, her eyes on the camera lens—on Josh's eyes right now, in the present.

He reeled from the eye contact, pulling back his head, turning away. Kimmy thumbed the screen to pause the playback.

The Kimmy with him in the room—their own bedroom—was kinder, softer, than the devil on the phone. That Kimmy had been leaner and meaner. Scarier.

Kimmy whispered, “Do you want to stop?”

“No, I want to keep going. . . . What am I going to see?”

Kimmy muttered, “This is too soon,” and retreated.

“No, it’s not too soon,” he said, holding her wrist. “I want to know, so I’m not surprised.”

Kimmy hugged him from behind again, kissing his neck. She said, “I made this for you. That’s all you need to know. When I made it, I knew I would show it to you.”

Josh let her kiss his neck, loving the damp feel of her lips and the slickness of her tongue. But his eyes remained open, staring at the bedding, mind electric yet petrified.

What if this filth he watched wasn’t recorded *last* summer? What if the video was a ruse? What if Kimmy had arranged this current event as some sort of punishment—and done it in conjunction with Devlin? Did he really know if Devlin was gone? Had he looked it up? Had he done any research or hired a private eye? No, he trusted Kimmy. Trusted Kimmy to tell the truth when he knew she was capable of the worst things. Things worse than Devlin had ever done.

What if she was recording this exchange right now from some hidden camera so she could show it later to Devlin? Or worse: *what if Devlin walked out of the closet after you submit, so he and Kimmy could point at you and laugh and rub your face in it?*

“When was this?” He frowned, though anxious, feeling nothing but free-fall and abyss. “Where was it?”

Kimmy hid the screen away, still kissing his neck, her light bodyweight hot on his back. He swore he could feel the hardness of her nipples. She said, “Devlin’s apartment. It was after, you know. . . . He has a black eye here. You might not see it because he was wearing makeup.”

A sudden and unexpected smirk picked up the corner of his mouth, though it eased into a grimace. There *was* a certain joy in the remembrance of his hurtling chair, and the sight of Devlin on his hands and knees on the floor of the hotel room. “Oh, yeah?”

A soft kiss at the nape of his neck. Then she said, “Are you okay seeing me with him?”

“I think I am,” he said, bolstered by a new lightness shone on him from the memory of a large victory in his life.

“I know I hate him, here in the video,” she said. “I know I want to humiliate him.”

“I was your hero.”

Kimmy kissed his neck one more time, then chuckled. “Yeah, maybe.” The warmth of her cheek rested on his collar. “But this was before you went up north to the cottage with Meyer. Before I could try to make things right with you. If I thought you were my hero, I hadn’t told you yet.”

“If only I’d hung in there.”

“You’d never have gone in the water.”

“I *fell* in, Kimmy.”

“I know,” she said, the hand not holding the phone lay warm on his ribs, her thumb stroking his skin.

“Okay,” he said, taking her wrist and lifting the phone to where she’d held it before. “Let me watch, please.”

Kimmy’s chin on his shoulder, they watched her thumb the screen until she got the video playing again; Kimmy peeking past his shoulder, the way she did past Devlin’s in the video.

Devlin's large hands eclipsed the phone, and now, the way he'd thought of Kimmy's hands on Devlin's masculine chest, he thought of those strong hands of Devlin's on Kimmy's skin. Caressing her throat, her waist, her thighs. His fingers touching Kimmy's sex, toying with her labia, two or three sliding inside her and Kimmy's wet gushing around Devlin's digital intrusion. That raw, unbridled lust rose up inside him again; it hadn't been dormant over the last year, but it had been subdued. Held under. Bubbling up at inopportune times, like in the tent in Mexico, tormented by the photo of his beautiful wife with another man, a rich man, not wearing her wedding ring. But this here tonight was an opportune time. A supported time. There couldn't be a safer cockpit from which to indulge the wild thrill of jet-powered extramarital sin.

For the first time since their reunion, the thought of Kimmy with Devlin excited him. For a long time, under the year-long covered stovetop simmer, that part of him had withered. Now, new life pulsed through those wilted vines. Now, the sight of Kimmy's hand on Devlin's arm offered an amount of distress that drowned in a rising flux of outrageous sexual delirium. The sight of her betraying hand on this powerful man seized Josh's chest and held his breath at bay; tide pools of liquid delight eddied in the swell of his hip bones, two salacious orbs of ripe passion. His cock throbbed like a hammered thumb, hollering for attention, hard as steel and buzzing like a live wire.

And maybe there were other changes in his body, too, because, as if sensing his psyche changing gears, Kimmy said, "I love you. And I love that this arouses you. I accept it; I *embrace* it."

Meanwhile, on the screen, Devlin sneered, eyeing the Kimmy at his shoulder, filming them both, saying, "This is for you, Josh."

Hearing Devlin address him got a shiver that scrambled up his spine but soon disappeared into Kimmy's warmth pressing on his back. But as it receded, the horror of last summer loomed large, rising up like a vampire

from a coffin. All the hurt, all the anguish, all the pain and the suffering, all swelling larger and fearsome—and then last year’s horror dissipated like the shiver, soaked up into Kimmy’s embrace.

In his bedroom. In his house. In his bed. With his wife. His wife who had done so much to restore what they’d had. And one of the things they’d had, and had enjoyed, were moments just like this one. Fantasies, sure, but fantasies no more—and somehow still okay. Somehow, a cyclical process; a turning of the gear, one more trip around the sun. A little more than a year later and he and Kimmy had returned to their initial phase, altered and yet the same. A harmonic recurrence.

Now Devlin said, “Your favorite panties, Joshy? You know them...”

Kimmy slipped behind Devlin, disappearing for a moment, her arms moving, doing something while stooped over behind Devlin. Josh knew what she would do before he watched it happen. Sure enough, Devlin lowered the camera angle, no more showing his face and chest, showing Josh instead his enormous penis. Truly horse-like in a semi-engorged state. It dangled between his thighs, heavy and fat, curving a little to the right. It jostled, too, and it was from Kimmy’s action—drawing up Devlin’s thighs the tiny panties she’d once worn on her own slim hips. The ones Devlin hid. The ones he’d donned himself one time. At their sight, his cock hurt more. If Kimmy’s free hand dropped between his thighs right now and her knuckles grazed the swollen tip, he would paint the phone screen in a half-second.

Devlin’s hanging meat curled in the crotch of Kimmy’s panties, then tumbled aside, its bulk unsupportable by the narrow crotch. Video-Kimmy lifted the straps at the hips, snugging the panties up into place, both Kimmy and Devlin snuffling amusement at their naughty endeavor. The green embroidered satin delta, the dainty cover meant to shield a woman’s dearest flesh, cupped over the heft of Devlin’s oversized genitals. One testicle squeezed aside and sagged opposite his huge wrinkled penis. Kimmy, on

the video, laughed, and her hand appeared, working to fit Devlin's penis back under the fabric. It was futile; the man's penis was far too large.

Devlin said, "Remember when you wore them and your little dick stuck straight up inside? . . . I swear, Kimmy, his dick stretched it out, but I didn't see *any* skin."

The sound of Kimmy's laughter killed him. The Kimmy beside him, the same one in the video, snuffling soft laughter in the present, hot damp breath on his collar.

Chapter 22

Chymical Wedding

For the first time he could remember, this event brought no shame or humiliation, and instead of hostility, he right-faced Kimmy, surprised, and also showing her haughty offense. Not even at the size humiliation, but at the audacity of her laughter; her willingness to bring playful abashment. It was a line crossed. Not a bad line, but one he was surprised she was already conditioned to cross. The timing surprised him; she'd been reluctant to begin this, telling him he wasn't ready. There was a new audacity; where earlier she'd been timid and hesitant, now she joked in ways that showed her powerful ability to master a moment. But master it in a manner meant for his own benefit.

Kimmy paused the video, Devlin frozen mid-taunt.

Josh said, "I take it you think I'm ready now?"

And in that fragile moment, where misunderstandings could seize control and turn the night in a terrible direction, there was a connection through their gaze that he welcomed. A togetherness she'd convinced him was true when they'd played games with dirty stories, when she had him believing it was the two of them against Devlin. She'd lied then, but maybe, given all that had transpired since, Kimmy intended a time like tonight where she could reclaim her affair for themselves. He didn't think she'd ever had any genuine feelings for Devlin.

“Maybe you are,” she said, her eyes dropping to his mouth. He leaned his head closer, and they kissed, mouths mismatched but connected.

When her hand touched his side, he flinched and pulled away his kiss. His elbow tucked in to block Kimmy’s touch.

“Let’s be careful,” he said. At his words, Kimmy’s eyes studied his, and he could glean she considered if he meant he wasn’t comfortable yet with this kind of play. But it was the opposite, and he saw her expression as she inferred his meaning: this is working, and if you move too fast, it might end before it had even begun.

“I didn’t know if I was ready for this. I was faking, to be honest. Hoping we could get somewhere back to normal.”

“This is normal,” she said—and not as a question, but as a statement.

“I guess it is,” he said.

“I love you,” she said, no smile, eyes lowered. He said it in return.

A sweet moment, but now a real complexity: the transition from this sweet intimacy to a video where his high school bully would intimidate him, say cruel things, and his wife would play on the video with his bully’s enormous penis. But he was sure Kimmy’s claim was true; that this escapade he witnessed a year later on her phone had been performed and recorded for his own pleasure.

And Kimmy understood the dilemma and his uncomfortable placement. She said, “This was what I wanted for you. I wanted *us* to be the tormentors, and for Devlin to be our well-endowed toy. We would use him for our own fun, and our pleasure would come at his expense.”

He straightened in the cockpit, the space between Kimmy’s open legs, her naked breasts on his back, her chin at his shoulder. She faced the phone screen to him again, and he regarded it now, Devlin there, smudged in paused motion, sneering, ready for the taunts to continue to flow. He told Kimmy to play it, and she did.

Devlin continued: “—his little dick poked a tent-pole in the fabric. God, Josh is such a horny devil. All that pent-up lust and all he’s got for delivery is a double-A battery. And his wife needs a lot more than that. She needs a man’s cock. She needs it deep to get off.”

Now Kimmy’s hand in the video spread clawed fingers wide and cupped the satin heft of Devlin’s genitals stuffed into the panties. He was more than her hand could support, even with the fingers out wide. One of Devlin’s extra-large testicles escaped her clutch completely, sagging out of the flimsy fabric between the V of her pinky and ring finger. The sight of his wife’s beautiful hand on something too large and erotically ugly provoked an exquisite but awful excitement.

Devlin said, “But she’s got me for what she needs, Josh. I give it to her so good. She begs for it deep. . . . Ah, fuck, that feels good. Yeah, get me hard for Josh to see. You like her fingers wrapped around my cock? Make a circle, Kimmy, show him how thick I am.”

Kimmy’s hand swished aside, tugged up the panties’ front patch and let Devlin’s fattening penis tumble out and swing against his leg. When her hand gripped it near the middle, the end bloated, and the head of his cock swelled larger. Her hand stroked up, cinching his cock skin to a turtleneck that choked up the flared ridge of his purpling glans. Kimmy made hissing sounds of delight, loving the feel of this other man’s magnificent cock in her grip.

“God, that is so big,” Josh said.

Kimmy kissed his neck, whispering, “He’s huge.”

“Do you love it? Love how big he is?”

Kimmy kissed his neck again, nibbling a little. “You know I do.”

He watched the screen like he was stoned, mesmerized by this psychedelic unreal sight: his wife’s hand, the one with the wedding ring, getting his high school bully’s huge cock nice and hard, stroking him with

care and with obvious foreknowledge, able to please Devlin with earned skill. He said, "You really know how to handle that thing."

"He makes my hand look so small."

"You have such beautiful hands."

"You like seeing my hand on his cock?"

"It's grotesque," he said. "But in the best way."

Kimmy's breath grew hot on his neck while they watched her urge Devlin's member to a raging ramrod of mythical size. Her panties had cinched a line up the center of his scrotum, and a ball hung down on either side, jiggling with her hand movements. Once he was hard, Kimmy seemed now to display it for the camera Devlin held, maybe like she was viewing the screen with him, holding it outright, showing off the length, then, as Devlin had asked, attempting to circle her thumb and middle finger around mid-shaft, not coming quite close enough to touch.

Devlin said, "You like it."

And Kimmy, on the video, purred, "It's beautiful."

It had become too much to take. With each pulse of blood that pumped up Devlin's monstrous cock, he'd come closer and closer to losing it. Like the blood pulsed into him, exciting him to a point of bursting. It was anger and jealousy and hurt and an intense sexual desire that consumed him. The video had pushed him to his limit, and they'd barely started. He had to look away.

Kimmy paused the video, hugging him tighter, putting the phone down on the bedding. "It's too early, Josh. It's too early."

He enjoyed the hug, rode its pleasure for a moment, then shrugged her away. "It's not that," he said, rolling to his side on one of her legs, laying sideways on the bed over it. His hand grabbed a wad of bedding and squeezed. "It's good, it's just..."

Kimmy rubbed his shoulder. "It's what?"

"Just give me a minute," he said, squeezing his eyes shut.

“Are you okay?”

“Yeah-yeah,” he grunted. “It’s a lot. It’s . . . good.”

Kimmy’s hand on his shoulder stroked down his side, and it sent him into the stratosphere. He rolled away from her touch, ready to explode, getting off her thigh and onto his knees and elbows on the bed next to her, his forehead planted on the mattress. His stomach quivered and his hardness throbbed and ached and shivers of pleasure radiated in silvery lines from the tip to the root, then from there spreading like voltage gradient, zinging through his viscera and into his chest. He admitted to Kimmy in choking gasps what was wrong: that he didn’t want to come.

Kimmy’s hand stroked his back, but as it stroked lower, toward his ass, he whimpered and moved away. “Gimme a minute.”

“You’re not going to come, Josh,” Kimmy said, with firm command. Enough, he side-peeked to see her up on her knees, a determined look on her face. She pushed him over to his back and he drew up his knees for a brief moment, then let them drop, surrendering himself to her. Putting his orgasm under her control. Kimmy smiled at the sight of his erection and the shining river of lubricant running from the tip. He closed his eyes and wished for her to grip it and stroke it and bring the release shining on the horizon. But she didn’t. Instead, she straddled him, getting his wrists and holding them over his head. She looked fucking stunning. And in a glorious spike, he felt rising love and adoration for her. She was a gift. A beautiful and smart woman who would play a game with him that brought much sexual delight. She’d bought their house, bore their child. She did everything. And she loved him.

He smiled, and she smiled, too.

She said, “You’re enjoying my video?”

“You’re the cruelest person I know,” he said, still smiling.

“We’re not even at the best part yet.”

“You have a favorite part?” he asked, playful.

Her smile faded, but not the warmth in her eyes. She said, “I don’t think we’re there yet, Josh. I warned you.”

She had warned him away from the video, and all he’d thought was she was protecting herself from his furthered anger, but he’d never anticipated not being ready because of the video’s extreme provocation. This wasn’t like the afternoon in the Yorkville hotel room, where she’d tried to put his penis next to Devlin’s. That hadn’t worked. It couldn’t work because Devlin was in the room. Devlin’s presence changed his brain chemistry, disallowed any pleasure from the moment; all he’d experienced was anguish. But this video shown in retrospect, one where his wife had played against Devlin for her husband’s benefit, was altogether different. Without Devlin’s presence, it was Josh and Kimmy again.

“I’m not ready for your favorite part?”

Kimmy sucked in her lower lip, shaking her head no. The prospects riled him. What could be so outrageous he needed better preparation?

He said, “Do you like seeing him again?”

Kimmy’s mouth corners turned down, and she shook her head no again. It wasn’t the whole answer.

He said, “Do you like seeing his cock again?”

Kimmy stayed expressionless and his heart ratcheted up good and tight, waiting for her real response. She smiled a little, then bit her lower lip. The hand holding his right wrist guided his reach down between them, where the space was warm and humid, where his cock ached mere inches away from his wife’s entry. The missed heartbeats galloped away now, knowing what she wanted him to feel and astounded by how dirty they both were.

She said, “Feel me,” and he did, finding her pussy sopping wet, hot and slick.

“You’re gushing,” he said, running his fingers through her greased folds, furrowing through the flesh to find her aperture and putting two

fingers inside her, watching her eyes close and her face turn upward. “You miss his cock.”

“Yeah,” she gasped, and he folded, almost spilling his seed, drawing up his knees again, knowing if any part of her touched his live wire, there’d be a catastrophic result. He helped heave her aside, his long-legged wife and her flooded pussy getting to her back on their bed, hiding her shame now, knees together, protecting from her husband the devilish reality that another man’s cock made her horny as hell.

Josh rolled out of bed and crouched by its side. He peered at Kimmy laying on the bed, naked and gorgeous, watching him with playful amusement and the appropriate measure of shame.

“You’re so beautiful,” he said.

She smiled and snuffled a small laugh. “Can I make you come, please?”

He rose and stood, let her see his own magnificent specimen, maybe less than half the size in volume, and wasn’t embarrassed that his size-queen wife could see it. His stomach ached; his balls ached. It would be so easy to knee onto the bed and let Kimmy slip her long fingers around his meager girth and he would finish in seconds. But he had other plans, crossing the room now, headed to the other side, knowing what to do.

Chapter 23

Malebolges & Male Bulges

The dildo was cold and inhuman under his touch. Toys were nothing like the real thing. But when choosing such an item for her own pleasure, Kimmy Chang had bought the biggest dick in the sex store. Kimmy liked *size*. Not just as a vague rhetoric on aesthetics, but for the physical response, the tactile interference into her interior; getting stretched, getting stuffed, getting reamed out, having her organs displaced. All the rude offerings spewed in men's spaces were true with the woman Josh Waters had married. She might be tall and thin, and her pussy might be tight, but she possessed an affinity and keenness for a certain trait in male sex organs.

The thing was heavy. It wobbled when he shook it. Did Devlin's do that? And if it did, did Kimmy like shaking it and watching it wobble?

Shame bloomed, but he found he could push it back with sound reasoning. Like, try as he might to pretend the past was the past, the truth was much of what happened between them last summer was unresolved. Time had passed, but no patches or mending had truly begun. Maybe he could find peace in reuniting with the hot and flammable moments that he'd shared with Kimmy. The times when they'd explored this dark engine that wanted to open up on the highway and see how fast they could go. He'd been unsure and ashamed but Kimmy showed him support and played with him. All of that was real. Those things happened. And though the fantasies

they'd spun together were realer than he wanted, those times with Kimmy had been electrified with strange passion and vulnerability and delightful perversion.

With his back to Kimmy—waiting for him in bed, knowing what he was doing but unable to see—he tested the dildo's girth, circling his thumb and middle finger. They met with moderate effort, but the thickness astounded him. How could his wife accommodate such a thing?

He turned to regard her now, found her ready and waiting, on her back, legs slinking, resting on her elbows, all long limbs and sexy stare and tawny skin that looked dark-tanned against the light color of their bedding. Her beauty ached in his heart.

He smiled and showed the weapon to her. It wobbled, and he dropped it down to his thigh, stepping back to the bed and crawling on it to meet her in the pillows. Her hand went right to the thing she craved: the replica of Devlin's penis. Her fingertips toyed with the shape of the cock head, her eyes darting from there to his eyes. "What do you want to do with this?"

He remained silent, looking down between them where he held the replica and where his wife's fingers smoothed sexual shapes, reminiscing about the man who did things to her that her husband never could. He said, "Did you ever measure him?"

Kimmy shook her head, soft silky hair on the pillow. Then she whispered, "No. Why do you need a number? We know how yours looked up against his." She circled one hand at the dildo's base, her pinky curled on the molded scrotum.

"We did," he said, stomach turning, cock aching, thinking of that awful afternoon in Yorkville, watching Kimmy move her other hand to grip above the first, then swapping out, laddering up the enormous dildo, three hand lengths, then one half as she gripped the cock head, a massive rubber plum in her elegant grip. She swirled the hand on the cock head the way he imagined she liked to do with Devlin.

Both of them watched her stroke the massive toy held between their bodies, their heads drawing closer on the pillows until their foreheads almost touched.

She said, “Devlin’s curved, and I liked the shape of his cock head better than this one. His was larger.”

“It was?”

“Yeah,” she said, squeezing and caressing the fake glans, about twice the size or more than his own.

He offered a complaint out of instinct, a point against Devlin’s magnificent cock, saying, “His dick was two-toned.”

“Yeah,” Kimmy agreed. “I wonder how it would look if no one circumcised him.”

“You’d prefer that?”

Kimmy’s eyes drifted up to meet his, and she smiled, letting go of the toy, then rolling away, reclining and opening her torso, her arms coming up above her head. “I asked you what you were going to do with that.”

“Do we need lube?”

“I don’t think so,” she said and chuckled, helping him guide the end of the dildo between her thighs.

“You really want it,” he said, an unfortunate petulance in his tone. Like a disgusted condemnation—his former *modus operandi*, the one that heaped the lion’s share of blame onto Kimmy. There was no blame to share anymore—the slate was clear, and each knew the enjoyment of the other.

And savvy Kimmy rode right over his speed bump like she drove on Air-Ride suspension, saying, “You really want to give it to me too,” which was correct. Maybe he didn’t have to explain anymore how his kink’s straps got cinched tighter by his indignation. Her agency heightened the thrill—the more control she held, the more lust, and the better he cherished the disgust because it honed her libertine blade. It put all of this on her like he

was an innocent man forced to endure a gory Moral Spectacle in the public square. The umbrage put his chin higher, braced him for greater impact.

Slipping into a new role was easy; he assumed the demeanor of a reluctant husband, enduring a dark and reluctant navigation of his wife's shameful and humiliating need. *Kimmy needed a big one, and her husband didn't have a big one.* This brave husband sidled next to his wife, watching the Devlin replica as he moved it between her thighs. Kimmy's hands swept her flat tummy in eager anticipation. Devlin's erect cock was similar in length to her forearm and thicker than her wrist. Kimmy's rump raised from the bed to meet the first pressure he applied with the replica (*though she liked the size and shape of Devlin's cock head more*). The movement was eased by Kimmy's gushing excitement, slick crackling, now followed by Kimmy's heavy breathing. Her breathing hitched as he penetrated her, then a quick gasp as the toy's (smaller) head breached her. As soon as she sensed the deeper situation, her hips roiled and humped, and he swore, through peristaltic action, Kimmy compelled the Devlin replica deeper, the rubber passing along his grip. He drew it back and watched his wife's back bow. The toy inched deeper, reclaiming its prior entry. Her thighs went in and out, and she uttered a pleading whimper in her throat.

Odd thoughts coalesced; pulp-fiction science explaining in his head that Kimmy could only squeeze that way on thick ones; that her pussy loved to milk Devlin, but hubby Josh's pecker proved too skinny to get a grip on. A wash of erotic shame flooded him and left an eerie glee when it receded. He scooted downward, kisses working along Kimmy's breast, her ribs, tummy, and hip. Kimmy's legs parted to accommodate him, and he took the space, getting a Devlin's-eye view of how beautiful Kimmy Chang looked when she was in heat and getting the kind of dick she needed.

So he used it on her. Used it and studied her response. Used it and watched it go in and out of her. Watched that tenderest of places pummeled

by Devlin's rubber facsimile. Kimmy humped it. Kimmy worked with him, reacting to his own thrusts and teasing.

His wife looked different this way. He was used to her reaction with him. Used to her responses to his actions separated from this implement and using his own equipment. Kimmy's hips rolled and her back arched and after a while her hands went to her chest and squeezed her own breasts in a manner he considered too harsh. This big dick drove her wild. In fact, after some time, her skin shone with the sweat of excitement. It was a beautiful sight to behold and yet it screwed up his stomach and tightened his chest.

Imagine what Devlin did to her. How could she ever hate their time together when he must have driven her out of her mind? This was how she was when she was with Devlin. And he knew that already, had seen it with his own eyes. And yet, somehow, it hurt better knowing he could replicate it in some small measure.

When she urged him to put it deeper, he asked her if she was sure. It didn't seem proper. It didn't seem enjoyable.

"Deeper," she urged him again.

And now, he took better command, getting over top of her, Devlin's big fake cock in his right hand, his left planting over her shoulder. He was looking down at her now, his face over hers. She bit her lips. He pushed the huge toy deeper and watched her face contort into a horrifying mask of dolorous ecstasy.

The face she made in the Yorkville hotel room.

Kimmy naked but for Devlin's tie wrapped around her eyes as a blindfold. Devlin with his cock in her, no condom, and Josh watching it all. "Kimmy likes it deep," Devlin had said. "Loves it."

He withdrew and plunged, again and again, doing it slowly and meant for Kimmy's maximum pleasure.

Devlin with Kimmy, Devlin fucking her and taunting Josh at the same time. *No woman can take it like your wife, Josh. No woman wants it like she*

does. Her little pussy was made for my cock.

Devlin folding Kimmy in half, fucking her in the same position Josh was in now, but bringing her chin to her hips, shortening the planes, her tummy scrunching, spacetime folding so the end of Devlin's cock could touch Kimmy's deepest trigger.

Kimmy's got a G-spot up here, Joshy. You ever hit it?

But he couldn't fold Kimmy in half. Wouldn't. Fold her in half and ram her over and over with a big fake cock? He didn't even know what he was doing. He slowed the pace, still pleasuring her but not wanting to ape Devlin's prowess.

He took her hand, kept stroking the toy, asking her, "You like it deep?"

She nodded and gasped. His cock ached, and he darted a look down to see an unstopping stream of his pre-cum spilling onto her hipbone. The pressure in his belly for release quivered at bloatmax, and pyroclastic surges warned of catastrophic eruption.

He wanted now to feed her more, but it didn't feel right. It felt too deep, and there was more resistance. But, boy, if he could make her come—if *he could make her squirt!*—then things would be different. But to try and fail on a night like tonight would bring unhappiness. And though he wasn't entirely sure, he suspected he was happy.

He let the Devlin replica remain imbedded and allowed Kimmy to fuck it. Her pussy gripping and humping, his wife showing her teeth; a vein rose on her neck as she went wild on the big dick.

"He said you have a G-spot up there. Is that real?"

Kimmy moaned, mouth falling open, eyes squeezed shut. Her hands went to him, her claws on his sides. He pushed a little deeper, worried he'd hurt her, but Kimmy's head rolled back and she cried out in rapture.

He'd left her huffing, skin shining. She'd come, but he'd produced no watery explosions. But seeing the flush on her chest and the way she smiled now, coming out of her pleasure, had a flood of emotion wash through him,

making him shudder. A ton of fear and hurt lifted for a brief moment, and it felt incredible.

Kimmy, though dazed, was still eager, humping the cock again, reclining sleepily on the pillow, eyes narrowed and peaceful, but one brow arched at a sharp, sly angle. “It’s real,” she whispered, grinding her hips. “It’s real, but I think it’s deeper.”

He looked down at the cock, not all the way inside her. “You think?”

She inhaled and sucked on her lips for a second, then said, “Devlin knew where it was. He has nerve endings in the end of his cock and he just knew where to put it.”

The smile eased away from his face, and dull dread lifted in his heart. Remembrances of Kimmy’s keenness on the size and shape of Devlin’s manhood poisoned the good working in his veins. But helped that, too. In fact, there was much pleasure in resisting the awfulness of his wife’s lust and libido.

“He did?”

She said, “I didn’t even know it was there.”

No. Of course she didn’t. How would she? Her husband didn’t have the equipment she needed. That was the terrain for better men. Ones who deserved her.

Kimmy’s hand touched his neck, cupped his cheek. Her eyes were awake now. “Did I go too far?”

He was quick to assure her she hadn’t, shaking out of the reverie, returning to her. A sickness tightened in his belly. The need for release was urgent; its demand loud and sharp and incessant; a thrumming ache in his balls he could get rid of in seconds. He said, “Not too far at all.” Then: “I want to see the rest of the video.”

Kimmy’s expression didn’t change, but he read the twinkle of reticence, a shimmer over her black eyes. “I don’t think it’s a good idea, Josh.” Her voice was soft and compelling.

“That’s why I want to see it.” His voice was alluring and solicitous.

Now her expression changed, softening to compassion. “It gets worse, Josh. I mean it.”

“I want to see.”

Kimmy rolled her head back on the pillow and raked a hand through her hair. The act of ecstasy and also one of frustration—she wanted him to see it, but didn’t think he was ready. Her reluctance cranked up his need to eleven. There could be no way tonight he didn’t watch her video with Devlin in her panties.

Chapter 24

Fleurs de Mal

“**O**ne time, when we couldn’t fuck, she had me jerk off a big pearly load into her panties—and you were just around the corner, buddy,” Devlin was saying on the video, filming from his chest, the view in the dresser mirror. The reflection showed what he’d seen before: Kimmy eclipsed at Devlin’s side, her left arm curling around at Devlin’s hip, her grip on Devlin’s massive dick. “She loves my cum on her pussy.” This was Devlin’s dirty talk. Yes, he was taunting him, but these were the words that turned Devlin on. These were the dirty thoughts that aroused him. “Your birthday or some shit,” Devlin was saying, grunting, hissing, loving the pleasure of freestyling his oral bullying while the nerd’s wife stroked his huge dick.

Meanwhile, here in real life, the very same woman from the video reenacted the scene. Both of them kneeled center-bed, facing the headboard. This time, *he* held the phone. Kimmy watched over his shoulder, watching what she’d done, watching her own hand choking Devlin’s enormous chicken. There was a bottomless drop-away feeling, being with his wife and together witnessing the grotesque beauty of her former lover’s sexual implement. The drop-away was a good feeling; a wrestling, awkward joy. For whatever reason, the feeling made his balls like lead weights, hanging heavy in the hammock of his sack. Kimmy’s hand stroked his hips and thighs, knowing any venture close to the midline would set her husband off.

He anticipated Kimmy would coordinate a mutual ejaculation, synchronizing her husband's orgasm with the video of her big-dick tryst. And that had him wondering if Kimmy had ever later watched this video on her own—and if she had, did she enjoy it?

“I think about that one all the time,” Devlin was saying off-screen, Kimmy's grip struggling on his girth, cock skin shining from Devlin's lubrication, giving this magnificent thing slow, luxurious strokes. Kimmy's beautiful long fingers shone with Devlin's semen; the supple, flared lip of his cock head squashing under her stroke.

Kimmy on the screen, but face unseen, chuckled at Devlin's confession. She said to him, “You do?”

“Mm, yes,” Devlin grumbled. “You're so fucking hot. So fucking dirty. You make me crazy.”

When there was the sound of them kissing, Kimmy's hands slid from Josh's hips up to his shoulders, as if to brace him through this awful ordeal. She kissed his neck, softly bit at his collar.

He asked her, “Is it true?”

And she said it was. She must have made Devlin crazy. Yes, he was sure she had Devlin drop a load in the crotch of the panties she wore. It made him realize one astounding thing: Kimmy's betrayal must have devastated Devlin.

The intent of the video hit him now, a whole new perspective opening up like palace gates. If Kimmy arranged and performed this theater for him—and he believed she had—then Devlin was the sucker here. Kimmy was the bully. Kimmy encouraged Devlin's secrets, his hopes and dreams, and the things that motivated him; encouraged the revelation of Devlin's rather sad passion for humiliating a guy from grade school who'd only ever wanted to be left alone.

“By now you've heard the news,” Devlin said, and began moving, the camera's viewpoint jostling for a moment, before steadying again, showing

Devlin with his left arm reaching behind him, touching Kimmy. Seeing him touch Kimmy turned Josh's stomach over and tightened his chest.

Josh flinched at this direct communication; the taunts could be expected, but this conversational addressing unnerved him, and dread loomed. A bloom of sweat formed on his upper lip and he held his breath in awful anticipation. And behind him, Kimmy seemed to still—as though steeling herself to what would come.

Devlin continued, his voice low and mocking, “And, hey, guess what, Joshy? That little baby of hers? Yeah, that's *my* baby. You're gonna raise her for me, aren't you, though, buddy?”

Josh's grip struggled on the phone. Behind him, Kimmy's breath hitched, her fingers digging into his shoulders.

“You know how it works, right?” Devlin sneered, his hips bucking slightly, Kimmy's hand still wrapped around his thick shaft. “If you want to make a baby, you gotta plant the seed real deep. You know how she likes it deep, Joshy. Must be some biological need or something.”

Each word was a high-school slug to the gut, but he couldn't look away from the screen. Kimmy smoothed warm hands on his shoulders and his cock buzzed and thrummed, hard and quivering upright.

“Her cervix is so deep, man,” Devlin grunted as Kimmy's strokes became firmer. “She needs a real man to do the job. You just couldn't cut it, could you, Joshy?” Sex and desire thickened his growling voice, breath hitching as he spoke, loving the whole thing, so into this ultimate cruelty.

Kimmy's nails bit into Josh's skin, her breath hot on his neck. “Don't listen to him, Josh,” she whispered, voice trembling. “He's just trying to hurt you.”

“But you're hurting him,” he said, though the damage was done. Devlin's words were a toxin, flooding Josh's veins, filling him with rage and despair. He watched, helpless, as Devlin threw his head back, his body tensing as he neared his climax.

“Fuck, Kimmy,” Devlin groaned, his hips jerking. “You’re so fucking good at this.”

Josh’s heart pounded, breath in ragged gasps. He felt Kimmy’s hand slide down his arm, fingers intertwining with his. She was shaking, her body pressed against his back, cheek resting on his shoulder.

“I’m sorry, Josh,” she whispered. “I’m so sorry.”

Josh didn’t respond, frozen, eyes locked on the screen, watching as Devlin’s body convulsed, stomach flexing, his release imminent. The room spun, and he suffered the sudden sensation of falling, of sinking. Of drowning.

Devlin’s voice returned. “That little pecker of yours, Joshy, it’s not meant for real women. Not women like Kimmy.”

Kimmy’s fingers dug deeper into his shoulders. The room shrank, the walls closing in as Devlin mocked him.

“God made her this way to keep out the riffraff,” Devlin sneered. Kimmy’s hand still gripped around his shaft. “But don’t worry, I got the job done for her. You can reap the benefit.”

Kimmy’s nails bit into his skin, her breath hot on his neck. “She’s yours, Josh.”

“I know you’ll take great care of my baby,” Devlin grunted, body tensing as he neared climax. The camera’s viewpoint jostled, showing Devlin’s sneering, sweaty face contorted with pleasure, before returning to the mirror, showing Kimmy’s hand stroking his massive, throbbing member. His wife’s familiar hand on another man’s cock: the familiar fingers, the angle of her thumb, the tendons he knew so well.

Kimmy was shaking, pressed against Josh’s back. “I’m sorry, Josh.”

Josh’s breath struggled in short, sharp gasps. Kimmy’s voice whispered apologies in his ear, hands sliding up and down his arms. Her touch was electric, a jolt that shot straight to his balls. Despite the venom spewing from the screen, his body responded, his erection jerking and leaking.

"I'm sorry, Josh," she murmured again, breath hot on his neck.

Now her hand moved from his arm to his hip, his stomach flexing in terrible anticipation. Then across his belly and lower, fingers circling his meager length, stroking him in time with the cruel rhythm of Devlin's grunts as she jerked his huge cock on the video.

"Fuck, Kimmy," Devlin groaned on the screen, hips jerking, orgasm imminent, and Josh's heart raced out of control. Devlin urged Kimmy to jerk his monster faster, and Kimmy, with him here in the safety of their marital bedroom, obeyed, jerking faster tonight, getting Josh bucking and whimpering.

Devlin's grunts grew heavier, more insistent. The camera angle shifted, the view tilting downward, showing the reflection of Devlin's massive cock in Kimmy's struggling grip, the huge swollen head gleaming. "Here it comes, Joshy," Devlin growled. "You see this? This is what a real man looks like, mm, when he's about to fucking *explode*."

Kimmy's hand moved faster, her grip tightening around Devlin's cock, squeezing and screwing like she couldn't wait to see Devlin's orgasmic firework show. On the screen, her breath hitched, a small moan escaping her lips. The sound slipped a shiver down his spine, a mix of revulsion and unwanted arousal.

"Fuck, Kimmy," Devlin groaned, his hips jerking forward. The first spurt of his ejaculation hit the mirror with an audible splat, the thick, white liquid streaming down the reflection of their entwined bodies. "Look at that, Joshy. Look at all that, mm, fucking baby batter. . . . That's what you need to make a fucking *baby*." The eruption continued, the second and third bursts bigger than the first.

Kimmy on the video chuckled, a low, throaty sound that Josh knew well. Her hand slowed, milking Devlin's cock as he continued to spurt, painting the mirror with his awesome release. "God, Devlin," she groaned, her voice filled with admiration. "That's so fucking hot."

Each word, each sound, was a twisting knife. He couldn't look away, couldn't stop the incendiary mix of pain and arousal coursing through him. Kimmy's hand moved faster on his own smaller manhood, her grip tightening, matching the rhythm of her strokes on the screen.

"You see that, Joshy?" Devlin growled, his voice triumphant. "That's what a real man looks like. That's what your fucking wife needs."

Kimmy on the video moaned again, her hand slowing as Devlin's orgasm subsided. She chuckled, her eyes locked on the mirror, watching as Devlin's release slid down the glass. "God, that's so much cum," she said, filled with awe, as she squeezed and milked Devlin's beefy cock.

"I'm lying to him, Josh, I'm sorry, it's not how it sounds," she whispered.

The room spun, the walls closing in as his body convulsed at last. He tried to hold back, to fight the inevitable, but it was futile. With a guttural groan, he exploded, his release lining the bed in a series of weak and watery ropes.

The video ended abruptly, the screen going black on the two biggest bullies combined in sexual depravity. His breath came in heaving gulps, heart pounding in his ears. Kimmy's hand stilled, thumb and finger circling behind his cock head. The room was dead silent.

The phone slipped from his grasp, falling to the bed, Devlin's torture echoing in the black cavern of his malformed mind.

Kimmy slipped to the bed, pulling on his arm but not luring him enough to follow, laying on her back, eyes rolling up, both her hands going between her thighs. She grabbed a handful of slim flesh on her skinny thigh with one hand, the other planting down two long fingers that thrummed over her wet petals.

Her eyes fluttered closed as the fingers moved in a sickening frenzy over her engorged clit, the crackling wet sound showing the enormity of her

carnal hunger. Josh watched, transfixed, as she writhed on the bed beside him. Her lips parted, soft gasps escaping as she lost herself in the moment.

"Josh," she squeaked. Her fingers quickened their pace, her hips arching off the bed as she chased her release.

Josh's heart pounded, body still tingling from his own climax, but he couldn't look away from the sight of his wife, so uninhibited, so raw. Devlin's cruelty did his to her. Those taunts of paternity and infidelity and humiliating submission, of crushing a woman's husband under the weight of his undeniable sexual power, turned Kimmy Chang on. She was *worse* than the man who'd ruined his life.

Her breath came in short, sharp pants now, body trembling as she neared the edge. Josh watched the flush spreading across her tawny chest, the sheen of sweat on her brow. Her eyes remained closed, her mind lost in some dark, depraved fantasy that he could only imagine.

"Fuck," she gasped, her body stiffening as she pushed herself over the edge, crying out, twisting and contorting in naked beauty.

Soon, her hand stilled, the fingers pressing against her clit as she rode out the last waves of her orgasm. Josh watched, his worn out and deflated cock twitching in response to her unbridled pleasure.

Kimmy's eyes fluttered open, meeting his gaze, a mix of shame and still-burning desire swirling in their dark depths. She bit her lip, a soft moan escaping as she withdrew her hands from between her thighs.

Josh's mind raced with thoughts of what had just transpired. He had watched his wife masturbate, had seen the awful lust that lurked inside her. And he had been turned on by it, had found himself drawn into her web of depravity even though he'd once escaped. He couldn't deny the connection they shared. A dark bond tied them together. But he also couldn't shake the unease settling in his center, the knowledge that their new and reignited relationship was built on her lies and betrayal.

As the haze of her pleasure began to clear, Josh regarded his wife, her eyes studying him, her chest heaving, her body glistening with sweat. She was a fucking vision, an evil temptress, a siren calling him to doom. And despite everything, he couldn't help but reach for her, his fingers brushing a strand of hair from her gorgeous face.

In that moment, there was no Devlin, no video, no betrayal. There was only the two of them, lost in a sea of uncertain desire and sad regret.

Then he crumpled, Devlin's boasting taunts rising up in his mind like mountain-borne thunderclaps.

A raw, guttural sound tore from his chest, the first of many heaving sobs that wracked his body. Total annihilation swept through him like a storm. He folded, curling like an inchworm, forehead pushed into the bed, naked ass in the air, then slumping to his side in his own weak wet spot. He cried out his daughter's sweet name.

Kimmy was at his side in an instant, her arms wrapping around him, issuing a desperate litany of reassurances. "It's not true, Josh. It's all lies. Devlin's wrong. I lied to him to get what I wanted. To hurt him. Please, Josh . . . Colleen is yours, only *yours*. I swear it. You know it." Her hands cupped his face, forcing him to meet her gaze, her eyes shining with unshed tears.

But the damage was done. The poison had entered his veins, and a dark miasma clouded his thoughts and squeezed his heart. He gasped for breath, each inhale a shuddering, painful affair. The sobs came in waves, crashing over him, pulling him under.

Kimmy held him tighter, her voice steady and sure, a lifeline. "He's lying, Josh. He's just trying to hurt you. Colleen is your daughter. She's ours."

He clung to her words, to the promise they held. He fought his way back to the surface. His mind cleared, the fog of devastation lifting, leaving behind a bruised and wounded landscape.

"I need her, Kimmy," he rasped, his voice raw and wounded. "I need Colleen. I need her."

Chapter 25

And Perhaps Her Grave

D evlin's menace still hung between them. Those things he'd said—she'd *encouraged* him to say—had been the cruelest words, the vilest barbs. Bottomless depravity.

She had pushed too far, too fast. A pang of regret twisted in her heart. She should have known better. *Why had she let Josh talk her into it?*

But she knew why. It was *exciting* to show Josh too early. Early would deliver a greater and harsher impact. Danger burned hot sweaty lust in her heart.

"I want Colleen," Josh said again.

"We'll get her, but first, we need to shower," she said. "We need to clean up. Okay?"

Josh looked at her. "Shower?"

"Yeah, come on, come with me." She tugged at his arm. "You get in the shower, and I'll make the bed. I'll join you in a second. Colleen can't come in like this."

She led him to the bathroom and turned on the shower. Josh stood, eyes distant but following her movements.

"Get under the water, Josh. I'll be right back."

She slipped out of the room and stripped the bed, balling the sheets up and tossing them into the laundry basket. Her old phone lay on the

nightstand where she'd put it, screen showing now an ominous void. She snatched it up and hid it away in the closet, bound for the safe later. Out of sight, but never out of mind. She knew the damage it held, and Josh had only seen the smallest portion.

Then back to the bathroom and the sound of water hitting the tiles. Josh's wavering flesh tone moved behind the frosted glass, his head under the stream. She cracked open the door, steam billowing out, saw Josh standing under the spray, his head bowed, water cascading down his back—then back to the bed. She grabbed a fresh set of bedding from the closet, made the bed, plumped the pillows, setting them neatly against the headboard, back to the bathroom and slipping into the shower behind Josh.

Josh regarded her over his shoulder, some nice life showing in those eyes—and the smallest of smiles. A guilty smile, but that was always a good one. She rubbed his collar, reached for the soap, lathering her hands, gliding them over his shoulders, down his arms. She washed him with care. Her hands moved lower, washing his stomach, his hips, her touch intimate but not sexual. She thought more of healing, more of care.

At last, Josh turned to face her, bringing her into the spray and warmth and into his arms. His eyes showed hurt, but there was love there, too. And, lo-and-behold, perhaps some humor as well. An admission that what just happened between them was crazy. Outlawed. Depraved. So, so nasty.

But now it was over.

Her body pressed his, arms wrapping him, their skin soft and soap-slippery. Her cheek pressed Josh's neck. And *she* smiled, too. They stood under the warm spray, sharing the somber moment, not saying a thing.

Then Josh, far away but happy somehow, said, "How am I ever going to feel safe with you, Kimmy?"

Kimmy's hands raked through his wet hair, holding a handful at his crown, the water running over them in warm sheets. A thousand answers jammed in the doorway; rushing lies. She breathed in and held it. Then let it

out, her nails running his scalp. “You won’t, Josh. I don’t think you’ll ever feel safe with me.”

Josh’s expression didn’t change, watching her with steady intent, eyes awake now, but narrowed in scrutiny. He leaned his head back into the spray, still watching her.

She said, “It’s the condition you’ll manufacture. Fear. You like it. You like it, so you manifest it. You want to be afraid because it’s exciting. *I* excite you.”

“Yeah. You do,” he admitted, unsmiling.

Her eyes teared up, not from sorrow, but from unalloyed love. Abounding, overwhelming love for the man she married. For the man who stood with her now, naked in more ways than one. She kissed his dripping chin. Josh was as fucked up as she was; as dark.

“I never knew I could excite a man as much as I excite you,” she said. “I *want* to excite you. I *want* to make you crazy.” Her hands cupped his face, thumbs brushing his cheeks. “I hated when I scared you away. It was the hardest thing I’ve endured in my life. Don’t hate me. Just love me. Love me and let me scare you. Just for the thrill.”

“You like it, don’t you? You like it that way.”

She bit her lower lip, showing him an expression of great wounding. He held her, and she didn’t budge.

“I promise I’ll never hurt you, not for real,” she whispered, her forehead resting against his, their eyes locked. “I’ll never do that again.”

Josh closed his. “You planned that video?”

She held her breath for a second, then let it out. “I . . . put him where I wanted him. I would have done terrible things to him if you asked me to. I was only getting started.” She smiled, bowed her brows, ready to claim she was only joking, but Josh believed her and didn’t recoil.

“I planned all of it,” she said. “I wanted him to say those things. I *lied* to him. I told him every dark, gross thing he wanted to hear. Colleen is *yours*,

Josh. I had to tell him that to make it work. You know that.”

Josh stood rigid, water cascading off his shoulders. Her hands cupped his face, guiding him to meet her gaze. “Josh, you know Colleen is yours. You know it.”

“I *know*,” he said. “I know why you made that video. I understand. I know Colleen’s mine.”

“She is. She’s *your* daughter, Josh. *Your* little girl.”

There was a heavy unsaid in the air, a dread zeppelin, and better left unsaid: *Yes, when I made the video, when I filmed Devlin in my panties, I didn’t know whose baby I carried.*

Josh said, “Did you. . . did you enjoy it? Watching the video again.”

“You know I like it. You don’t even have to ask me that—it was obvious. But do you know why? It’s not just what you see on the video. What we watched is just a part of it. You know how I *feel*. None of it has any meaning without you. If there were no you, there would be no video, and there would be no affair—there would have been no *chance* I would give Devlin Stone a minute of my time.”

Josh’s mouth squirmed, his brow troubled. Though he always seemed like he understood the truth, he sometimes wanted it not to be true. Whether it was part of Josh’s kink, or simple denial, she didn’t know for sure. The denial only served to remove his responsibility, but she was sure he saw what she’d explained. They needed each other in a way that would guarantee their future.

Her hands slipped up his arms and held them under his shoulders, getting his eyes to meet hers. She said, “I gave you everything you needed to destroy me. I ruined you. I know I destroyed you, Josh, but I also know you had every reason and all the ammunition to end me in return, to seek righteous vengeance, and you didn’t do it. I wanted you back more than anything. You’re here because you love me. If you didn’t, you would’ve done the right thing and told anyone who would listen about the evil your

wife performed. And if they were unsure, you could *prove* it. But you waited. You gave me what I needed to make things right. The space, the time. The time to show you how much you mean to me and how much I need you in my life. You had the evidence, you knew my crimes, you knew how to hurt me. How to destroy me. But you didn't."

She levered off the shower behind his back, stepped out, and held a towel for him. Josh came out, and she wrapped him in it.

With the towel around his shoulders, hair hanging wet on his brow, Josh's smile returned. Not big and showy, a smile that portrayed something more like surrender. He said, "I really do love you. I *still* love you."

"I know you do," she said, touching his jaw. "I hope you know how much love I have for you, too."

Josh went to the bedroom, and she went to the closet with a towel on her head, wet hair wound in it. She dressed in satin pajamas; she rubbed lotion on her face and hands and forearms. Josh's eyes watched her every move from the bed.

She closed the closet door and entered the bedroom. "I'm going to get Colleen," she said.

Josh's face brightened, and he whispered encouragement to hurry up already. She laughed and moved to the door, paused there, hand resting on the knob's cool metal. She opened it wider, eyes rolling up, regarding the frame, closing it, returning it to how she found it, then opening it again. Her lips slimmed, and she shook her head in a silent admonishment.

She turned, shoulder pressing the doorframe, eyes finding Josh, Josh sitting upright in bed, back against the headboard. His gentle hands smoothed out the fresh sheets around him, hair damp, face flushed from the shower. But his eyes were bright, eager.

There was no greater gift to give her daughter than Josh as her father.

She smiled, and Josh looked up, eyes meeting hers, and he smiled in return.

“I’ll be right back,” she said.

A few steps down the hall, she paused outside Hyun’s door, knocked lightly, but heard no response. She pressed her ear to the door. Silence. She opened the door into a dark room, curtains drawn, light filtering in from the hallway, casting a long, thin rectangle across the floor. She slipped inside, eyes adjusting to the dim. Hyun’s room was sparse, the only furniture a bed, a dresser, and a small desk piled in disarray with textbooks, and the laptop she’d bought her, closed now for the night. Hyun’s backpack lay on the floor. The bed was a mess of tangled sheets and blankets, a lump huddled in the middle. Hyun’s shape rounded up the covers, her slight frame curled into a tight ball. She faced the wall, her back to Kimmy, dark hair fanned across the pillow.

She slunk across the room, slippered feet silent on the wooden floor. The silhouette of Colleen’s crib showed from the soft amber nightlight plugged low, near the floor.

Chapter 26

Aegis

The hall light silhouetted Kimmy, returning to the bedroom with Colleen in her long arms. She paused bedside, eyes dark and unreadable, holding his gaze for a moment before she leaned forward, transferring Colleen into his eager clutch. Colleen stirred, tiny fingers curling and uncurling, but didn't wake. Her pouted mouth, with the pronounced Cupid's bow and the gentle curl of her beautiful mother's lips, babbled soft and sleepy sounds.

Josh chuckled, holding her to his chest. "She's talking in her sleep," he murmured, finger-brushing Colleen's delicate cheek. Love and adoration surged; a powerful wave rendering him breathless for many heartbeats. He pressed a gentle kiss to Colleen's forehead, inhaling her sweet baby scent, kick-starting his sinus rhythm back into action.

Kimmy sat on the bed next to them, her hip pressing against Josh's, her arm brushing his. She leaned in, eyes on Colleen. "She had a busy day," she said, reaching out to smooth a tuft of dark hair on Colleen's head.

Ten minutes ago, they'd watched a video of Kimmy and Devlin, Kimmy jerking off Devlin's donkey dick, his wife manipulating a man he hated into saying ridiculous things, uttering the most pathetic sexualized drivel; stuff bubbling up from the mire of Devlin's own sick fantasies. An avowal, a confession, coaxed to the surface by Kimmy's skillful hand and wicked

promises. Done the way she'd done to her kind Josh so many times while she tormented him with her fidelity's endless conjecture and stroking his dick like it was a tuning fork and she sought the perfect pitch. Was she cheating? Was she lying? Was she only teasing? But he'd watched her do it to Devlin, wielding her astounding wiles to corral Devlin's wild horse into a grazing paddock and telling her timid husband the wild stallion who frightened him was tame now. *Go on, Josh, don't be afraid of him. He'll eat a sugar cube right from your hand.* He saw it clearly: Kimmy humiliated Devlin in that video. Kimmy broke him like a wild horse everyone else on the ranch swore no one would ever break.

How far would she have gone with Devlin's torment if her endeavor hadn't crumbled the way it did?

Kimmy ran her fingers through his damp hair, and her touch startled him, pulling him out of the darkness again. But her touch was welcome and bolstered him with the strangest sense of safety. He leaned into her touch, with his baby nestled on his chest.

Here, in this way, in this place, he could never feel safer. Alone in the warm bedroom he shared with his wife; a transgressive woman who'd pulled back on the yoke before it was too late and their marriage plummeted into the ground and ruined the whole airshow for everyone. A woman who'd earned his return. And Colleen: his child and new reason for being.

And while he was safe, he could play with fear and angst and dread; hone a sharper edge to his secret sexual blade. Oil it and care for it and preserve it. No more danger. Not for real. Kimmy served as his hidden stash of masturbatory material; his beautiful wife held more secrets under lock and key and ready to serve as his reward for being a good husband. There were more videos. More tales to tell. The more truthful, the better.

And there was no way she'd begin with the best video. He knew her too well. There were raunchier ones. And the one she'd begun with had

devastated his heart and psyche with a precise hit and brought him an explosive orgasm wound around a distinct existential terror.

In the end, somehow he'd won against his bully. His wife had destroyed Devlin, and he'd said what needed to be said, saying it with a chair hurtled from the overhead position.

Colleen's eyes fluttered in dream. A profound sense of love and protectiveness surged. This precious thing depended on him. He pressed another soft kiss to Colleen's forehead. "I won't let you down, beautiful," he whispered. "I'll be the father you deserve."

Kimmy still ran her nails over his scalp, massaging his head, admiring him with their baby, soft-breathing and head cocked. Then she slipped off the bed, going to the stand in the closet and pumping a dollop more of lotion into a palm, running greased hands on her forearms and cheekbones. She asked him if he'd like a glass of water or anything and he told her he didn't.

"I think I'm going to make a cup of tea," she said to her reflection in the small closet mirror. "The sleepy-time kind. Do you want some?"

"No, thanks."

She returned bedside, then leaned down, pressing a kiss to Josh's forehead. "I'll be right back, okay? Don't fall asleep with her yet."

"No promises," he said. There was no stronger salve after what she'd shown him tonight than to lie in total peace and safety this way. His heart beat strong and steady, and he could fall asleep with no warning right now.

Kimmy crossed the room, pausing at the laundry hamper. She pulled the towel from her hair, the damp tendrils clinging to her neck and shoulders. She rubbed at her hair with the towel one more time, then tossed it into the hamper. She hefted the basket onto her hip and slipped out of the bedroom.

* * *

This time, Kimmy didn't knock on Hyun's door, just turned the knob and slipped inside, laundry hamper on her hip. She set it down by Hyun's desk. Hyun didn't stir, her form motionless under the blankets.

"I know you're not sleeping."

Hyun still made no response, and she stepped closer to the bed. Hyun didn't react, didn't even flinch; a silent, unmoving lump.

"Hyun," she said, her voice above a whisper now. "I know you're awake." She sat on the bed beside Hyun. "It's immature to ignore me." She gave Hyun a moment to say something, but Hyun didn't. "The door was ajar, Hyun. My bedroom door. It was open more than how I left it." No answer again, but this time she pitched forward, looming over Hyun's body, speaking toward where Hyun's hair spilled out over the pillow. "I hope you weren't spying on us." Kimmy sat upright again. She crossed a leg over the other and adjusted her satin robe at the thigh. She said, "Colleen's his daughter."

Finally, Hyun muttered, voice muffled by the blanket. "I know."

Kimmy looked around the sparse room, at the desk where Hyun had done her homework tonight, caring for Colleen while Josh spent intimate time with her. She said, "That room's not your room anymore."

Hyun shifted under the blanket, and snuffled a sound of irritation, like Kimmy disturbed her sleep. Kimmy licked her lower lip, watching the hump of bedding change shape, then settle again, Hyun still facing away toward the window.

"Josh deserves to be with her. To know her."

Almost exasperated, Hyun said, "I was the one who said that first."

The room was silent for a long moment—longer if she weren't pressed for time—the only sound the subterranean hum of the furnace. She leaned in, her mouth close to Hyun's ear, hidden under the blanket. "What did you see?"

Hyun grunted and curled tighter under the bedding.

“Did you watch us?”

Hyun didn't answer, stayed still and unflinching.

“Did you watch me with my husband?”

Hyun muttered a sound like no, and Kimmy said, “I think you watched us. So tell me: what did you see?”

Hyun muttered how she'd seen nothing, and now Kimmy asked her, “Did you like what you saw?”

Hyun sighed under the blanket, then at last pulled it down a smidge, enough to see her cheekbone and her eye peering off at the window. It took a long beat, but Hyun said, “No.”

Kimmy sighed, rubbed her knee, returned her gaze to Hyun's back. She whispered, “Did you touch yourself when you watched us together?”

When Hyun didn't answer, this time Kimmy leaned over Hyun's body, trying to catch Hyun's eye. Hyun wouldn't look at her, eyes moonlit and blank, looking at the window.

“Touch yourself now,” she said.

Hyun stiffened, her head angled closer before turning away again, putting her face into the pillow.

Kimmy said, “I want you to touch yourself. Roll on your front, get on your knees and your chin, and put a hand down your pajamas.”

Hyun arched her back and turned her face away, right into the pillow, reminiscent of a reluctant child going to the limit of their mother's patience in the smallest form of defiance. Kimmy liked to think Hyun rolled her eyes. The thought had the corner of her mouth twitch into the early stage of a smile.

But soon the arched back relaxed and circled to align with her face, under the blanket, complying and turning to get on her belly. Kimmy waited and Hyun drew up her knees and planted her chin on the pillow. The sheets moved with the blanket, wafting the same scent of the fresh sheets she'd

just dressed her bed with Josh. Kimmy said, “Higher on your knees. Move up your rump.”

The hump changed shape, rounding out, Hyun getting higher on her knees, and yes, sticking up her rump. She listened to the sound of Hyun’s skin sliding on cotton, pictured Hyun’s perfectly clean, perfectly manicured fingers sliding over her flawless skin, over that soft tummy and then down lower, under the waistband of the cotton pajamas she’d bought Hyun when they went to Quebec City in July.

Hyun’s breaths came heavier, slower, but with a wonderful heaving from arousal. The curve of her rump began to roll with the undulation of a woman’s hips as she entered the igniting pleasure of ecstasy.

“Are you touching yourself?”

The answer to this question was obvious, but Hyun’s muffled groan confirmed the supposition.

Now Kimmy said, “Let me hear it.”

Hyun gasped the most exquisite sound of sexual suffering, and Kimmy’s already sore and exhausted nipples swelled hard all over again. And she indulged the urge to tighten her thighs and core, feeling the trickle of renewed excitement—this when she’d thought she’d wrung from this evening all she could. Nothing was ever enough, it would seem.

Now she leaned a little closer and whispered to Hyun, “Let me hear that tight little pussy.”

Hyun made a sound of disgust in her throat and writhed away from Kimmy’s voice, but Kimmy smiled, knowing Hyun liked nothing more than hearing the grossest vulgarities and total disrespect for that beautiful little split between those soft thighs.

“I want to hear it,” she urged again, and Hyun rewarded her with the softest little gasp into the bedding and the sudden arrival of the wet and sticky sound of those fingers strumming over that sexy hot flesh.

“I love that sound,” she whispered, flexing her own thighs and rump right now, feeling an indescribable baking heat. “Make it louder for me.”

Hyun’s breaths sped up, and Kimmy watched the bedding roll up and down, quicker and quicker, and Hyun’s gasps came with the quietest whine that tightened Kimmy’s chest with such intense adoration she ached for her sweet subject in a way she could never describe. The physical manifestation brought her hand over her heart.

The sound of well-lubricated sex flesh came to her now from beneath the bedding, the wettest sound imaginable. The image of combining her flesh with Hyun’s seized her. The ease with which she could slip under the blankets and show Hyun how annoyed she was teased her with its glorious proximity.

She looked over her shoulder, a little confirmation the bedroom door was closed and Josh was excluded. She told Hyun to “Pat it, pat it for me.”

Hyun whimpered, and the wet sound stopped for a beat, replaced now by the sound of Hyun’s pretty fingers tapping her swollen labia. Kimmy told her now, “Put two fingers inside, okay?”

The sounds stopped, and the humped crest rose as Hyun slid fingers inside her pussy, her breaths coming faster, tightened with lust now.

“You’re gushing, Hyun. Can’t you hear it?”

Hyun whimpered again, then bit down on the sound, still fingering herself.

“You’re gushing like that and you’re telling me you didn’t watch? Don’t lie to me.”

Chapter 27

Here We May Reign Secure

The rhythm of the undulating bedding-hump ignited an unsettling passion. She touched her neck and licked her lower lip. Hyun fingered herself, her hips rolling up and down and around. And the *sound*.

She said to the hump, “Are you a voyeur? A little peeping Tom, getting off on other people and the things they do in secret?” This particular line of interrogation would sometimes reduce Hyun to a curled and quivering jelly-hatchling. Hyun’s breath hitched, and the frenzied hip-rolling under the covers accelerated.

“You’re a little mouse, Hyun. Scurrying around in the dark, trying to steal pleasure-crumbs for yourself.”

Hyun’s breaths came in shorter gasps now, her body tensing like she neared climax. Kimmy leaned in even closer, her voice barely a whisper. “You’re just a plaything, Hyun. A little toy to use. Come for me, little toy. Show me how much you like being used.”

Hyun’s body convulsed, the pillow muffled an agonized cry.

But they weren’t done yet. That wasn’t the real orgasm.

“Did you see Josh and me?”

Hyun’s breath hitched again, and the hip-rolling faltered for a moment before resuming.

Kimmy leaned in, murmuring, “I know you were watching, Hyun. Did you enjoy seeing us like that? Did you enjoy seeing me with my husband?”

Hyun whimpered, her rump lifting high.

“Did you like what you saw when you watched us? Did it excite you?”

Hyun scrunched up her features and shook her head no.

Kimmy’s eyes narrowed, not in anger, but in intense focus. “Did it thrill you, watching us together? Did it make you feel something you shouldn’t?”

This time Hyun didn’t answer, her movement slowing, a sound in her throat others would call agony.

“Are you feeling something you shouldn’t?”

Hyun agreed through the sniveling communication of twisted and agonized human suffering, and now Kimmy changed gears, the awful traction of her words biting into hot, lurid soil. “I want you to suck Josh’s dick. What if I wanted to watch that? Would you suck his dick for me?”

More anguished cries into the pillow. This was Hyun’s greatest fear.

“I’d like to see your perfect little mouth suck him off.” She leaned in closer, sending breath over Hyun’s ear, her words a seductive purr. “I want him to come in your mouth, Hyun. I want you to swallow every last drop. Would you do that for me? Open your mouth for me, show me your little tongue.” She reached out, one finger tracing the upper curve of Hyun’s mouth. “Come on, Hyun. Show me. Let me see that little tongue of yours. Let me see how you’d suck him off.”

She peered over Hyun’s shoulder, watching her face, pulling back the edge of the blanket so she could see Hyun’s mouth better. Her mouth was open, the lips parted as she gasped. Hyun knew Kimmy watched, and soon her reluctant little tongue appeared, slick and small and so pink and shimmering.

“That’s it,” Kimmy sighed, biting her lips a moment and riding a swell of her own lust. “Suck your thumb for me. Show me that pretty little mouth of yours all pouted and wet.”

Hyun's body tensed, her breath hitching at the unexpected request. She remained still under the blanket, her face turned away from Kimmy.

"Come on, Hyun. Show me. Let me see you suck your thumb like a good girl."

Hyun hesitated for a moment. She turned her head, putting her face toward the side of the bed where Kimmy sat. She couldn't meet Kimmy's gaze, keeping her eyes narrowed. Her hand emerged from under the blanket, her thumb tentatively approaching her mouth.

"That's it, Hyun. Now open that pretty little mouth and suck. Show me how you'd suck Josh's dick for me."

Hyun's lips parted, and her thumb slipped into her mouth. Kimmy imagined it as Josh's dick, and the horror Josh would endure having his cousin's ex-wife suck his cock. Hyun began to suckle on her thumb. Hyun was the darkest of treasures.

"That's it, Hyun. Just like that. You're such a good girl for me. Now imagine it's Josh's cock in your mouth. Would you suck it just like that? Would you make him come in your pretty little mouth?"

Hyun's eyes squeezed closed, brow furrowing, body squirming under the blanket while she sucked her thumb and fingered herself. She whimpered and shook her head no again, her thumb still moving in and out of her mouth, her breaths coming faster.

"Open your eyes, Hyun. Look at me while you suck that thumb. Imagine it's Josh's cock in your mouth, his cum shooting into your throat. He would come *so* fast for you. It wouldn't take long. Would you swallow it all for me, Hyun? Would you be a good girl and take every last drop?"

Hyun's eyes opened, her dark gaze locked onto Kimmy's face. She nodded this time, eyes warbling with such exquisite pleading. *I don't want to suck Josh's cock. Please, don't make me.*

Kimmy smiled, saying in a low, sultry purr, "That's my good girl, Hyun. Now keep sucking. Show me how much you want to please me, how much

you want to please Josh. Show me how much you want to be our little slut, our little plaything. Show me, Hyun. Show me everything.”

This horrified Hyun and her eyes widened into unambiguous terror. But she fingered herself harder and faster. The squelching of her little digits in her pussy seemed so loud she worried Josh would hear it all the way in the master bedroom and come to investigate. Hyun had to stop sucking her slippery thumb so she could gasp for breath around it.

“When I’m not here, I want you to tease Josh, make him want you, make him want to fuck you. Wear those little shorts I like, you know the ones, nothing underneath, and he can see just enough of that nice little pussy that drives me crazy, and all Josh can think of is bending you over the couch and fucking you so hard.”

This was something Hyun would *never* do, and thus, it was rocket fuel to her tormented sexual psyche.

She leaned closer to Hyun, whispering now the big secret: “I showed Josh the video, Hyun. The one where I stroke Devlin.”

Hyun grunted, her hips rolling faster, the blanket a tumultuous sea. “I hate that video,” she groaned, her voice thick with both pleasure and unambiguous disdain.

“You love it, Hyun. You love watching me with him.”

“I hate it,” Hyun insisted, her voice a desperate whine. “He’s so gross, Kimmy.”

There was nothing more exquisite than hearing Hyun utter her name when she was tormented this way. Hyun battled between revulsion and desire. It was a battle they both knew pretty well, a game they played in the dark. She leaned in closer, her voice a sultry purr. “But you’re watching it, aren’t you, Hyun? You’re right there on the edge, imagining it’s you I’m touching, you I’m pleasing, my hand slipping down the front of your pajamas.”

Hyun grunted, her whole body tightening, squeezing out this beautiful utterance as the orgasm triggered: “He’s the devil.”

Hyun’s body seized for a long moment, then convulsed under the blanket. Her ass rode up and down in stomach-squashing pleasure. She couldn’t see much, but she didn’t need to. She reached down at the foot of the bed, gripping the edge of the blanket, pulled it up, revealing Hyun’s small, perfect feet. Her toes were scrunched, the nails painted in the oyster shell she’d picked for her at the salon. She grinned, her eyes never leaving Hyun’s feet as they curled and uncurled, the toes wiggling as Hyun rode out the waves of her orgasm.

Hyun’s eyes fluttered open a moment, then squinched shut in mortification.

“Good girl,” Kimmy cooed, a finger tracing the arch of Hyun’s foot. Hyun shivered at the touch, her body still sensitive from her orgasm, and her feet pulled away under the safety of the blanket once more.

“Devlin is nothing,” she whispered, sitting upright again. “A big dick and no—”

“I hate it when you say that,” Hyun said, expression harrowed and worn out.

Kimmy smiled. “I know. I know you do.”

Hyun swallowed, her mouth worked around, some thought coalescing. She said, “You touched me.”

“Your foot? I suppose I did.”

The rules were clear: they wouldn’t touch each other unless Josh was out of the province. Not just the house, not just the town. He had to get on a plane and land somewhere else before she’d suck Hyun’s delicate nipples, before she’d do any of Hyun’s favorite tongue-related tasks.

They wouldn’t even kiss.

But she’d touched Hyun’s sole without thinking, the urge compelling her, and that was the way it would be. She stood now, moving to the door.

“You’re going?” Hyun sat up a little, swiping the tangled hair from her face.

Kimmy lifted the laundry basket and returned. “Will you sleep with these?”

Hyun’s brow crinkled, and she peered into the basket.

“I changed the sheets after we made love. I want you to sleep with them.”

Hyun’s lip twitched. “Will you kiss me?”

“I can put them in the laundry,” she said, resigned, as if she were ready to leave.

“I’ll sleep with them.”

Kimmy upended the basket, and Hyun pulled out the sheets onto her bed. With one more hopeful plea, Hyun said, “Would you touch me?”

“He’ll smell me on you.”

Hyun pleaded one more time: “But you’re mine.”

Kimmy smiled, stayed standing above Hyun, and remained that way for a long, tense moment. Then she said, “Good night, Hyun.” A long pause, a warm smile. “I love you.”

“I love you, too,” Hyun whispered, settled for now, and as Kimmy left the basket at the door and went to leave, she wished Hyun good night once more, Hyun hugging the sex-dirtied sheets, pulling them under the blanket with her.

* * *

The dream began as though he was waking.

Josh stirred from a deep sleep, Colleen’s gentle warmth on his chest. Her small breaths steadied his restless mind. A soft glow from the bedside lamp cast shadows on the walls. The faint rustle of fabric and the clinking of a cup reminded him where he was. He blinked away the sleep still

clinging to him like a hot blanket, and his eyes adjusted to find Kimmy standing bedside, drying hair on her shoulders, a mug of tea cradled in her hands.

Josh smiled sleepily. "Hey," he murmured, voice hoarse but softened with affection.

Kimmy set the cup down on the nightstand before kneeling beside him. "I didn't mean to wake you," she whispered, brushing her fingers against Colleen's cheek, her expression softening. "But I missed you both."

He adjusted his hold on Colleen, sitting more upright. "I fell asleep while watching her," he said. "She's *so* peaceful."

"I love seeing you with her," she said. "You're such a wonderful dad." She cupped his cheek, her hand hot from the tea mug. "I'm so lucky to have you back in my life, Josh. I'm so lucky to have both of you."

A wave of warmth enveloped him, and he pulled Kimmy into bed, wrapping an arm around her while still holding Colleen. "I never imagined we could be here again," he said. "But look at us."

"It's like a dream," Kimmy said, nestling her head against his shoulder.

In that moment, nestled in the dim light of their shared space, everything felt right. In place. He gazed at Colleen, the miracle they'd created, and then at Kimmy, the woman whose love had always been a desperate need, now in his bed. That bleak and lonesome motorcycle trek felt further away than it should. Distant.

He might have doubted their future before, but lying with his two ladies this way, there was a new beginning, a clear path ahead, one filled with endless potential.

"I love you," he said.

"I love you, too," she replied, looking into his eyes, pure sincerity illuminating the future.

With Colleen between them, the three of them protected from the world outside, he saw how this was all he'd ever wanted. A sense of belonging, of

purpose.

He couldn't wait for tomorrow. Or the next day after that.

Chapter 28

What Though the Field Be Lost?

In the bright Saturday morning light, dread's cold hand stroked sickly fingers down his chest to wake him. There was that endless feeling: one of sinking. One of cold, unthinking waters, of borderless blue nothing. It was the returned fear of having something of great value he could lose.

He bolted upright in bed, arms thrashing the bedding, looking for his baby. Looking for Colleen. The bed was empty. The crib was empty. Lonely hopelessness seized him.

But he had only slept in. The sun was bright. The clock told him it was almost 10:30. Once he washed his face, brushed his teeth, and put on some clothes, that awfulness withered, and faint hope began to bloom in the waking dread's muck.

Downstairs, he arrived to the smell of savory cooking—like old times. Gone were those days of comfort in their modest Ajax apartment, but now he and Kimmy were renewed and reinvigorated. It was like he'd flashed forward in time and he and Kimmy had everything they'd ever wanted. They had sold their souls to the devil to get here—but here they were.

Only it wasn't Kimmy cooking in the kitchen; it was Hyun.

He wished her a good morning, and she returned the greeting—a lot cheerier than he'd usually seen Hyun since his return. He wished there was

a way to reassure her that she was welcome without coming right out and saying it; it could sound insincere. Something would occur to him.

Hyun was at the stove with her back to him, using chopsticks to submerge a thin, quivering slice of red meat into a batter. There was a steaming wok on the burner, cutting boards with chopped vegetables, a colander suspending hot noodles, and more—a serious production. She wore a cotton apron with a pale floral pattern. Over her shoulder, she said, “Brunch is almost ready. Go say hi to Colleen; she’s in the sitting room. I’m almost done here.”

He asked, “What’s the special occasion?”

But before she could answer, Kimmy appeared on his left, coming in from the sitting room at the back of the house. She held a bright-eyed bundle against her chest—his baby daughter, gurgling with delight at seeing him. Colleen reached out her grabbing little hand, laughing. Kimmy bounced at the knees with Colleen, whispering to her, “There he is! Is that who you were looking for?” Colleen giggled and uttered a bubbly vowel sound, still reaching for him.

Kimmy passed Colleen over, and he held her, heart bursting at the sheer delight of her happy laughter. As he bounced with her and made the noises she liked, Kimmy traced the beginning tuft-curl from Colleen’s brow, saying, “She heard your voice in the kitchen and wanted to see you.”

With breathy disbelief: “She recognized my voice?” He practically swooned.

Kimmy went around the island to join Hyun, and Josh sat on one of the tall stools, holding a robust and active Colleen. She had a lot to say this morning, and he listened, telling her a few things as well, much to Colleen’s enjoyment. Colleen’s mother looked incredible from the back as she helped Hyun in the brunch’s final stages.

It used to be, on a morning like this one, Kimmy would bum around in sweats and whimsical slippers. Kimmy looked good as an adult woman

now—a grown-up, a mother. Tall, long legs, slim; she wore casual pants and a thin belt, a light black sweater tucked in, and elegant black house slippers. Her glossy hair hung down her narrow back like black silk. Everything around him was different, and yet it was all the same.

When it was time to eat, Josh put Colleen in her high chair and set her next to him, with Kimmy on the other side. Hyun sat catty-corner to Kimmy, the two of them touching elbows, once Hyun had served the dishes and platters onto the island. He asked, “Do you cook like this all the time?”

Kimmy looked at him and smiled, saying, “Sometimes we like to do it on the weekends. It’s nice.” Hyun and Kimmy shared a look.

Josh said, “It is nice. Thanks so much, Hyun. This is so much work.”

“We usually wait till Sophie’s here—this is her new favorite.”

He asked her what they were having and Kimmy explained, “Hyun makes the best *jeong*—these pancakes. Some have beef and some have shrimp. Sophie *loves* the shrimp; Josh, you’ll like the beef. There’s *japchae* here, that’s the glass noddles. And you can dip the pancakes in the vinegar sauce here. I made the sauce.”

“I can’t believe Sophie’s not here to enjoy this,” Hyun said, her voice tinged with a hint of sadness. “She loves my pancakes.”

Kimmy leaned against Hyun, nudging her playfully. “She’ll be back this week. Maybe she’ll stay with us full time one day.”

Hyun almost smiled, but it failed to launch. “Maybe.”

“Right,” Josh said, dipping a small beef *japchae* in the sauce Kimmy made. “Maybe we’ll move Meyer into the garage, turn this place into a family compound.” He popped the pancake in his mouth, laughing to himself about Meyer huddled up in the garage, peering out the window and watching cousin Josh in the big house with everyone else. Hyun didn’t see the humor, still glum. He said, “Hyun, this pancake is amazing, I mean it.

Oh, my god, that's the best." He loaded a shrimp one onto his plate to try next, see why Sophie liked them better.

Kimmy said, "No, but maybe we should do something, all of us together."

"With Meyer?"

"No, the four of us here. And Sophie."

He said, "What do you mean, like travel?"

"Yeah, sure. We could take a vacation."

Hyun said, "Maybe in the summer. I'll be off school."

"Sure," Kimmy said, sipping a tea. "Or maybe at Christmas. What do you think, Josh?"

"What do I think? Yeah, sure. Why not? That sounds great. Where? Can you fly with a baby?" He got his face close to Colleen's, their noses touching, and Colleen babbled and laughed and holy fuck was he in love with her. She batted his cheek with a tiny fist.

Hyun said, "Of course, you can fly with a baby."

He said, "Can *I* fly with a baby? I don't want everyone looking at me *because* I'm flying with a baby. Not that Colleen's a big crier, but you never know, you get her up to 5,000 feet and she might start hollering."

Kimmy said, "We can think of something."

"Somewhere warm," Hyun said.

"Shoot," he said, putting down his chopsticks, sitting back.

"What is it?"

"I think I'm supposed to be in Rome in December some time. I'll have to check my calendar."

Hyun said, "We can make it summer. Go to Rome, and we'll—"

"Well, he *has* to go to Rome," Kimmy said, putting a hand over Hyun's. "If it's for work."

Hyun nodded, smiling. "I know. I mean we don't have to squeeze a vacation in. How long are you going to be in Rome?"

“Two weeks.”

“Wow,” Hyun said, and put a bite of the shrimp *jeong* in her mouth. “Two weeks. That’s good.”

* * *

They walked from their beautiful home, along the charming Unionville main street lined with quirky shops and good restaurants, the paths in brick, the lamp posts styled like they burned whale oil, out to the park and along the path around Toogood Pond. Josh pushed Colleen in a stroller, and she walked with her hands in her pockets, a plaid shawl of Scottish wool over her chest and shoulders. The sun shone from high, and a light breeze rustled the leaves beginning to show bright swatches of yellow and orange. Change could be beautiful.

Josh leaned closer to the pram, voice animated with soft fatherly love as he pointed out a gaggle of Canada geese waddling along the pond’s edge. “Look, Colleen, look at the geese,” he said, finger tracing the line of birds. “*Canada* geese. They’re getting ready for migration. They’ll fly further south when it gets colder. They like open water.”

Stark change had swept into their lives with stormy force, and she’d somehow brought their plane down to safety. A moment like this one arrived in unreal glory—almost undeserved.

A pair of mallards glided across the pond’s surface, reflections shimmering in the gentle ripples.

“See those ducks?” Josh continued. “They’ll stick around longer than the geese. They like it here. These big guys, these geese? They don’t like the winter. I don’t really like it either,” he added in low-voiced father-daughter confessional.

She stooped as well, she and Josh on either side of Colleen. “But eventually those little duckies will go, too.”

Josh wore an easy smile, eyes wandering from her and over to Colleen as he narrated tales of birds and their journeys. Neither of them knew jack about birds, but Josh knew what to say.

Seeing Josh with Colleen tugged a straight line from her heart and down through her viscera, billowing out with the concussive whump of a cataclysmic explosion, radiating outward in a fuel-rich and fiery cumulus cloud. Not lust, though it *was* sexual. Colleen needed a sibling. A sister. At least one, for sure.

“Other birds, not these water guys, but the ones you see in the trees”—Josh pointed out the tree canopy above and Colleen clapped hands and looked *almost* where he pointed—“some of them travel thousands of miles, like all the way to Mexico. That’s really, really far.”

“Josh,” she said, stopping him midway in migration talk. He turned toward her, curious.

“Yeah?”

He stood when she stood, and she circled the stroller to face him, her back to the pond and the ducks and the geese. Josh regarded her quizzically.

She said, “I know you’ll stay. I know you’ll stay for Colleen. I want you to stay for me, too.”

“I will,” he said, quicker than she anticipated—and almost bothered that she would speculate on such a thing.

“I think you will,” she said, nodding, continuing, “I want more. More of what we have. You’re perfect, Josh. You’re everything to me. Everything fits, everything is so good.”

“It is,” he said, assuring her, his eyes showing the first signs of emotional pinking.

“But I want more.”

Josh’s brow lowered, concerned, and she could measure the hurt in his expressive eyes.

She said, “More of what we already have.”

But her husband's reticent mind went deep down in the dark, down where only the devils played. She smiled with compassion but didn't acknowledge she knew went through his mind.

"Josh, I mean more of this," and wagged her head to the side, toward Colleen. Josh needed to appreciate all he had and stop obsessing over what he didn't. "More of us," she said.

Josh narrowed his eyes like he didn't understand.

She whispered, "I want more babies, Josh."

Josh's expression shifted from surprised confusion to unambiguous delight, but she quickly tempered that enthusiasm. "I might have a busy time ahead," she added, taking his reaching hands in her own. The thought of juggling another child was daunting; after all, they were still navigating the complexities of their current situation, and there was much she protected Josh from.

"I understand," he said.

"Sometime soon, but I'm not sure when."

Josh tried to onboard what she'd told him without exuberance, trying to show her a maturer version of himself, one not so heedless and agitated. He held her hands, and they stood by the edge of the pond in their new and idyllic town, their baby daughter in her pram at their side. The park was active, a lot of people out enjoying the sun and the fall colors and the pathways and shops. He said, "How busy do you think you'll be?"

Kimmy hesitated, reluctant to reveal too much. They'd come so far, yet the past's shadows still lingered. "We've got a lot on our plates with Colleen and everything else."

"Yeah," he replied, brows bunching as he processed her non-response.

"Did you bring that bread Hyun packed?" she asked.

He submitted to the subject change with an easy sigh, smiling even, going back to the pram's handlebar, reaching below and retrieving a paper sack Hyun had filled with torn pieces of bread. When he returned with it,

holding it at his sternum, the sight of him so paternal and dutiful filled her with soaring affection. She loved him, yes, but there was more than love. She embraced him, the bag crinkling between their chests.

“I’ve wished for a day like today for a year. You’re all I want, Josh. And I don’t even deserve you. You’re going to be the most incredible father. I’m blessed to have you.”

Josh tossed bits of bread toward the ducks, and the ducks honked and sped closer to the shore. Colleen’s eyes lit up with excitement, her little hands reaching out, fingers stretching as if she might grasp the feathery creatures. Josh laughed, and Colleen babbled louder, a stream of joyful sounds bubbling from her mouth as she leaned forward in her pram. They were a good duo.

Josh dipped closer to Colleen. “You want to say hi to the ducks, huh?” He offered another piece of bread, this time to Colleen, and Colleen took it and threw it about a half foot away and barely out of the pram. It had Kimmy laughing as well. Josh tossed a piece of bread in the direction Colleen had, his landing in the water and sending a thrashing of duck bodies in its direction. One lucky duck sped off while the rest waited to what else might be in store. Colleen squealed in delight.

As Josh tossed bits of bread to the mallards, they quacked and swim-waddled at the shore. She leaned against him as he continued to toss bread into the water. Colleen laughed and watched every bit of the action. The moment could have extended forever, but there was only so much bread in the bag Hyun had packed. When it was emptied, the show was over, and Josh and she watched Colleen try so hard to shape words and communicate with them. It was the finest moment she could have imagined to kiss Josh. It was unexpected but welcome, Josh rigid at first but soon relaxing. Colleen commented on this action as well. Their mouths came together, soft

and accommodating, and she kissed the man she loved and married. Josh was receptive, even commanding, but they were in public and the moment was meant to be brief. She stepped back.

He smiled, let the kiss linger on his lips, his eyes showing happiness. He asked her what she wanted to do next.

“I want to keep walking. There’s a bridge down there, and the path goes far before it comes back around.”

“Do you want to grab some coffees to bring along?”

“We’ll get them when we circle back.”

Josh said, “Okay. We can sit with Colleen and let all the luckiest townspeople have a peek at her.”

Distant from the pond, they stopped on an iron bridge and admired the view, the water coursing below them, the stream’s edges bloated with the recent rainfall and battering the swamped grassy shore.

When the time was right, she said, “Keith has political ambitions.”

Josh turned his attention to her, leaning an elbow on the railing. “That makes sense,” he said.

She regarded him. “It does?”

“Yeah,” he continued. “I guess that’s why you handled him so well. You know, over Devlin.”

She hummed a sound in her throat and looked down at the water again. “He didn’t need a scandal over his belligerent scion,” she admitted, shaking her head, dismissing the former situation.

Josh turned his back to the view and to Colleen, who’d fallen fast asleep, blanket-bundled in her stroller while the walk took them away from the pond’s town-side bustle and into a quieter, untamed piece of suburban wilderness. “What, so this guy wants to be Prime Minister?”

Kimmy shook her head. “No. It’s not like that. Keith’s not a politician. It’s just . . . if a few things fall into place like we want them, Keith’s in a short line to be finance minister.”

Josh’s brow wrinkled with the burden of trouble. “A lot of ifs,” he said. He looked down, contemplative. “That photo of you and him in the news, that was planted.”

Insightful. “He has a public relations person.”

He regarded her again. “And this person wanted you in the photo?”

“Yes. Not as his date, though. You know that.”

Josh sighed, but kept his composure. “As Devlin’s replacement. He wants *you* to run Stone.”

“God, *no*, Josh,” she said, restraining laughter. “He hardly knows me. I’ve been at Stone for a year.”

“But he likes you. Or believes in you or something.”

“I don’t know about that. He believes in my abilities.”

“Well, he should,” Josh said.

“My role will become more extensive over the coming months. Maybe years.”

“I understand what it will mean,” Josh said, jaw flexing, staring at the water rushing below. His mind worked overtime and she stood at his side.

Chapter 29

Of Man's First Disobedience, and the Fruit

There'd been six outrageous days in a row of perfect fall weather. Bright blue skies, crisp, cold air, and the sun shining bright. Might be the best colors of fall he'd seen in years. Unionville looked unreal.

But this afternoon he was downtown, right in the heart of it. Cars inched in traffic, their windows down, some good music playing, but far more bad. Most people were in happy moods, despite the construction holdups. He was sitting street-side, on Adelaide, down by the business heart of Toronto. There were only two tables outside the Much Love café, and he was lucky to get one. The honeylocust above the tables showed the yellow of the seasonal change, and once in a while one of its smaller leaflets would flutter down to the table and he'd flick it off to the sidewalk. The two sunglasses-wearing women at the other table now were arguing about the value of maintenance fees against how often the elevator was down in their building. A little less salacious than their last discussion, which was about another friend's husband "needing space," and he'd enjoyed their exercised litigation of the absent friend's life and all the things the friend could be doing better.

It was for the best, because now he could see a long, black car down toward the Church Street intersection, heading this way. He checked his

watch. It was ten to one. Perfect timing. There was a better story about to take place than the sunglass women's.

He'd booked the afternoon off, telling Harjeet he had a dentist appointment. He drove into the city with only a vague conception of what he would do.

For lunch, he'd had the grilled cheese on house-made *challah* bread and a Greek salad. He was down to his coffee and a plate of *choux* balls.

A big group of Bay Street guys were street-strutting and bantering with coffee cups—no jackets, sleeves rolled up, sunglasses on—and he eased his head to the side to keep track of the shining black car. A Mercedes or a Maybach or whatever. This had to be him.

The finance bros passed on, laughing, and Josh watched the car get closer, then pull over to the side, right where expected. Outside the restaurant.

The Cafoni Classici restaurant occupied the building across the street. It was an Old Town Toronto courthouse in sandstone, a three-story pavilion with a pedimented entrance, two pilasters flanking it. The modern neighborhood had grown up around it and dwarfed its structure and status, but it was still a fine and implacable building. The Gruppo Cafoni was a collection of restaurants, six in Toronto and now one in Los Angeles. Keith Stone had money in the group, Keith getting out of the black limo now and buttoning his suit jacket, looking around. Not even acknowledging the driver who'd come around to open the door for him.

Even if he didn't own a piece of the restaurants, this would be where an executive like Keith Stone would dine. A possible future Minister of Finance.

There was a time when Mom and Dad marched young and bullied Josh down to the Stone estate to tell Devlin's uber-rich father what his son was up to. Papa Stone didn't care. Dismissive asshole. When Josh and his parents went home that night, Mom broke a glass in the sink she was so

mad. “Fucking prick,” she’d called Keith Stone, and Mom never swore. Young Devlin Stone had always been on the path to full Fucking Prick status. And this was the man who’d set him on his way.

Keith was tall, and where Devlin was handsome, Keith Stone looked scary. Like if he wasn’t wearing a ten-thousand dollar suit, you wouldn’t want to encounter him in a dark alley. He’d been handsome once, probably, but he was in his late fifties now, and his face was lined and creased with the marks of an angry scowl. Big, strong build still, and massive hands. He wore his silvered hair back from his face. Wouldn’t want anything to shield his dark, predatory eyes.

Josh watched Keith trot up the old court steps and disappear inside the restaurant.

Fifteen minutes ago, he’d seen another actor in this affective theater trot up the same steps and disappear into the Cafoni Classici. That one had unbelievable legs. Long and strong, feet clad in expensive heels. She’d dressed all in black with a tight and ass-hugging mid-length skirt. Her jacket had been tailored to show her exquisite physique; the narrow waist, the long limbs, the elegance. Hair up, showing off the grace of her magnificent neck. An absolute ball-shrinking terror in her own right.

He’d watched her take a spot at a table framed in one of the courthouse windows, ten feet above the sidewalk. Like a theater’s stage.

And now she stood and received her lunch partner, the two of them coming close, the woman standing to greet him and offering a professional gesture to the seat across from her. On their best behavior in public.

They sat. The woman had already ordered drinks. She knew what the powerful man liked. The Honorable Minister Stone.

Stone lifted his menu, but his eyes stayed on his frighteningly gorgeous companion, Stone saying, “What did he say?” And Kimmy’s coy. She’s saying to Keith how she hasn’t asked him yet. Stone reminds her she told him she would. Kimmy’s urging Keith to be patient. She raises her chin,

regarding her new quarry, and she says to him, “I think he’s enthusiastic. And, I think, in time, we’ll get what we want.” Those sultry red lips issuing promises that would have Keith Stone on his knees. And Keith smiles, thinking of all the ungodly passion awaiting him.

Josh shifted with great perineal discomfort in his café chair and popped a *choux* ball in his mouth and watched and watched, and hot coals glowed in the ash, a new wind breathing fire into dormant coal.

* * *

Headlights brightened the bedroom, Hyun coming home from a night class, a few minutes before ten o’clock. Josh closed the bedroom door and went to the bathroom. Kimmy stood at the mirror, teeth brushed, rubbing face cream onto sharp cheekbones, the protuberances that showed when she hollowed her cheeks and raised her brows, staring into her own dark eyes. Her satin robe hung open, showing the skimpy underwear she wore and her flat tummy and the sweep of ribs drawing up to her topless chest. He floated tonight on contented waters and an easy cotton protected him from the world’s sharper edges.

They’d been alone tonight as a family. Father, mother, and daughter. They’d cooked dinner together in their beautiful home. After eating, they’d curled up on the couch and watched television. They had plans for the weekend and Sophie would be here soon. Maybe they’d have a movie night and make popcorn with real butter.

Kimmy was the same girl he’d fallen in love with when he was a boy. They were united. They were one. All the good of their life before eased back in gentle waves, each one washing a little higher on the beach, reclaiming the marks of former tides.

Right now, Colleen was in her crib. She’d had a good night with her mom and dad. Josh brushed his teeth and Kimmy left him to it. He joined

her again by the crib's side. Colleen lay on her front, angel face to the side, her back moving up and down with gentle breathing.

He said, "She sleeps so well."

"We keep her busy."

Which was true. "We do," he said, thinking of the scheduled activities Kimmy had organized on a sheet pinned in the kitchen. From play time and mirror time, music and movement, water time in a warm plastic tub. Colleen had three helpers in the house devoted to her development. He'd wanted to read a board out to her before bed tonight, but she'd conked out before he could.

"Soon we'll have her in the nursery overnight," Kimmy said. "I think it's past time, really."

Their little baby all alone. "We won't need Hyun to watch her when we want to be loud," he said and bumped a hip to Kimmy's, and she showed a white smile he hadn't seen in so long. It was a beautiful smile.

Kimmy snuffled a small laugh behind her hand and moved to the bedside. "Do you think we were loud the other night?"

He couldn't remember. "I think I might have been."

Kimmy chuckled again, and slipped off the silk robe, putting it on the chair by the bed, then slipping under the covers in only her underwear bottoms. He ached to feel her body heat. He joined her, leaving Colleen be, content in her own cottony brume of sleep, and slipped into bed with Kimmy, the sheets crisp and cool. Their bodies came together under the bedding, and they settled until the sheets warmed.

He said, "How was lunch with Stone?"

"It was good," she said. Then: "I wondered if you'd ask. It took you a while."

"I just remembered," he said, lying, slinking close to her, getting the heat radiating from her lean body and soft skin. He pressed against her, took

her in his arms, her back to his chest. Kimmy shimmied rearward, cozying herself to him. He said, “Stone’s closer to taking over the world?”

She giggled a soft, wonderful sound, like he was being silly, but also seeing the humor. “Things are going well for him.”

“Oh, I’m so glad to hear it,” he said drolly. Kimmy laughed again. She was playful tonight. He already knew she was when he’d seen her preparation for bed was only a pair of panties. He sighed and groaned as his arms circled her narrow body. She felt incredible. And she really was his. He wouldn’t deny it again. Kimmy sighed, too. Arching her back and craning her head forward on the pillow. He kissed the gentle knob of bone at the base of her neck. Kimmy’s breaths deepened. His cock hardened, and he pressed it into her ass cheek. Kimmy pushed back. He held her tighter.

“I saw you with him,” he said.

She stiffened a long moment, and he thought she was mad. She said, “You did?”

“I watched you. I watched you at the restaurant.”

The stiffness relaxed, but there was a sober silence for too long. He dipped his chin, traced his lips along her shoulder and up to her neck again. “In your slim skirt and your hair up—you looked so fucking hot.”

“Josh, you *have* to be kidding.”

One hand swept upward, the right hand cupping her small breast, finding her nipple hard on his palm. She moaned. His other hand eased down her tummy to the panty waistband. Her rump rolled against his hardness and squashed his balls. They writhed in slow increments, imitating copulation, his cock straining his briefs, hard and straight, pressed into his wife’s perfect ass.

Kimmy’s breaths came deep and tormented, and she writhed with him, reluctant yet somehow still eager.

She whispered something, but he couldn’t hear. He asked her to repeat it. She said, “If you want it, this time you’re going to have to *beg* me.”

A figurative spotlight shone on him and for a brief second he felt exposed or caught red-handed. His eyes widened with secret fear.

Their baby babbled a soft sound, then settled, and somewhere down the hall, Hyun's bedroom door opened then closed.

Kimmy would love it. Tormenting her husband. And tormenting her former lover. Tormenting Devlin Stone by fucking his domineering father. There was no way Devlin didn't have a daddy complex.

"I just wanted to see you with him," he said.

"You saw me eat lunch with my boss," she said. "Nothing more."

"You looked so fucking beautiful, Kimmy."

"Josh..."

His hand slipped under the panties and over her shorn mound, silky soft and smooth. His fingers slipped her crease and found her hot and wet and wanting penetration. He eased a finger inside her and Kimmy shuddered and gasped. Her hand came up and her long fingers wound through his hanging hair.

"It's only play, Kimmy."

"You *can't* ask me, Josh. You can't," she panted. "You'd have to get on your knees and *beg* me."

THE END

Afterword

As I close the last chapter of "Devil in the Waters," I'm gonna reflect on the incredible journey we've all shared over the past fifteen books.

Each character—Josh, Kimmy, Colleen, Hyun, Meyer, Devlin, et al.—has been a part of my life, as much as I hope they've been a part of yours. Their struggles, triumphs, and growth have mirrored not only the intricacies of love and family but also the complexities of every relationship out there. They are in an impossible union, but Josh and Kimmy love each other in unique ways I've never written before. It was the hard labor of writing (and your reading) that brought them to where I left them and I thank you for participating and keeping me going. Especially the supporters on my Patreon. I could not have done a story of this style and length without their incredible support.

So thank you for joining me on this voyage through the tumultuous waters of Josh and Kimmy's lives. Your support and wonderful enthusiasm drove me to tell their stories more honestly, even when the waters were rough and cold and the truths hard to dredge. I would love to have written a happier ending than the one here, but this is where the characters arrived. The truth is their story isn't over, and I don't think it ever will be. I could write another 15 books with ease.

Writing this series has been a labor of love, filled with moments of laughter, heartbreak, and healing. I'm a different person now than when I began this in 2019. I hope that, like me, you found facets of your own emotions within these pages even when things were at their most outrageous.

To those who have traveled with me from the beginning, your loyalty has been a beacon. To new readers who joined us along the way, thank you for embracing this world. You've all breathed life into these stories.

With heartfelt gratitude,

—KT

* * *

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